31 DEVOTIONALS ON THE BOOK OF REVELATION

Behind the Curtain

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How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Behind the Curtain
31 devotionals on the Book of Revelation

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/offb/en/

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DAY 1

The Alpha and the Omega – Who Is at the Helm of Your Life?

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 1:1–8

1 The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave him to show his servants what must soon take place. He made it known by sending it through his angel to his servant John, 2 who testified to the word of God and to the testimony of Jesus Christ – everything he saw. 3 Blessed is the one who reads aloud, and blessed are those who hear the words of the prophecy and keep what is written in it, for the time is near.

4 John, to the seven churches in the province of Asia: Grace to you and peace from him who is and who was and who is coming, and from the seven spirits who are before his throne, 5 and from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead and the ruler of the kings of the earth.

To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood
6 – and he made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father –
to him be the glory and the might for ever and ever. Amen.
7 Look, he is coming with the clouds,
and every eye will see him,
even those who pierced him,
and all the tribes of the earth will mourn over him.
Yes, amen.

8 "I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, who is and who was and who is coming, the Almighty.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a journey of thirty-one days through the book of **Revelation**. Many people see Revelation simply as a book about the end times, full of strange symbols. Yet it actually begins as a deeply personal pastoral letter. It opens with a breathtaking vision of the glorified Jesus Christ, followed by seven direct, loving but piercing letters to seven real churches in Asia Minor (chapters 1–3). After that the book leads us to the throne in heaven and the Lamb, through the seals, trumpets and bowls and the conflict with the dragon, all the way to the new heaven and the new earth. The very first word of the book, *apokalypsis*, means unveiling: the curtain is pulled back, and we are allowed to see what is happening behind the scenes.

Over the next **31 days** we will walk through the whole book together. We will not merely be looking at ancient history; we will allow the risen Lord to look, through his Word, into our own hearts, habits and faith.

To understand Revelation rightly, we first need to know where and why it was written. Most scholars date the book around AD 95, during the reign of the Roman emperor Domitian (some think of an earlier date, shortly after Nero's persecution). According to the Roman historian Suetonius, Domitian liked to be addressed as *Dominus et Deus* – "Lord and God". In the cities of Asia Minor (today's western Turkey) honouring the emperor was part of everyday life: temples, festivals and trade guilds paid him homage. For Christians who refused to burn incense before the emperor's image, this could mean social rejection, economic boycott, prison and even death. They were afraid and discouraged, and felt as if the mighty Roman Empire was about to swallow the church.

John himself is on the rocky island of Patmos, probably as an exile. And precisely there, in his isolation, God tears open the curtain of the visible world.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at a few key words from the original Greek that open up the depth of this introduction:

- **"Revelation" (*apokalypsis* – ἀποκάλυψις, v. 1):** The first word of the Greek text is *apokalypsis*. In today's language "apocalypse" makes us think of the end of the world and chaos. But in Greek it simply means "**the removing of a veil**" or "**unveiling**". This book was not written to hide God's plans behind difficult codes, but precisely to pull the veil aside so that believers can see who really sits on the throne. Notice too: it is the revelation *of* Jesus Christ – he is both the Giver and the Content of this vision.
- **"What must soon take place" (*ha dei genesthai en tachei* – ἃ δεῖ γενέσθαι ἐν τάχει, verse 1):** John takes up, almost word for word, Daniel 2:28, where Daniel tells Nebuchadnezzar that God has made known what must take place in the last days (so in the Greek translation of the Old Testament). John replaces "in the last days" with "soon": what was still far off for Daniel has begun with Christ. That is why verse 3 says, "for the time is near". For the seven churches this was no distant future but their own time – and because the whole time between Christ's first and second coming is the last days (Acts 2:17; Hebrews 1:2), every generation of believers lives in this "soon".
- **"Blessed" (*makarios* – μακάριος, v. 3):** Verse 3 contains the first of seven beatitudes in Revelation. The word *makarios* describes a deep, spiritual joy and well-being that does not depend on outward circumstances. This blessing is promised to the one who **reads aloud** (in those days one person read the scroll aloud in the congregation), to those who **hear** (listen attentively), and to those who **keep** (*tēreō* – τηρέω: live it out and hold on to it).
- **"The Alpha and the Omega" (to *Alpha kai to Ō* – τὸ Ἄλφα καὶ τὸ Ὦ, v. 8):** These are the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet. In Jewish thought people sometimes said that something stretched "from Aleph

to Tav" (the first and last Hebrew letters) to express completeness. God is saying: I wrote the first sentence of world history, I will write the final full stop, and I govern every letter and chapter in between.

- **"The Almighty" (*pantokratōr* – παντοκράτωρ, v. 8):** At the end of verse 8 stands the mighty title *pantokratōr* – the one who lays his hand on everything, the Ruler of all. In the Greek translation of the Old Testament this word often stands where the Hebrew says "the LORD of hosts". Domitian thought he ruled the world with his legions; against him stands the Almighty God, who holds past, present and future in his hand.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

These first eight verses give us three unshakeable theological anchors:

1. **Our identity rests on Christ's finished work, not on our circumstances.** Before John writes a single word about affliction or judgement, he reminds the churches who Jesus is and what he has done (vv. 5–6). The Greek uses the present tense: *"To him who loves us"* – his love never stops! And then the past tense: *"and has freed us from our sins by his blood"*. (Some later manuscripts, followed by the King James Version, read "washed"; the oldest manuscripts read "freed".) We are not pitiful victims of the world; he *"made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father"*. A priest has direct access to God, and a king reigns with Christ.
2. **Jesus Christ is the true Ruler over every earthly power.** He is described with three titles in verse 5: the *faithful witness* (he always speaks the full truth in a world full of political and spiritual lies), the *firstborn of the dead* (he has already conquered the enemy's worst weapon – death), and the *ruler of the kings of the earth*. No president, dictator, economic system or crisis stands outside his authority.
3. **History is moving towards a visible, certain climax.** History is not turning aimlessly in circles. Verse 7 combines prophecies from Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10: *"Look, he is coming with the clouds, and every*

eye will see him." What is now hidden from the world will one day be unmistakable.

Living It Out

When we look at our own lives, we may not be persecuted by a Roman emperor, but we know the feeling of being overwhelmed. We read the news, look at our bank statements, think about our health or our children's future, and it often feels as if chaos is in charge. We get stuck in the "middle" of our story, where things look uncertain and broken.

Revelation 1:1–8 sets our perspective straight. It asks us to stop staring at the "little emperors" of our day – fear, uncertainty, other people's opinions, or worldly powers – and to lift our eyes to the *ruler of the kings of the earth*.

Notice how John responds in the middle of his exile in verses 5 and 6: he bursts into a song of praise (a doxology). He does not wait until he is released from Patmos before he praises God. He praises him *on* Patmos, because he knows his sins are forgiven, he is deeply loved, and his King is coming. When you know who the Alpha and the Omega is, you need not panic about chapter 5 or chapter 12 of your life. The Author of your life is already at the end, and he is good.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What "veil" of fear, worry or daily rush is keeping you at the moment from seeing Jesus' rule over your situation?
- Verse 3 promises blessing to those who do not only read and hear the Word, but *keep* it. Are you reading the Bible at the moment only to gather information, or are you letting it shape your choices and attitudes every day?
- Are you living today as someone who is already loved, freed from your sins and part of Christ's kingdom of priests – or are you living as if you still have to earn God's favour or people's approval?

Prayer

Lord Jesus, you who are and who were and who are coming, the Almighty: today I bow my heart before you as the Alpha and the Omega of my life. Forgive me for so easily letting the storms, uncertainties and noise of this world blind me to your greatness. Please pull the veil from my eyes today.

Thank you that you do not merely rule me from a distance, but that you love me, have freed me from my sins by your own precious blood, and have made me part of your kingdom. When I face choices, pressure or fear today, remind me that you are the faithful Witness and the Ruler of the kings of the earth.

Open my ears to hear your Word on this journey through Revelation, and give me an obedient heart to keep it. To you belong all the glory and the might, today and for ever and ever. Amen.

DAY 2

The Glorified King among the Lampstands

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 1:9–20

9 I, John, your brother, who shares with you in the affliction and the
kingdom and the endurance in Jesus, was on the island called Patmos
because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus. 10 On the Lord's
day I came to be in the Spirit, and behind me I heard a loud voice like a
trumpet, 11 saying, "Write what you see in a book and send it to the seven
churches: to Ephesus, to Smyrna, to Pergamum, to Thyatira, to Sardis,
to Philadelphia and to Laodicea." 12 And I turned to see the voice that
was speaking with me. And when I had turned, I saw seven golden
lampstands, 13 and in the middle of the lampstands one like a son of
man, dressed in a robe that reached to his feet, with a golden sash
around his chest. 14 His head and his hair were white like white wool,
like snow, and his eyes were like a flame of fire; 15 his feet were like bur-
nished bronze, as if glowing in a furnace, and his voice was like the
sound of many waters. 16 In his right hand he had seven stars, out of his
mouth came a sharp two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun
shining in its power.

17 When I saw him, I fell at his feet as though dead. And he placed his
right hand on me and said, "Do not be afraid. I am the First and the Last,
18 and the Living One. I was dead, and look, I am alive for ever and ever,
and I have the keys of death and of Hades. 19 So write down what you
have seen, what is, and what is going to take place after this. 20 As for the
mystery of the seven stars that you saw in my right hand, and the seven
golden lampstands: the seven stars are the angels of the seven churches,
and the seven lampstands are the seven churches."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

John finds himself on Patmos, a small, rocky island of volcanic origin in the Aegean Sea, some 60 to 70 kilometres off the coast of Asia Minor. The Romans often banished troublesome people to islands, and according to ancient church tradition John was sent to Patmos in this way – a place of isolation and oblivion. He himself says only that he was there *"because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus"*. But no Roman power could shut out the Spirit of God. On "the Lord's day" (probably Sunday, the day of Christ's resurrection) John's physical limitations are overtaken by a heavenly reality.

Before Jesus addresses his messages to the seven particular churches, he first gives an overwhelming vision of himself. Why? Because the church's greatest problem in times of crisis (and of prosperity) is **too small a view of Jesus**. John uses images from the Old Testament (especially Daniel 7 and 10, and Ezekiel 1) to paint a portrait of who the risen Christ really is.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore some key terms from the original Greek:

- **"Who shares with you" (*synkoinōnos* – συγκοινωνός, v. 9):** In verse 9 John does not call himself an exalted apostle above the churches, but your brother, a *synkoinōnos* (someone who has an intimate share in something together with others). He shows that for a Christian three things belong inseparably together: **affliction** (*thlipsis* – θλῖψις: pressure from outside), **kingdom** (*basileia* – βασιλεία: reigning together with Christ), and **endurance** (*hypomonē* – ὑπομονή: courageous staying power under heavy loads). You cannot have the kingdom without being willing to go through pressure with endurance.
- **"Lampstands" (*lychniai* – λυχνίαι, vv. 12, 20):** This was not the one seven-branched lampstand (the menorah) of the Old Testament tabernacle and temple (Exodus 25:31–37; cf. Zechariah 4:2), but seven sepa-

rate golden lampstands. The church has no light of her own; she is simply the stand that must hold up the light of Christ in a dark world.

- **"Sharp two-edged sword" (*rhomphaia distomos* – ῥομφαία δίστομος, v. 16):** The word for the sword that comes out of Jesus' mouth is not *machaira* (μάχαιρα), the ordinary word for a shorter sword or dagger, but *rhomphaia* – originally a long, heavy weapon (the word is often linked with the Thracian long blade), and here *distomos*, literally "two-mouthed", razor-sharp on both sides. (Revelation uses both words, so the difference should not be pressed too far.) Isaiah 49:2 says of the Servant of the LORD: "He made my mouth a sharp sword." It symbolises the absolute power of his spoken Word to cut lies open and to pass righteous judgement.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

Every physical detail of this vision carries a specific theological truth for the churches:

1. **Jesus is present in the midst of his church (vv. 12–13).** He stands *in the middle of* the seven golden lampstands, and in 2:1 he is described as the one *"who walks among the seven golden lampstands"*. He is not an absent landlord who has left his church to her fate. His long robe and the golden sash around his chest recall the dress of the high priest, and also that of a king. Just as the priests in the temple tended the lamps every day, trimmed the wicks and added oil, so Jesus walks among his churches to examine them, purify them and keep them burning.
2. **His divine wisdom, knowledge and power (vv. 14–16).**
    - *Hair white as snow*: In Daniel 7:9 God (the "Ancient of Days") is described with hair white like wool. By applying this feature to Jesus, the text declares that Jesus possesses eternal wisdom and is himself God.
    - *Eyes like a flame of fire*: Nothing is hidden from him. His gaze burns through every religious mask, all hypocrisy and every excuse.

- *"His feet were like burnished bronze, as if glowing in a furnace, and his voice was like the sound of many waters"*: He stands immovable to trample down evil, and his voice drowns out all the noise and propaganda of the world.

3. **Absolute security and victory over death (vv. 16–18).** John falls overwhelmed at his feet – according to the church's tradition the same John who had leaned against Jesus' chest at the Last Supper! Then that same pierced right hand that holds the seven stars touches him tenderly. Jesus combines his awe-inspiring majesty with intimate gentleness: *"Do not be afraid."* He has *"the keys of death and of Hades"*. Not Rome, not illness, and not the devil decides when a believer's life ends; Jesus opens and shuts.

Living It Out

We often live with a shrunken version of Jesus in our minds. We think of him only as the gentle Shepherd in a children's Bible picture or the suffering Man on the cross, and we forget that today he is the glorified King whose face shines like the sun in its power. When our picture of Jesus is small, our problems look enormous. But when we see him as John saw him on Patmos, our fears shrink to their true size.

Think of the picture in verses 16 and 17: the hand that holds the stars (the angels of the churches – many understand them as the leaders or messengers of the church) is the same hand that rests on the shoulder of a trembling, overwhelmed human being. This means that no power can snatch you out of his right hand, and that his immense strength always goes together with his personal compassion for you.

At the same time this vision challenges us. If Jesus walks today with "eyes like a flame of fire" through the corridors of your heart and your church, what does he see? We can fool other people with pious words and a neat appearance on a Sunday morning, but before him everything lies open

and bare. Yet his purpose with the sharp sword of his Word is not to destroy his children, but to cut away everything that keeps us from shining brightly as his golden lampstands.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- John calls himself one who shares in the affliction, the kingdom and the endurance. How are you handling the "pressure" (*thlipsis*) in your life at the moment – is it making you bitter, or is it growing patient endurance in you?
- Is there any area of your life that you are trying to hide from others, about which you need to realise afresh today that it lies completely open before Jesus' "eyes like a flame of fire"?
- Which specific fear in your life needs to hear today that Jesus holds "*the keys of death and of Hades*" in his own hand?

Prayer

> *Glorified Lord Jesus, as I look at this vision of you this morning, I realise how small and limited my thoughts about you often are. I bow in reverence before your majesty. You are the First and the Last, and the Living One who has conquered death for ever.*
>
> *Search my heart today with your eyes like a flame of fire; show me where I wear masks, and with the two-edged sword of your Word cut away everything that does not bring you honour. Thank you that in my own "Patmos" moments of isolation or struggle you do not stand far off, but walk among us.*
>
> *Please lay your right hand of grace on my life today and speak your peace over my fears. Help me today to let your light shine brightly like a pure golden lampstand wherever I go. Amen.*

DAY 3

Ephesus – The Danger of a Dutiful Heart without Love

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 2:1–7

[1] To the angel of the church in Ephesus write: The one who holds the seven stars in his right hand, who walks among the seven golden lampstands, says this: [2] I know your works, your toil and your endurance, and that you cannot bear evil people. You have tested those who call themselves apostles and are not, and you have found them to be liars. [3] You have endurance, and you have borne up for my name's sake, and you have not grown weary. [4] But I have this against you: you have abandoned your first love. [5] So remember from where you have fallen, repent, and do the first works. If not, I am coming to you, and I will move your lampstand from its place, unless you repent. [6] But you have this: you hate the works of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate. [7] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Welcome to the first of the seven letters! When the messenger from Patmos landed with the scroll on the mainland of Asia Minor, **Ephesus** was the very first city. The seven cities lie in the order of a circular route, probably the road a messenger would follow from city to city. Ephesus was no mere village; it was the pulsing economic, political and religious metropolis of the province of Asia. The city boasted a massive theatre seating about 25,000 people and the world-famous temple of Artemis (Diana) – one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. Around this tem-

ple idolatry, sorcery (cf. Acts 19:19) and powerful trade guilds (Acts 19:24–27) flourished. On top of that, Ephesus had a temple for the emperors and was a centre of emperor worship.

To be a Christian in Ephesus meant swimming every day against a tsunami of pagan immorality and idolatry. And yet this church had an incredible spiritual pedigree: Paul had taught them for three years (Acts 20:31), Timothy had worked there (1 Timothy 1:3), and according to church tradition the apostle John himself ministered there before his exile.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into a few Greek key words that unlock the heart of Jesus' message to Ephesus:

- **"Toil" (*kopos* – κόπος, v. 2):** When Jesus says in verse 2, "*I know your works, your toil and your endurance*", he does not use the ordinary word for work. *Kopos* means **exhausting, sweat-draining labour that wears you out to the bone.** These believers were no lazy pew-warmers; they had worked themselves to exhaustion for the Lord.
- **"Bear" (*bastazō* – βαστάζω, vv. 2–3):** In verse 2 ("cannot bear") and verse 3 ("borne up") the same verb is used, creating a beautiful play on words. They patiently bore heavy burdens and persecution for Christ's sake, but they refused to bear or tolerate false teachers and evil in the church.
- **"Abandoned" (*aphiēmi* – ἀφίημι, v. 4):** In verse 4 Jesus says: "*You have abandoned your first love.*" Notice the precise choice of word: he does not say they had *lost* their first love (as when you accidentally leave your car keys lying somewhere). *Aphiēmi* means **to leave behind, let go or abandon** – something you let go of yourself, not something that merely happens to you. Their passion for Jesus had gradually given way to mere duty.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

Four great theological truths stand out from this letter:

1. **Sound doctrine and hard work can never replace intimate love for Christ (vv. 2–4).** If we looked at the church in Ephesus today, we would think it the perfect model church. They were busy, persevering, morally clean and theologically razor-sharp. They even unmasked false apostles and the Nicolaitans (a group who, as 2:14–15 suggests, taught that Christians could make compromises with pagan idolatry and sexual licence). But the One with eyes like a flame of fire looks past their impressive CV straight into their hearts. They were so busy defending the *truth* that they had stopped loving the *Person* who is the Truth. Orthodoxy (right doctrine) without passionate love always degenerates into cold, loveless legalism.
2. **Loveless religion leads to the loss of spiritual influence (v. 5).** Jesus' warning is shocking: "*I will move your lampstand from its place*." This does not mean that an individual child of God loses their salvation, but that a church (or a believer) loses the privilege and power to be a light-bearer for Christ in their surroundings. A church that no longer burns with love for Jesus and for people ceases in God's eyes to be a true church – it becomes merely a religious club.
3. **The way back to spiritual renewal has three clear steps (v. 5).** Jesus does not only give the diagnosis; he gives the medicine. We see the three R's of restoration:
    - **Remember** (in the Greek a present imperative: keep thinking back to that high point when your heart still beat warmly for Jesus and his grace overwhelmed you).
    - **Repent** (*metanoeō* – μετανοέω: make an immediate, radical U-turn in your thinking and priorities).
    - **Repeat – do the first works** (return to the deeds that were driven by simple, grateful devotion and wonder, not by mere religious routine).

4. **The reward for the one who conquers is restored fellowship in God's presence (v. 7).** The "tree of life" takes our thoughts straight back to Genesis 2 and 3, where humanity was banished from the garden of Eden after the fall. To the believer who conquers by clinging to Jesus, he promises the full restoration of that broken relationship: eternal, unhindered fellowship with God *"in the paradise of God"*, made possible by the "tree" of the cross of Golgotha.

Living It Out

This letter to Ephesus often hits the most devoted, mature Christians hardest. When we first come to faith, our hearts are full of wonder. We read the Bible because we are hungry to hear Jesus' voice; we pray because we want to be with him; we serve because we overflow with gratitude.

But as the years go by, a subtle danger creeps in. We get used to grace. We begin to focus on "church business", correct theological debates, projects and duties. We get angry about the moral decay of the world around us (just as Ephesus could not bear evil people), but meanwhile our own hearts become hard, critical and cold. We confuse **being busy for the King** with **intimacy with the King**. Like Martha in Luke 10 we become so exhausted by our service in the kitchen that we forget to sit at Jesus' feet.

Jesus says to you today: *"I see how hard you work. I see how tired you are. I value that you stand firm for the truth in a compromising world. But I miss you. I am not only looking for your hands and your mind; I am looking for your heart."* You do not have to wait for an emotional feeling before you return. Jesus' command is practical: remember, repent, and begin again to do those first works of simple surrender and worship.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If you honestly compare your relationship with Jesus today with a time in your past when you felt closest to him, has your love deepened, or has it cooled into mere routine and duty?

- Has your zeal for what is "right and wrong" perhaps made you hard, critical or loveless recently towards people who fail, instead of approaching them with Christ's compassion?
- What were your "first works" when you first truly understood the Lord's grace? Which one practical habit of stillness, praise or selfless love can you deliberately take up again today?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, you who walk among the golden lampstands and know every secret of my heart, I come and stand before you today without pretence. Thank you that you see my toil, my endurance and my desire to stand for your truth. But Lord, your eyes of fire also see how easily my faith turns into a list of duties that I simply tick off.*
>
> *Forgive me where I have become so busy with things around you that I have left you yourself behind. Forgive me for a critical spirit that wants to be right but has forgotten how to love. Today I want to remember from where you have saved me. I turn away from my lukewarmness and my hurry.*
>
> *Please kindle again the fire of my first love as I behold your cross. Let everything I do today flow not from mere duty, but from a heart that overflows with wonder at your grace. Amen.*

DAY 4

Smyrna: The Wealth of a Faith Tested by Fire

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 2:8–11

8 And to the angel of the church in Smyrna write: The First and the Last,
who was dead and came to life, says this: 9 I know your affliction and
your poverty – but you are rich – and the slander of those who say they
are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan. 10 Do not fear any-
thing you are about to suffer. Look, the devil is about to throw some of
you into prison so that you may be tested, and you will have affliction
for ten days. Be faithful to the point of death, and I will give you the
crown of life. 11 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to
the churches. The one who conquers will not be harmed at all by the
second death.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

About 55 kilometres north of Ephesus, along the coast of the Aegean Sea, lies the next stop on the postal route: **Smyrna** (today the city of Izmir in Turkey). Smyrna was proud of its splendid architecture on the slopes of Mount Pagos; the public buildings that ringed the hill were sometimes compared to a crown. It was a wealthy harbour city – and for Christians one of the most dangerous places on earth to live.

Smyrna was fiercely loyal to Rome. As early as 195 BC it built one of the very first temples in honour of the goddess *Roma*, and in AD 26 it beat ten other cities for the coveted right to build a temple to the emperor Tiberius. In Smyrna, emperor worship was not merely a religious ritual; it was civic pride. A pinch of incense on the altar before the emperor's image and the confession *Kyrios Kaisar* ("Caesar is Lord") counted as proof of

loyalty to the city and the empire. Whoever refused became suspect and could lose his place in the trade guild, his work and his customers. (The well-known certificates proving that someone had sacrificed come only from the persecution under the emperor Decius in AD 250; in John's day the pressure was more social and economic – but no less real.)

The name **Smyrna** is the Greek word for **myrrh** – a precious, fragrant resin used for perfume and for embalming the dead (and given to Jesus both at his birth and at his burial, Matthew 2:11; John 19:39). Myrrh is a familiar picture: it releases its sweetest, richest fragrance when it is **crushed and pounded**. The church in Smyrna lived up to its name: a crushed church giving off a lovely fragrance for Christ. (It is also one of only two churches, together with Philadelphia, to which Jesus speaks not a single word of rebuke or criticism!)

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the powerful Greek terms in this short but profound letter:

- **"Poverty" (*ptōcheia* – πτωχεία, v. 9):** Greek has two words for poverty. The first is *penia* (πενία): you have just enough to live on and no luxuries. But Jesus uses *ptōcheia* here – **extreme, beggarly poverty**, having absolutely nothing. Because the Christians refused to worship the emperor, their businesses were boycotted, their property plundered and their work taken away.
- **"Affliction" (*thlipsis* – θλῖψις, vv. 9–10):** The word means pressure: being pressed together or crushed under a massive weight (picture olives in an olive press).
- **"Crown" (*stephanos* – στέφανος, v. 10):** When Jesus promises *"the crown of life"* in verse 10, he does not use *diadēma* (διάδημα, the royal crown of a ruler) but *stephanos* – the laurel wreath handed to an athlete who had successfully finished a gruelling race. Smyrna was known for its athletic games, and the believers would have grasped the picture at once.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This passage reveals four priceless truths for believers who suffer:

1. **The risen Christ knows the road of suffering and death first-hand (v. 8):** To a church facing death, Jesus introduces himself as the one *"who was dead and came to life"*. He does not shout orders from a safe distance; he himself died the worst of deaths and walked out on the other side of the grave. Many interpreters also hear an echo of Smyrna's own history: the old city was destroyed around 600 BC and only rebuilt about three centuries later – a city that had, as it were, "died and lived again". Jesus shows that he is the true Resurrection and the Life.
2. **Heaven defines wealth radically differently from the world (v. 9):** In the eyes of Smyrna's citizens the Christians were pitiful beggars (*ptōcheia*). But Jesus inserts four words that change everything: "***but you are rich***". Why? Because they had treasure in heaven that no emperor or mob could steal (cf. James 2:5). Later we will see Laodicea, which thinks it is rich while it is spiritually bankrupt; Smyrna has nothing on earth but possesses everything in Christ. Even when members of the local Jewish community (who were exempt from sacrificing to the gods and the emperor) probably denounced the Christians to the Roman authorities to protect themselves, Jesus declares that true spiritual identity lies in faith, not in bloodline.
3. **God sets a firm limit on the length and purpose of our suffering (v. 10):** Jesus does not hide the truth – it will get harder before it gets better. The devil is behind the persecution, tempting them to compromise, but God uses the very same fire to test and refine their faith ("*so that you may be tested*"). Notice the words "**for ten days**". In the Bible (as in Daniel 1:12–14, where Daniel and his friends were tested for ten days) "ten days" points to an **intense but strictly limited and measured period**. The devil is on a leash; God holds the stopwatch.

4. **Eternal life disarms the fear of physical death (vv. 10–11):** Jesus' command is not *"Be successful"* but *"Be faithful to the point of death"* (that is: even if it costs you your life). The first death (physical death) can strike the body, but the one who conquers will never be harmed by the **second death** (Revelation 20:14 – eternal separation from God in the lake of fire). About sixty years after this letter was written (if Revelation was written around AD 95, as most assume), Polycarp, the aged bishop of Smyrna – according to Irenaeus a disciple of John – was executed in the city's stadium. When the proconsul pressed him to curse Christ, Polycarp, according to the account of his martyrdom, replied: *"Eighty-six years I have served him, and he has never done me any wrong. How then can I blaspheme my King who saved me?"*

Living It Out

We live in a culture that tries to avoid suffering at all costs and treats prosperity as the only proof of God's blessing. When hardship, financial loss, rejection or illness comes our way, our first reaction is often: *"What have I done wrong? Why has God abandoned me?"*

Smyrna smashes this false theology. This church had done **nothing** wrong – on the contrary, they were so faithful to Jesus that they lost everything! Sometimes God allows us to go through the winepress of *thlipsis* (affliction), not because he is angry with us, but because he is releasing the precious myrrh-fragrance of Christ's character in our lives.

Perhaps you are going through a "ten-day" season of pressure today. Maybe you are being sidelined at work because you refuse to join in the lying or to excuse corruption. Maybe you feel shut out by friends or family because you stand by biblical values. Or maybe you are walking through a dark valley of loss where you feel you have come to the very end of your strength (*ptōcheia*).

Hear the voice today of the One who himself went through death and lives again: "**Do not fear anything you are about to suffer.**" Your pain is not blind or endless. It has been measured out by your Father's hand ("ten days"), and at the end of this race the victor's crown (*stephanos*) of life is waiting for you. What you give up for Jesus' sake today makes you rich for eternity.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- By what do you currently measure whether you are "rich" and blessed – your bank balance, comfort and people's approval, or your spiritual wealth in Christ?
- Where in your life are you being tempted right now to burn a "pinch of incense" to the world's idols (keeping your faith quiet or bending your values) just to avoid conflict, mockery or loss?
- How does it change your view of your present trial to know that God has set a fixed time limit ("ten days") on your suffering and that the enemy does not have the last word?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, you who are the First and the Last, who drank the bitter cup of death and rose in victory, I come to take refuge in you today. Thank you that you see every tear, every bit of pressure and every loss in my life. Forgive me that I so often measure my worth, and your love for me, by outward comfort and earthly prosperity.*
>
> *When life crushes me like myrrh, give me the grace not to become bitter and rebellious, but to release the sweet fragrance of your presence. Today I pray especially for my brothers and sisters around the world who sit in prison for your name's sake, who lose their livelihood and endure persecution – strengthen them with your supernatural courage.*

> *And in my own "ten days" of trial, take away my fear. Make me faithful, not only when it is easy, but to the very end, with my eyes fixed on the crown of life. Amen.*

DAY 5

Pergamum: Where Satan's Throne Is – The Danger of Subtle Compromise

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 2:12–17

12 And to the angel of the church in Pergamum write: The one who has
the sharp two-edged sword says this: 13 I know where you live: where
the throne of Satan is. Yet you hold fast to my name, and you did not
deny your faith in me, even in the days of Antipas, my witness, my faith-
ful one, who was killed among you, where Satan lives. 14 But I have a few
things against you: you have people there who hold fast to the teaching
of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the people
of Israel, so that they would eat food sacrificed to idols and commit sex-
ual immorality. 15 So you too have people who in the same way hold fast
to the teaching of the Nicolaitans. 16 So repent. If not, I am coming to
you soon, and I will make war against them with the sword of my
mouth. 17 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the
churches. To the one who conquers I will give some of the hidden
manna, and I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name
is written that no one knows except the one who receives it.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today our journey takes us about 100 kilometres north of Smyrna and a little inland to **Pergamum** (today's Bergama in Turkey). If Ephesus was the commercial heart of Asia, Pergamum was the old royal city and for a long time the official capital of the Roman province, carrying great political and religious weight. The city was built on an imposing, steep hill that towered some 300 metres above the surrounding plain. Pergamum was fa-

mous for its huge library, which according to tradition held 200,000 scrolls (and according to the well-known story, the word *parchment* comes from the name *Pergamum*).

In and around the city stood a forest of pagan temples:

1. On top of the acropolis, the enormous horseshoe-shaped **Altar of Zeus**, which looked like a giant throne on the hillside.
2. Down on the plain, the world-famous sanctuary of **Asclepius**, the god of healing, whose symbol was the serpent and who was honoured as "Saviour" (*Sōtēr*).
3. The **imperial temple** to Augustus and Roma (29 BC) – the first temple in the province to a living emperor; later Pergamum would gain further imperial temples.

What is more, the Roman governor (proconsul), who also held court in Pergamum, possessed the *ius gladii* (literally, the right of the sword) – the authority to impose the death penalty. So it is fitting that in verse 12 Jesus introduces himself as *"The one who has the sharp two-edged sword"*. The Roman governor may wield an earthly sword, but Jesus holds the supreme sword of eternal judgement.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into a few key words of the Greek text:

- **"Live" (*katoikeis* – κατοικεῖς, v. 13):** In verse 13 Jesus says: *"I know where you live."* Greek has a word for staying temporarily, like a foreigner or someone living in a tent (*paroikeō* – παροικέω), but *katoikeō* means **to settle permanently and put down roots**. The believers' address lay literally in the shadow of the devil's stronghold – but for some in the church the world around them had sadly also begun to feel too much like "home".

- **"Stumbling block" (*skandalon* – σκάνδαλον, v. 14):** In verse 14 Jesus refers to Balaam, who taught Balak to put a *skandalon* before Israel. The word probably first meant the stick or trigger inside an animal trap to which the bait was tied; in the Bible it already means a snare or stumbling block. As soon as the animal takes the bait, the trap snaps shut. It describes how sin always looks attractive and innocent at first, before it catches you spiritually.
- **"White stone" (*psēphos leukē* – ψῆφος λευκή, v. 17):** There are several explanations, and two fit particularly well. In the ancient world white and black pebbles were used for various purposes. In a law court a judge could drop a black pebble into an urn to declare guilt, and a **white pebble** for acquittal and innocence. In addition, small tablets or stones (*tessera*) were sometimes used as admission tickets to a banquet or the games.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This passage sets four vital truths before us:

1. **Jesus knows your address and understands how hard your surroundings are (v. 13):** Twice Jesus says that Satan *lives* in Pergamum and has his *throne* there. Whether this refers to the giant altar of Zeus, the serpent cult of Asclepius, or the centre of emperor worship and of the Roman power that persecuted Christians – the point is clear: Pergamum was a spiritual war zone. Jesus does not brush their hard circumstances aside. He praises them for clinging to his name under enormous pressure, even when a faithful member named **Antipas** (according to a later tradition roasted alive inside a hollow bronze bull) was killed for his faith. Jesus honours Antipas with the title he himself bears in Revelation 1:5, *"the faithful witness"*: Antipas is *"my witness, my faithful one"* (*martys* – μάρτυς).
2. **Where frontal attacks fail, the enemy uses subtle compromise (vv. 14–15):** When the devil saw that bloody persecution and the death of Antipas could not break the church in Pergamum, he changed tactics.

In Numbers 22–25 the sorcerer Balaam could not curse the people of Israel, because God protected them. So Balaam gave King Balak devilish advice (Numbers 31:16): don't fight Israel; invite them to your feasts instead, let the Moabite women seduce the men, and soon Israel will provoke its own God. That is exactly what happened in Pergamum through the Nicolaitans. Their reasoning went: *"God knows our hearts belong to him; surely it doesn't matter if we just eat meat with our business partners at the pagan temples and join in the wild guild parties to keep our jobs."*

3. **Tolerating sin in our midst makes us complicit before God (vv. 14–16):** Most of the church in Pergamum may not have committed sexual immorality or eaten idol meat themselves, but they quietly tolerated those who taught it. Whereas Ephesus (day 3) had truth without love, Pergamum had a twisted "love" (tolerance) without truth. Jesus demands that the whole church repent of this spiritual passivity – otherwise he himself will intervene with *"the sword of my mouth"*.

4. **God's reward surpasses every worldly feast you give up for his sake (v. 17):** To the believer who refuses to feast at the world's polluted idol banquets, Jesus promises the **hidden manna** – the true bread of heaven, intimate fellowship with himself (like the golden jar of manna hidden in the ark of the covenant, Hebrews 9:4). And to those rejected by society and found guilty by Roman judges, he gives the **white stone** of eternal acquittal and full access to the wedding supper of the Lamb (19:9), engraved with a new, intimate name that exists only between you and your Redeemer.

Living It Out

Many of us feel today as if we work or study in "Pergamum". You may find yourself in a corporate environment, on a university campus or in a circle of friends where it feels as if "Satan's throne" stands right next to your desk – a place where Christian values are mocked and dishonesty, lust or materialism are the norm.

It is encouraging to know that Jesus does not expect you to move into a monastery on a mountain. He says to Pergamum: *"I know where you live."* You can be a light in the darkest place, just like Antipas. His name is a short form of *Antipatros*, but preachers have long played on it: *anti-pas*, **"against all"** – a man willing to stand against the whole current of his culture for Jesus.

But Pergamum warns us against the enemy's most dangerous trick: **syncretism** (mixing our faith with worldly lifestyles). Few of us today would openly say: "I *deny Jesus*." We withstand the lions' den but fall for the "Balaam trap" of small, daily compromises. We watch the same impure entertainment as the world, laugh at the same dirty jokes, bend the rules on our tax returns, and justify it all under the cover of "grace" and "we don't want to seem judgemental". We try to stand with one foot in the kingdom while sitting with the other at the world's table. Today Jesus calls us back to undivided loyalty. Whatever you lose on earth because you refuse to compromise is nothing compared with the white stone and the hidden manna from his hand.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What does the "Pergamum" you live and work in every day look like? What specific pressure do you feel to keep your faith quiet or to blend in with the crowd?
- Is there a "Balaam stumbling block" in your life right now – an area where you have made a small moral or spiritual compromise and tried to talk yourself into thinking it is "not that bad"?
- Do you look for your identity and acceptance in this world's "admission tickets" (status, popularity, financial success), or do you rest in the white stone and the new name Christ gives you?

Prayer

Lord Jesus, you who hold the sharp two-edged sword of truth, I bow before your authority today. Thank you that you know exactly where I live, work and move, and that you fully understand the pressures and temptations that surround me every day. Lord, give me the backbone of an Antipas, so that I do not deny my faith in you when it becomes uncomfortable or costly.

But above all guard my heart against Balaam's subtle traps. Forgive me for the times I have compromised with the world to fit in, to avoid conflict or to gain an advantage. Search my life with the sword of your Word and cut away every growth of conformity to the world.

I do not need the world's approval or forbidden pleasure; feed my soul today with your hidden manna, and let me rest in the knowledge that I have been acquitted through your blood and have received a new name from your hand. Amen.

DAY 6

Thyatira: When Tolerance Becomes Betrayal

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 2:18–29

18 And to the angel of the church in Thyatira write: The Son of God, who
has eyes like a flame of fire and whose feet are like burnished bronze,
says this: 19 I know your works: your love and faith and service and en-
durance, and that your last works are more than the first. 20 But I have
this against you: you tolerate the woman Jezebel, who calls herself a
prophetess and teaches and deceives my servants, so that they commit
sexual immorality and eat food sacrificed to idols. 21 I gave her time to
repent, but she does not want to repent of her sexual immorality.
22 Look, I am throwing her onto a bed, and those who commit adultery
with her into great affliction, unless they repent of her works. 23 And I
will kill her children with pestilence. And all the churches will know
that I am the one who searches minds and hearts, and I will give to each
of you according to your works. 24 But to the rest of you in Thyatira, all
who do not hold this teaching, who have not come to know the deep
things of Satan, as they call them, I say: I am not putting any other bur-
den on you. 25 Only hold fast to what you have until I come. 26 And the
one who conquers and keeps my works to the end, I will give him au-
thority over the nations,

27 and he will shepherd them with an iron rod,
as clay pots are shattered –

28 just as I too have received it from my Father. And I will give him the
morning star. 29 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to
the churches.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

The postal route now swings south-east from Pergamum into the inland valley where **Thyatira** (today's Akhisar in Turkey) lay. It is fascinating that the smallest and politically least important city on the route receives the **longest letter** of all seven churches. Thyatira had no natural mountain fortress like Pergamum and no great seaport like Ephesus and Smyrna. It was an industrial, working-class town and a commercial centre known for its textile trade (remember Lydia, the seller of purple from Thyatira, who came to faith in Philippi in Acts 16), as well as for metalwork, tanning and pottery.

The whole economic life of Thyatira revolved around **trade guilds** (the ancient version of trade unions). Each craft had its own guild and its own patron god. The city's chief god was *Apollo Tyrimnaios* (the sun god), honoured as a "son of Zeus"; many interpreters think the emperor was identified with him in Thyatira. Guild meetings were often held in pagan temples. They began with a drink offering to the idol, followed by a banquet of meat sacrificed to the idol, and could easily end in drunkenness and sexual excess. If a Christian craftsman refused to attend these guild meals, he put his place in the guild – and with it his customers and his income – at risk, and plunged his family into poverty.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us examine key words of the original Greek text:

- **"The Son of God" (*ho hyios tou theou* – ὁ υἱὸς τοῦ θεοῦ, v. 18):** Verse 18 is the **only place in the whole book of Revelation** where the title *"The Son of God"* occurs. Why here of all places? Probably because Apollo (and with him the emperor) was honoured in Thyatira as "son of Zeus". With eyes like a flame of fire and feet like burnished bronze (*chalkolibanō* – χαλκολιβάνῳ, a word found nowhere outside Revelation; it points to a bright, glowing metal, and Thyatira's guild of

bronze- and coppersmiths is known from inscriptions), Jesus declares that he is the only true Son of God, who tramples every false claimant underfoot.

- **"Tolerate" (*apheis* – ἀφεῖς, v. 20):** In verse 20 Jesus says: "*you tolerate the woman Jezebel*". It is the same Greek verb (*aphiēmi*) that the letter to Ephesus (2:4) uses for "*abandoned*". Where Ephesus let go of its first love, Thyatira let go of its duty to stop evil – they gave a false teacher free rein.
- **"Minds and hearts" (*nephrous kai kardias* – νεφροὺς καὶ καρδίας, v. 23):** In verse 23 Jesus says he is "*the one who searches minds and hearts*" (cf. Jeremiah 17:10). The Greek literally says "kidneys and hearts". In ancient Hebrew and Greek thought the **kidneys** (*nephros*) were the seat of a person's deepest emotions, secret desires and motives, while the **heart** (*kardia*) was the seat of the mind, the will and the thoughts. Jesus looks past outward deeds into the most hidden rooms of our motives and desires.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This powerful letter opens up four great truths for us:

1. **Growth in love and service does not excuse a lack of spiritual discernment (vv. 19–20):** Thyatira was the exact opposite of Ephesus. They overflowed with *agapē* (love), *diakonia* (practical service), faith and endurance. What is more, they were not going backwards: Jesus says "*that your last works are more than the first*". They were growing! But their greatest strength had become their most dangerous blind spot. Their love had degenerated into a soft, spineless tolerance that refused to confront falsehood.
2. **The "Jezebel spirit" justifies sin under a spiritual cloak (vv. 20, 24):** There was an influential woman in the church who called herself a prophetess. Jesus calls her "Jezebel" – after the notorious Old Testament queen (1 Kings 16–21) who brought Baal worship and idolatry into Israel. With "prophetic authority" this woman taught

Thyatira's hard-pressed Christian craftsmen that it was perfectly fine to take part in the guilds' idol feasts and immorality. She probably even claimed a deeper, secret "spiritual knowledge" (of the kind that would later flourish in Gnosticism) – which Jesus pointedly calls *"the deep things of Satan"* (v. 24). Her argument may have run: *"To truly conquer Satan and prove your spiritual freedom, you must enter his depths; what you do with your body at the guild feasts does not touch your soul."*

3. **God's patience with sin is gracious, but not unlimited (vv. 21–23):** Look at the astonishing grace in verse 21: *"I gave her time to repent."* Even to a "Jezebel" God gives chance after chance. But when grace is stubbornly rejected, righteous judgement follows. With sharp irony Jesus says that the woman who chose the bed of immorality will be thrown onto a **bed** – the bed of her sin becomes the bed of her punishment – together with her spiritual followers ("her children"), so that all the churches will once again hold in holy awe the One who searches minds and hearts.

4. **The one who conquers receives eternal authority – and the presence of Christ himself (vv. 24–28):** To the faithful remnant who refused to bow the knee to economic pressure, Jesus gives two wonderful promises. First, he takes up Psalm 2:8–9: the believers who are trampled like clay pots by the powerful and the guilds today will one day receive authority over the nations with the Messiah and *"shepherd them with an iron rod"*. Second, he promises: **"And I will give him the morning star."** The morning star appears in the very darkest hour of the night as the unfailing sign that dawn is near. In Revelation 22:16 Jesus declares: *"I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star."* The greatest reward Jesus gives is not merely a gift – it is **himself**.

Living It Out

Thyatira holds up a mirror to the modern church and to our personal life of faith. We live in an age that has raised "tolerance" to the highest of virtues. Our culture tells us that being loving means never saying that

anything is wrong.

The letter to Thyatira shows how deadly this half-truth is. True biblical love is never blind to evil (in Philippians 1:9 Paul prays that our love may abound more and more *in knowledge and every kind of insight*). When we let sin and false teaching go unchecked in our own lives, our families or our churches under the banner of "love" or "keeping the peace", we commit spiritual betrayal against the holy Son of God.

Think too of the "guild pressure" of our time. Every day we are confronted by modern "Jezebels" – voices on social media, in the corporate world and even within distorted forms of Christianity – whispering to us: *"You've got to make a living. Everybody does it. God understands your needs; just bend the truth a little to save your career or to be socially accepted."*

But today Jesus looks with eyes like a flame of fire into your mind and heart – into your deepest motives. Have you perhaps misused his grace and patience (*"I gave her time"*) as an excuse to keep holding on to a cherished sin? To those who are worn out from swimming against the current, Jesus tenderly says in verse 25: **"Only hold fast to what you have until I come."** The night may look its darkest right now at your work or in your circumstances, but the bright Morning Star is already on the horizon.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which of the two extremes is the greater temptation for you personally: the loveless correctness of Ephesus, or the spineless tolerance of Thyatira that overlooks sin and compromise?
- Is there a specific area of your life where God has given you time to repent (v. 21), but where you have so far mistaken his patience for approval?
- When Jesus searches your mind and heart today (your deepest secret desires and motives), does he see that your good works flow from sincere surrender to him – or from the wish to be seen by people?

Prayer

Lord Jesus, Son of God, whose eyes like a flame of fire see through every pretence and whose feet stand unshakeable like glowing bronze, I humble myself before you today. Thank you for the grace with which you notice every bit of growth in love, service, faith and endurance in my life.

But Lord, keep me from a twisted love that makes peace with sin. Search my mind and my heart today. Show me where I have tolerated voices of compromise in my life – where I have listened to excuses that justify sin for the sake of comfort, profit or acceptance.

Thank you for your indescribable patience, which has given me time to turn back. I no longer want to misuse your grace; today I break with every compromise. Give me the strength to hold fast to your truth until you come. Be my bright Morning Star today, shining in the darkness and filling my heart with the hope of your eternal kingdom. Amen.

DAY 7

Sardis – The Danger of a Good Reputation Without a Beating Heart

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 3:1–6

[1] And to the angel of the church in Sardis write: The one who has the seven spirits of God and the seven stars says this: I know your works: you have the name of being alive, but you are dead. [2] Wake up, and strengthen what remains, which was about to die, for I have not found your works complete before my God. [3] So remember how you received and heard; keep it, and repent. If you do not wake up, I will come like a thief, and you will not know at all at what hour I will come upon you. [4] But you have a few names in Sardis who have not soiled their clothes, and they will walk with me in white, because they are worthy. [5] The one who conquers will in this way be dressed in white clothes, and I will never blot his name out of the book of life, and I will confess his name before my Father and before his angels. [6] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today our journey takes us a good fifty kilometres south of Thyatira to **Sardis** – a city living off its faded glory. Centuries earlier Sardis had been the legendary capital of the ancient kingdom of Lydia, where the proverbially rich King Croesus reigned. Gold was literally panned from the nearby river Pactolus, and the very first coins of pure gold and silver are credited to the Sardis of Croesus.

The old city's citadel stood on top of a steep, crumbling ridge of rock that towered hundreds of metres above the Hermus valley. The people of Sardis believed their city was utterly impregnable. And according to the

ancient historians, it was precisely this self-assured arrogance that brought about their downfall twice. In 546 BC King Cyrus of Persia besieged the city. Because the people of Sardis thought no one could climb the sheer cliffs, they left that side unguarded. Herodotus tells how a soldier in the Persian army watched a defender of Sardis drop his helmet over the edge and climb down a hidden path to fetch it. Soon afterwards the Persians climbed up by the same path, took the unguarded citadel by surprise and captured it like a "thief". According to Polybius something similar happened three centuries later (in 214 BC) under Antiochus the Great: once again climbers scaled the cliffs at a point where the guards were not at their posts. By the time John writes, Sardis was a wealthy but decadent city living on the fame of its past, while its heart had long since been hollowed out.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at some key words of the Greek text:

- ***Onoma* – ὄνομα (name / reputation):** In verse 1 Jesus says: "you have the name of being alive, but you are dead" (*nekros* – νεκρός). In the surrounding cities the church in Sardis had a brilliant reputation. It was active, well known and respected. But before Jesus it was a spiritual corpse – nothing more than a fine gravestone with an impressive inscription.
- ***Grēgoreō* – γρηγορέω (be watchful / wake up):** In verses 2 and 3 the sharp military command rings out: *grēgoreō* – "Wake up and stay at your post!" Anyone in Sardis who knew the city's shameful history – guards who did not keep watch on the walls while the enemy climbed in – would have flinched at this very word.
- ***Peplērōmena* – πεπληρωμένα (complete / filled):** In verse 2 Jesus says: "I have not found your works complete before my God." They were not without works; they had programmes and activities. But their works were like empty shells – attractive on the outside for people to see, but empty on the inside of Spirit-filled faith and real love for God.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This cutting letter reveals four profound theological truths:

1. **The Holy Spirit is the only source of genuine spiritual life (v. 1):** To a dead church Jesus does not introduce himself with a sword of judgement, but as "the one who has the seven spirits of God and the seven stars". The "seven spirits" refer to the Holy Spirit in his sevenfold fullness and life-giving power (cf. Isaiah 11:2; Zechariah 4:6). A church or a believer that leans on human organisation, tradition and reputation without the indwelling power of the Holy Spirit is merely running a religious mortuary. But the good news is this: Jesus holds in his hand the Spirit who brings dry bones back to life (Ezekiel 37)!
2. **Peace with the world is often a sign of spiritual death (vv. 1–2):** Have you noticed what is completely missing from the letter to Sardis? There is no mention of persecution from outside (as in Smyrna and Pergamum), no mention of Jewish opposition, and no mention of false teachers like the Nicolaitans or Jezebel from within! Why did the devil leave Sardis alone? Because a dead church poses no threat to Satan's kingdom. Sardis was so comfortably woven into its pagan culture that there was no friction left.
3. **Spiritual renewal calls for five urgent steps of obedience (vv. 2–3):** Jesus has not yet written the church off; there are still embers glowing ("what remains, which was about to die"). He gives five direct commands:
    - **Wake up** (*grēgoreō* – shake off spiritual slumber and complacency).
    - **Strengthen what remains** (*stērizō* – στηρίζω – prop up the faint sparks of faith that have not yet gone out, and breathe new life into them).
    - **Remember how you received and heard** (think back to the humble dependence with which you first received the gospel).
    - **Keep it** (obey the Word in practice).

- **Repent** (break at once with your spiritual hypocrisy, before Christ arrives unexpectedly like a thief with his discipline).

4. **Unstained faithfulness leads to public honour before God's throne (vv. 4–5):** Even in a spiritually dead city like Sardis the Lord knows the "few names" who refused to stain their spiritual clothes with the filth of the world. In the ancient world a worshipper often had to be ritually clean to enter a temple, and soiled clothes could keep him out. Jesus promises the conquerors three things:
   - They will **walk with him in white** – the symbol of complete purity, festive joy and the righteousness of Christ.
   - Their name will **never be blotted out of the book of life**. Ancient cities kept a register of citizens, and the name of a citizen who died or was condemned for a crime could be struck out. But even if the world strikes your name from its roll of honour, your name stands in the Lamb's register in the indelible ink of grace.
   - Jesus himself will **confess your name** "before my Father and before his angels" (cf. Matthew 10:32).

Living It Out

Sardis is a frightening diagnosis for believers today who have walked with the Lord for a long time. It is possible to be the perfect Christian on paper and in the eyes of your community, while your soul is running on "autopilot". People at church or at work may think you are a spiritual giant. You know all the right answers, you know how to pray nicely when someone asks you to, you give your contributions, and your name is on all the right committees. You have **the name of being alive**.

But when the front door closes behind you and no one is watching, there is no prayer life, no hunger for God's Word, no tears over sin and no dependence on the Holy Spirit. We live off spiritual experiences from ten or

twenty years ago – just as Sardis lived off the glory of King Croesus's day. Our works look impressive to people, but before God they are not "complete" – empty shells without a beating heart of faith.

Why do we fall asleep so easily, like the guards on the cliffs of Sardis? Because we think we are safe. We think: *"I've been baptised, haven't I? I gave my heart to the Lord years ago, I'm not a bad person."* And while we rest on our reputation, the enemy climbs over our walls by the unguarded paths of pride, lukewarmness and spiritual laziness.

Hear the Lord's wake-up call today: **Wake up!** Do not be content with a second-hand faith or a fine religious façade. He who holds the fullness of the Holy Spirit in his hand stands ready today to breathe his breath of life once more into the dying parts of your spiritual life.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If you were to compare honestly what other people think of your spiritual life (your "name") with what your relationship with God really looks like in secret, how wide would the gap between the two be?
- Are you living off old spiritual memories and victories from your past, or are you experiencing a fresh, living dependence on the Holy Spirit today?
- Which spiritual discipline or conviction in your life is like what "was about to die" (v. 2), and needs you to wake up today and deliberately strengthen it again?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, you hold the sevenfold fullness of the Holy Spirit in your hand. Today I bow before you with my heart laid bare. You are not deceived by my outward religious show or by the good opinion others may have of me.*

Forgive me for every time I cared more about my reputation before people than about the real state of my heart before you. Forgive me for spiritual sleep, for prayers that have become empty words, and for works I do out of habit without the power of your Spirit. Shake me awake today, Lord! Breathe new life by your Holy Spirit into every part of my faith that is bleeding to death.

Wash my clothes white in your blood and give me the grace to walk unstained through this world. Thank you for the unshakeable promise that my name is written safely in your book of life. Let my life today not be merely a dead name, but a living testimony to your resurrection power. Amen.

DAY 8

Philadelphia – Little Power, but an Open Door No One Can Shut

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 3:7–13

7 And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write: The Holy One, the
True One, who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut,
and who shuts and no one opens, says this: 8 I know your works – look, I
have set before you an open door, which no one is able to shut – that you
have little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied
my name. 9 Look, I will give you some from the synagogue of Satan, who
say they are Jews and are not, but are lying – look, I will make them
come and bow down before your feet, and they will know that I have
loved you. 10 Because you have kept the word of my endurance, I too will
keep you from the hour of testing that is about to come on the whole
world, to test those who live on the earth. 11 I am coming soon. Hold fast
to what you have, so that no one takes your crown. 12 The one who con-
quers, I will make him a pillar in the temple of my God, and he will
never go out of it again. And I will write on him the name of my God and
the name of the city of my God, the new Jerusalem, which comes down
out of heaven from my God, and my new name. 13 Whoever has an ear
should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

About 45 kilometres south-east of Sardis lies the youngest of the seven cities: **Philadelphia** (today's Alaşehir in Turkey). The city was founded in the second century BC by King Attalus II of Pergamum, who was so loyal to his brother Eumenes that he was given the nickname *Philadelphos* (meaning: he who loves his brother) – hence the name **brotherly love**.

Philadelphia was built for two specific reasons. First, it was a strategic **gateway city** (an "open door") to the central plateau of Phrygia. It is often said that its founders wanted Philadelphia to serve as a "missionary city" for Greek culture and language, to hellenise the interior. Second, it lay on a fertile volcanic plain that was ideal for vineyards – but this same geological setting came at a terrifying price: **earthquakes**. In AD 17 Philadelphia (together with Sardis and other cities) was struck by a devastating earthquake. For years afterwards aftershocks shook the city; the ancient geographer Strabo writes that Philadelphia's walls were constantly cracking and that few people lived in the city itself – most lived outside in the countryside. They knew what it feels like when the ground gives way under your feet and you have to flee again and again.

Apart from Smyrna, Philadelphia is the only other church against which Jesus speaks **not a single word of criticism or rebuke**.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into a few Greek key words in the text:

- ***Alēthinos* – ἀληθινός (true / genuine):** In verse 7 Jesus calls himself "the Holy One, the True One". In John's writings the two words overlap, but where *alēthēs* – ἀληθής often describes someone who speaks the truth (does not lie), *alēthinos* often stresses **what is genuine, authentic and real** (as opposed to a counterfeit or a shadow). Over against the hypocritical religion of their opponents, Jesus is the one true God.
- ***Mikran dynamin* – μικρὰν δύναμιν (little power):** When Jesus says in verse 8 "that you have little power", this is not a rebuke for weak faith. It describes their social standing and their small numbers. The church was small, poor, without political influence and without anyone powerful in its ranks.

- **Stylos – στῦλος (pillar):** In verse 12 Jesus promises to make the conqueror a *stylos* (a supporting pillar) in the temple of God. For people living in an earthquake zone, where huge stone columns regularly toppled, the picture of an unshakeable pillar in God's eternal temple was the ultimate symbol of lasting stability and security.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This tender and encouraging letter reveals four great theological truths:

1. **Jesus holds supreme authority over access to God's kingdom (vv. 7–8):** Jesus quotes directly from Isaiah 22:22, where Eliakim receives the key of the house of David – the palace and treasury of King Hezekiah. In Philadelphia the local Jewish synagogue had probably excluded the Jewish Christians and slammed the synagogue door in their faces (cf. v. 9). They claimed that these believers now stood outside God's covenant and kingdom. It is as if Jesus answers: *"Do not let closed human doors trouble you. I hold the key of David! I open to you the door to the Father's heart and the door for the ministry of the gospel, and no synagogue, emperor or demon can shut what I have opened."*
2. **Human weakness that clings to God's word is unstoppable (v. 8):** In the eyes of the world Philadelphia had "little power" (*mikran dynamin*). They had no mega-buildings, no big budgets and no high-profile leaders. But they did two things that count in heaven: they **kept his word** (lived it out in obedience) and **did not deny his name.** God is not looking for our impressive abilities; he is looking for our availability and faithfulness. His power is made perfect precisely in our weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9).
3. **Faithfulness today guarantees God's keeping in tomorrow's crisis (vv. 9–10):** Jesus promises two wonderful outcomes. First, their fiercest opponents will one day have to acknowledge that God has deeply loved this despised little group of believers (cf. Isaiah 60:14). Second, because they have kept "the word of my endurance" – Jesus' call to endure patiently – he will keep them "from the hour of testing" (*tērēsō se ek* –

τηρήσω σε ἐκ – to keep safe through the danger or out of it) that is about to come on the whole world, "to test those who live on the earth". The preposition *ek* – ἐκ means "out of". It does not necessarily mean that they will be spared that hour; it can just as well mean that he keeps them through it and brings them out of it. Jesus uses the same words in his prayer in John 17:15: not that the Father should take his disciples out of the world, but that he should "keep them from" the evil one. Whether the world around them shakes or not, their souls are untouchable in his hand.

4. **From earthquake refugees to eternal pillars with a threefold name (v. 12):** When Emperor Tiberius helped to rebuild Philadelphia after the earthquake of AD 17, the city out of gratitude changed its name for a time to *Neokaisareia* (meaning: the new city of Caesar), and later, under Emperor Vespasian, took yet another imperial name. It is as if Jesus says to his children in such an unstable city: *"In my kingdom you will never again have to flee from an earthquake ('he will never go out of it again'). You will be firm pillars. And I do not engrave on you the name of a changeable emperor, but a threefold eternal identity: the name of my God (you are his own), the name of the new Jerusalem (your eternal citizenship), and my own new name."*

Living It Out

How often do we feel like the church in Philadelphia today! You look at the huge challenges in your family, your workplace or your community, then you look at your own resources and think: *"Lord, I just have too little strength. I'm too ordinary, too tired, too insignificant to make a difference."*

On top of that you may already know the pain of doors slammed in your face – a job opportunity that fell through because of your integrity, a relationship in which you were rejected, or a dream that lies in pieces.

Philadelphia brings you indescribable comfort today: **Your "little power" is no obstacle to the One who holds the key of David!** When people slam a door in your face because you stay faithful to Jesus, the King of kings stands ready to open a door before you that no human power can push shut. It is an open door of intimate access to God's throne of grace, and an open door of opportunities to let his light shine exactly where he has placed you.

Perhaps today it feels as if "the earth is shaking" under your feet – financially, emotionally or physically. Everything that looked so strong on earth is cracking like Philadelphia's walls. Do not lose heart. "Hold fast to what you have" (v. 11). Stay faithful to his Word in the little things. Your security does not lie in earthly walls that can fall down, but in the promise that you are an unshakeable pillar in God's eternal house, and that the King has written his own name on your heart.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you feel overwhelmed at the moment by your own "little power" in a particular area of your life? How does it change your attitude to know that Jesus sees your very smallness and wants to work through it?
- Are you staring so hard at a door that has been slammed shut in your life that you may be missing the "open door" of service and faith that Jesus has opened right in front of you?
- Where in your life are you looking for stability and a "name" in worldly things that can collapse like Philadelphia's buildings, instead of resting in the fact that Christ has written his name on you?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, you are the Holy One and the True One – the only one who is truly genuine and trustworthy in a world full of pretence. I thank you that today you hold the key of David in your pierced hand. You know my life; you*

see how often I feel that I have too little strength for the demands and storms of each day. Thank you that you do not reject me because of my weakness, but that your power is made perfect in my frailty.

Help me to stop grieving over the doors that people or circumstances have slammed shut in front of me, and give me eyes to see the open door you have set before me. Give me the grace to cling to your Word through thick and thin and never to deny your name.

When everything around me shakes as in an earthquake, anchor my soul in the knowledge that I belong to you, that I am a citizen of the new Jerusalem, and that you love me with an everlasting love. Amen.

DAY 9

Laodicea – The Danger of Lukewarm Faith and the King Who Knocks at the Door

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 3:14–22

14 And to the angel of the church in Laodicea write: The Amen, the faithful and true witness, the beginning of God's creation, says this: 15 I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. I wish you were cold or hot! 16 So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I am about to vomit you out of my mouth. 17 For you say: I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing – and you do not know that it is you who are wretched and pitiable and poor and blind and naked. 18 I advise you to buy from me gold refined by fire, so that you may become rich, and white clothes to put on, so that the shame of your nakedness may not be exposed, and salve to put on your eyes, so that you may see. 19 All those I love, I reprove and discipline. So be zealous and repent. 20 Look, I am standing at the door and knocking. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. 21 The one who conquers, I will give him the right to sit with me on my throne, just as I too conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne. 22 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we reach the seventh and last city on the ancient postal route, in the Lycus valley: **Laodicea** (near modern Denizli in Turkey). Laodicea was the richest and most self-sufficient city in the region. When a devastating

earthquake struck the valley in AD 60, Laodicea, according to the Roman historian Tacitus (*Annals* 14.27), rose again from the ruins from its own resources, without any help from Rome.

The city was famous for three great industries – and in verses 17 and 18 Jesus uses all three to expose its spiritual poverty:

1. **Financial wealth and banking:** Laodicea was an important centre for money-changing, a city of banks and riches.
2. **Textiles and clothing:** According to Strabo the region was famous for sheep with soft, glossy black wool, from which expensive garments were woven.
3. **A medical school and eye-salve:** Near Laodicea there was a well-known medical school, and many interpreters link the city with "Phrygian powder" – an eye remedy (*kollourion* – κολλούριον) mentioned by ancient writers.

Yet this immensely wealthy city had one great weakness: **its water supply**. About ten kilometres to the north, across the valley, lay **Hierapolis** (modern Pamukkale), famous for its healing, mineral-rich **hot** springs. About sixteen kilometres to the east lay **Colossae**, known for its cold, refreshing water. Laodicea itself had no good springs and had to bring its water through a stone pipeline from springs to the south; the remains of the pipes are still thickly coated with lime deposits today. Many interpreters think that by the time the water reached Laodicea it was no longer hot enough to heal, nor cold enough to quench thirst. It was **lukewarm** and full of lime – water you would want to spit out. We cannot say for certain that Jesus had this very water in mind, but the picture would not have been strange to the first readers.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at some key words of the Greek text:

- **Ho *Amēn* – ὁ Ἀμήν (the Amen) and *archē* – ἀρχή (beginning / origin):** In verse 14 Jesus calls himself "the Amen" (cf. Isaiah 65:16 – the God of the Amen, the God of truth). He is the final, unshakeable guarantee of every promise of God. When he calls himself "the beginning of God's creation" (cf. Colossians 1:15–18 – a letter that, according to Colossians 4:16, was also to be read in Laodicea!), *archē* does not mean that Jesus was the first thing created, but that he is the **active Origin, Source and Ruler** of the whole creation.
- ***Chliaros* – χλιαρός (lukewarm) and *emeō* – ἐμέω (vomit):** The word *chliaros* occurs only here in the New Testament and means lukewarm. The reaction to it is *emeō* – which literally means to **vomit, to throw up.**
- ***Zēleuō* – ζηλεύω (be zealous):** In verse 19 this word comes from *zēlos* – ζῆλος (zeal), which is often linked with the word for "hot / boiling" (*zestos* – ζεστός) in verse 15. Jesus is saying, as it were: *"Stop being lukewarm; start boiling with zeal again, and repent!"*

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This gripping letter opens up four important theological truths:

1. **Spiritual uselessness disgusts the Lord (vv. 15–16):** For centuries people have thought that "hot" means spiritually on fire and "cold" means far from God. But if we read it against the background of Hierapolis (hot, healing baths) and Colossae (cold, refreshing drinking water), as many interpreters do today, then **both hot and cold are positive and useful!** A church that is spiritually "hot" brings healing to broken people; a church that is "cold" brings refreshment to a thirsty world. But Laodicea had become like its city water: lukewarm, fruitless and useless. It healed no one and quenched no one's thirst.
2. **Material prosperity often breeds spiritual self-deception (v. 17):** Notice the sharp contrast between Smyrna (Day 4) and Laodicea. Smyrna thought itself desperately poor, but Jesus says: "but you are rich" (2:9). Laodicea boasts: "I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I

need nothing." In the Greek the pronoun *sy* – σύ ("you") is emphatic, and the article stands before "wretched" (*ho talaipōros* – ὁ ταλαίπωρος): "you do not know that it is **you** who are wretched" – literally: the wretched one – "and pitiable and poor and blind and naked." Their greatest problem was not only their spiritual bankruptcy but their **blindness** to it. When our bank accounts are full and life is comfortable, we easily forget how desperately we need God.

3. **True spiritual wealth is only "bought" from Christ's hand of grace (v. 18):** How does a beggar who has nothing buy anything? As Isaiah 55:1 invites: "Come, buy without silver and without payment!" Jesus gently mocks Laodicea's three great industries:
    - Instead of the world's gold, seek **gold refined by fire** – tested, genuine faith that will endure into eternity (1 Peter 1:7).
    - Instead of Laodicea's showy black woollen garments, put on the **white clothes** of Christ's imputed righteousness to cover your guilt and shame.
    - Instead of Phrygian eye powder, let the Holy Spirit anoint your eyes with heavenly **salve**, so that you can see yourself and God truly again.
4. **Discipline and the knock at the door flow from Christ's unquenchable love (vv. 19–20):** After speaking the hardest words of all seven letters, Jesus opens his heart: "All those I love, I reprove and discipline" (*phileō* – φιλέω – tender, friendly affection). The most shocking picture in all of Revelation 1–3 is verse 20: the Head of the church stands **outside** the door of his own church! They were so busy inside with their meetings, their wealth and their religious programmes that they had not even noticed that Jesus was shut out. And yet he does not break the door down; he stands patiently and knocks. To the individual ("if *anyone* hears my voice") who opens, he promises to eat with him (*deipneō* –

δειπνέω, from *deipnon*, the main evening meal, at which guests sat at table for hours in deep fellowship) – and one day to sit with him on his throne (v. 21).

Living It Out

If there is one letter that strikes home in the modern Western church and our own comfortable lives, it is the letter to Laodicea. We have insurance for everything, medical cover, catering, entertainment on demand and comfortable homes. And without our noticing, our culture's attitude to life whispers its way into our spiritual life: "*I can manage on my own. I need nothing.*"

We pray only when a crisis hits that we cannot solve with a credit card or a doctor. We are not against God, but neither do we burn with passion for him. We are moderate, decent, balanced – and spiritually **lukewarm**. We adapt so seamlessly to the temperature around us that we quench no one's spiritual thirst and lead no one to healing at the cross.

But today, listen beyond the sharp diagnosis to the wonder of verse 20. However long you have relied on your own strength and prosperity, and even if you have pushed Jesus to the outer edge of your daily decisions – **he has not walked away.** He stands today at the door of your heart and your life, and he knocks through his Word and through the conviction of his Spirit.

He is not after your money or your impressive CV; he wants to come in to you and sit at your table. To open the door means letting go of your self-sufficiency, honestly admitting your spiritual poverty, and giving him once more the place of honour at the head of your life's table.

The seven letters end with a throne: the one who conquered sits with his Father on his throne (v. 21). Tomorrow another door opens for John – "a door stood open in heaven" (4:1) – and he is allowed to see who really sits on that throne.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is your life at the moment like Hierapolis's hot water (bringing comfort and healing) and Colossae's cold water (quenching spiritual thirst) for the people around you, or has your faith adjusted to the lukewarm temperature of your surroundings?
- In which area of your life have material security, knowledge or success perhaps made you feel without realising it: "*I need nothing*", so that your daily dependence in prayer has dried up?
- In which particular room of your life (your finances, your marriage, the way you spend your time or your secret thoughts) is Jesus still standing outside, knocking to be let in?

Prayer

Lord Jesus, you are the Amen, the faithful and true Witness, on whose word I can build my whole eternity. Today I bow before you in deep humility. Forgive me my lukewarmness. Forgive me for the times I grew so comfortable in my earthly blessings and my own abilities that I thought I could handle life on my own. Without you I am poor, blind and naked.

I come to you today with empty hands, to buy from you without money and without price: refine my faith like gold, clothe me in the white clothes of your righteousness, and anoint my eyes with your Holy Spirit so that I may see you and myself rightly again. Thank you that you love me too much to leave me in my lukewarm state.

I hear your voice and your knock at my door today, Lord. I open every room of my heart wide to you. Come in, be the Lord of my house, and sit at table with me. Let my heart boil again with zeal and love for you alone. Amen.

DAY 10

A Door Open in Heaven: The Throne Behind the Curtain

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 4:1–11

1 After this I looked, and look, a door stood open in heaven, and the first
voice, which I had heard speaking with me like a trumpet, said, "Come
up here, and I will show you what must take place after this." 2 At once I
was in the Spirit. And look, a throne stood in heaven, and on the throne
someone was seated. 3 And the one seated there looked like jasper and
carnelian, and around the throne was a rainbow that looked like an
emerald. 4 And around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the
thrones sat twenty-four elders, dressed in white clothes, with golden
crowns on their heads. 5 And from the throne come lightning and
sounds and thunder, and seven torches of fire are burning before the
throne; these are the seven spirits of God. 6 And before the throne there
was something like a sea of glass, like crystal. And in the middle of the
throne and around the throne were four living creatures, full of eyes in
front and behind. 7 The first living creature was like a lion, the second
living creature was like a young bull, the third living creature had a face
like a human being, and the fourth living creature was like a flying ea-
gle. 8 And the four living creatures, each of them with six wings, are full
of eyes all around and within. And day and night they never rest, saying:

Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God, the Almighty,
who was and who is and who is coming.

9 And whenever the living creatures give glory and honour and thanks
to the one seated on the throne, who lives for ever and ever, 10 the
twenty-four elders fall down before the one seated on the throne and
worship the one who lives for ever and ever, and they cast their crowns
before the throne, saying:

11 Worthy are you, our Lord and God,
to receive the glory and the honour and the power,
for you created all things,
and by your will they existed and were created.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we stood in Laodicea, where the risen Christ stands outside the door of his own church and knocks (3:20). Today the picture is turned round: "After this I looked, and look, a door stood open in heaven." The one who wanted to come in at Laodicea now invites John to come in to him: "Come up here, and I will show you what must take place after this."

Think of the first readers: seven small churches in the Roman province of Asia, probably in the reign of the emperor Domitian (AD 81–96). In their cities Rome's throne was visible everywhere – temples for the emperor, his image on coins and in market squares. Pergamum was the place "where the throne of Satan is" (2:13). Anyone who saw the world only from the street could come to just one conclusion: Rome rules.

Then Revelation 4 draws back the curtain. That is what *apokalypsis* (1:1) means: an unveiling of what is happening behind the scenes. It may sound almost like a conspiracy theory – a hidden power struggle behind the official version that the emperor is lord – but it is the opposite: God himself opens the door, not to make us suspicious and afraid, but so that we may worship and endure. And the first thing John sees behind the curtain is not a timetable or a battlefield, but a throne: "and on the throne someone was seated."

John stands in a long line here. Whenever God's people suffered under earthly thrones, he drew back the curtain of his heavenly council a little way. Job sees only his losses, but the reader sees the heavenly council, where the accuser can do nothing without God's permission (Job 1–2). King Ahab sits on his throne in Samaria, but the prophet Micaiah son of Imlah sees the LORD on his throne with all the host of heaven around him (1 Kings 22:10, 19). The message is the same every time: the thrones of the earth do not have the last word.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **A door standing open (*thyra ēneōgmenē* – θύρα ἠνεῳγμένη, v. 1):** The verb form describes a door that has been opened and stays open. John does not force heaven open; God has already done it.
- **What must take place (*ha dei genesthai* – ἃ δεῖ γενέσθαι, v. 1):** The language of Daniel 2:28–29. *Dei* ("must") is not about a calendar but about God's plan: history is neither blind chance nor the whim of emperors.
- **Throne (*thronos* – θρόνος):** Fourteen times in eleven verses. Everything stands *around*, *before* or *in the middle of* the throne: it is the centre of reality.
- **Worthy are you, our Lord and God (*Axios ei, ho kyrios kai ho theos hēmōn* –Ἄξιος εἶ, ὁ κύριος καὶ ὁ θεὸς ἡμῶν, v. 11):** According to the Roman writer Suetonius (*Domitian* 13), Domitian wished to be addressed as "our lord and god". Many interpreters therefore hear in the elders' song a quiet, courageous counter-voice. And the reason for their praise is not power but creation: *hoti sy ektisas ta panta* (ὅτι σὺ ἔκτισας τὰ πάντα), "for you created all things".

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The throne in heaven stands firm, even when the earth shakes.** Everything that happens in the rest of the book – the seals, the trumpets, the bowls – comes from this throne. For people who saw the emperor's image on their coins every day, this was the best news of all: Rome is great, but Rome is not seated on the throne.
2. **What happens on earth is understood from the hidden scene.** Satan may have a throne in Pergamum, but not in heaven, and he can do nothing that God does not permit. That does not make suffering hurt less, but it is never outside God's hand.
3. **The whole creation worships the Creator.** The four living creatures recall Ezekiel's cherubim (Ezekiel 1:10; 10:14–15) and the seraphim of Isaiah 6:2–3; many interpreters think the lion, the bull, the human be-

ing and the eagle represent the whole of living creation. The twenty-four elders are probably the whole people of God – twelve tribes and twelve apostles (cf. 21:12–14) – though others think of angelic beings. The Bible's story begins with the Creator (Genesis 1), and it ends at the same throne: "Look, I am making all things new" (21:5).

4. **The crowns go back to the throne – and Christ shares that throne.** The elders cast their crowns (*stephanoi*, victors' wreaths) before the throne. Everything they have received, they give back. And at the end of the seven letters Jesus said that he "sat down with my Father on his throne" (3:21). Tomorrow we shall see who stands in the middle of this throne.

Living It Out

Most of us live like the believers on the streets of those cities. We see the news, the budget, the diagnosis, and every day we hear an official version of who is in charge: the market, politics, the employer, or simply our own fears. Revelation 4 does not deny that these thrones exist. It simply puts them where they belong – far below the throne on which someone is seated.

That is why worship is not an escape from reality but the most honest look at it. When a small congregation sings on Sunday, it joins a song that goes on "day and night", even when you feel nothing of it. For the first readers it took courage to sing "Worthy are you, our Lord and God" in a city where the emperor claimed the same honour. For us it is no different: what you call "worthy" decides where your time, your money and your heart go.

And then there are the crowns. Each of us holds something tightly: a title, an achievement, our reputation, even our own hard-won faithfulness. The elders show us the freedom of laying it down. You do not have to keep your own throne standing; there is already one who reigns, and the door to him stands open.

Start tomorrow at the open door, before you even unlock your phone: read Revelation 4:8–11, name one "throne" that frightens you at the moment, and deliberately lay it before the throne on which he sits.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which earthly "throne" seems to rule your life at the moment – a deadline, money, an illness, someone's opinion? What changes when you look at it through the open door of verse 1?
- Does your day usually begin with the news or with the throne (v. 2)?
- Which "crown" are you holding so tightly that you would find it hard to cast it before the throne (v. 10)?
- In your decisions about time, money and attention, what do you actually call "worthy" (v. 11)?

Prayer

Holy Lord God, the Almighty, who was and who is and who is coming: today I stand with John at the open door and look up to your throne. You created all things, and by your will I exist. You alone are worthy – not the rulers of this world, not my fears, and not I myself.

I confess that I live as if the thrones of this earth had the last word, and that I cling to my little crowns as if my life depended on them. Teach me to lay them down before you.

Thank you that you have opened the door, and that the Lord Jesus, who sits with you on your throne, invites me to come in. Give me eyes of faith to see behind the curtain, and a heart that worships with heaven, so that today I may live faithfully and without fear. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 11

The Lion Who Is a Lamb: The Key to Revelation

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 5:1–14

1 And I saw in the right hand of the one seated on the throne a scroll
written inside and on the back, sealed with seven seals. 2 And I saw a
mighty angel proclaiming with a loud voice, "Who is worthy to open the
scroll and to break its seals?" 3 And no one in heaven or on earth or un-
der the earth was able to open the scroll or to look into it. 4 And I wept
and wept, because no one was found worthy to open the scroll or to look
into it. 5 And one of the elders says to me, "Do not weep. Look, the Lion
from the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so that he
can open the scroll and its seven seals."

6 And I saw in the middle of the throne and of the four living creatures,
and in the middle of the elders, a Lamb standing, as though slaugh-
tered. He had seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of
God sent out into all the earth. 7 And he came and took it out of the right
hand of the one seated on the throne. 8 And when he had taken the
scroll, the four living creatures and the twenty-four elders fell down be-
fore the Lamb, each holding a lyre and golden bowls full of incense,
which are the prayers of the saints. 9 And they sing a new song:

Worthy are you to take the scroll
and to open its seals,
for you were slaughtered,
and by your blood you purchased people for God
from every tribe and language and people and nation,
10 and you made them a kingdom and priests to our God,
and they reign on the earth.

11 And I looked, and I heard the voice of many angels around the throne
and the living creatures and the elders, and their number was ten thou-
sands of ten thousands and thousands of thousands, 12 saying with a
loud voice:

Worthy is the Lamb who was slaughtered
to receive the power and wealth and wisdom and strength
and honour and glory and praise.

13 And every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the sea, and everything in them, I heard saying:

To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb
be the praise and the honour and the glory and the might
for ever and ever.

14 And the four living creatures said, "Amen." And the elders fell down and worshipped.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the right hand of the Creator seated on the throne, John now sees something on which everything hangs: a scroll, "written inside and on the back, sealed with seven seals". It recalls the scroll Ezekiel received, also written on both sides (Ezekiel 2:9–10), and the book Daniel was told to seal until the time of the end (Daniel 12:4). The scroll probably stands for God's purpose for history – his judgement on evil and the coming of his kingdom. As long as it stays sealed, everything stands still.

Then the question rings through heaven: "Who is worthy to open the scroll and to break its seals?" And no one – not in heaven, not on earth, not under the earth – is able to do it. John weeps. These are the tears of every believer in Asia who wonders whether the suffering of Smyrna and the blood of the witnesses who lost their lives have any meaning.

One of the elders comforts him: "Do not weep. Look, the Lion from the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered." Every Jewish reader knew these titles. Jacob called Judah a young lion, from whose tribe the sceptre would never depart (Genesis 49:9–10), and Isaiah spoke of the shoot from the stump of Jesse, the Root to whom the nations would turn (Isaiah 11:1, 10). The Lion is the Messiah, the king many expected to crush Israel's enemies.

And then John looks – and sees a Lamb. "And I saw in the middle of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in the middle of the elders, a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered." Here lies the key to the whole book. John **hears** "Lion", but he **sees** a slaughtered Lamb – and the seeing interprets the hearing. The Lion of Judah does not conquer by tearing apart, but by being torn. God's power looks like the cross.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Lamb (*arnion* – ἀρνίον, v. 6):** John uses this word 29 times in the book, and with one exception (the beast of 13:11) only for Christ. Behind the image stand the Passover lamb of Exodus 12, whose blood set Israel free from Egypt, and the Servant of the LORD who was led like a lamb to the slaughter (Isaiah 53:7).
- **As though slaughtered (*hōs esphagmenon* – ὡς ἐσφαγμένον, v. 6):** The verb form describes something that has happened and leaves its mark. The Lamb is *standing* – he is alive – but he still bears the wounds. The risen Christ has not left his cross behind; he reigns as the Crucified One.
- **Has conquered (*enikēsen* – ἐνίκησεν, v. 5):** It is the same verb as in the promise to every church: "The one who conquers …" (2:7–3:21). Christ has already conquered, and his people conquer in the same way as he did (3:21).
- **Seven horns and seven eyes (v. 6):** In the Old Testament a horn is an image of strength (Deuteronomy 33:17), and the seven eyes come from Zechariah 4:10. The Lamb who looks weak has perfect power and sees everything.
- **Purchased (*ēgorasas* – ἠγόρασας, v. 9):** The word of the market, which could also describe the buying of slaves. By his blood the Lamb "purchased people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation". And verse 10 says, in the present tense, "and they reign on the earth" – not one day, but already now.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The Lamb is the key to Scripture and to Revelation.** Israel was looking for a Lion, and God sent a Lamb. This does not mean the promises were falsified; it shows where they were really heading. That is why we read every mighty, even terrifying image still to come in the book through this one: from now on the throne is "the throne of God and of the Lamb" (22:3).

2. **Only the Crucified One can open history.** No one else is worthy. The meaning of history does not lie in Rome's hands or in the hands of the powerful of our day, but in the hands of the one who died for the world. The cross is not an interruption of God's plan; it is the opening of it.

3. **The Lamb receives the worship that belongs to God.** Yesterday the elders sang, "Worthy are you, our Lord and God." Today they sing the same words to the Lamb: "Worthy are you to take the scroll." And at the end the whole creation sings: "To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb." Whoever worships the Lamb is not worshipping a second god, but the one God.

4. **The Lamb has made a new people – a kingdom and priests.** What God promised Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:6) comes true for people from every nation. They reign, but like their King: not by violence, but by witness and self-giving love. So Revelation will later say of the accuser: "And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb" (12:11).

Living It Out

We all want a Lion. When work wears us down, when our children get hurt, when the church is mocked in society, we long for power that puts things right quickly – a winning argument, influence, a God who simply flattens our enemies. It is not wrong to long for God to intervene. But Revelation 5 asks us to look at what God actually sent. The Lion of Judah conquers as a Lamb, and he invites us to conquer in the same way.

So the places where you feel weak or overlooked are not necessarily places where God is absent. It is often there that his power looks most clearly like the cross: in patience that does not hit back, in forgiveness that costs something, in faithfulness that no one notices.

Look, too, at the golden bowls full of incense, "which are the prayers of the saints" (v. 8; cf. Psalm 141:2). The prayers you have prayed for years, which sometimes seemed to vanish into thin air, have not been thrown away. They stand before the throne, in the hands of those who worship the Lamb.

And if, like John, you have wept because it seems that no one can open up your situation – hear the elder's word: "Do not weep." The scroll is in the right hands.

This week, choose one place where you would love to "roar" – a conflict, an injustice, a frustration – and ask: how would the Lamb conquer here? Then take one small step of self-giving love in that direction.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which "scroll" in your life seems closed and sealed at the moment, so that you want to weep with John (v. 4)?
- Where do you long for a Lion rather than the Lamb – for power that sorts things out rather than love that costs something (vv. 5–6)?
- Do you really believe that your prayers are kept before the throne (v. 8)? How would that change your prayer life?
- What does it mean for you to belong already to a kingdom and priests from every nation (vv. 9–10)?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, Lion of Judah and Lamb of God, you are worthy. You were slaughtered, and by your blood you purchased people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation – me too. With the angels and the*

whole creation I bring praise and honour and glory today to you and to the one seated on the throne.

Forgive me that I so often want a Lion to sort out my affairs, and have so little desire to follow the Lamb. Forgive my impatience, my harsh words and my hunger for power. You did not conquer by hitting back, but by giving yourself.

Thank you that the scroll of history, and of my life too, is in your hands, and that my prayers are kept before your throne. Teach me to conquer your way today: with faithfulness, patience and love that costs something. In your name, Amen.

DAY 12

The Lamb Opens the Seals: Who Can Stand?

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 6:1–17

1 And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals, and I heard
one of the four living creatures say with a voice like thunder, "Come!"
2 And I looked, and there was a white horse, and its rider had a bow; and
a crown was given to him, and he went out conquering and to conquer.

3 And when he opened the second seal, I heard the second living crea-
ture say, "Come!" 4 And another horse came out, fiery red; and its rider
was allowed to take peace from the earth, so that people would slaugh-
ter one another; and a great sword was given to him.

5 And when he opened the third seal, I heard the third living creature
say, "Come!" And I looked, and there was a black horse, and its rider had
a pair of scales in his hand. 6 And I heard something like a voice in the
middle of the four living creatures, saying, "A quart of wheat for a
denarius, and three quarts of barley for a denarius, but do not harm the
oil and the wine!"

7 And when he opened the fourth seal, I heard the voice of the fourth
living creature say, "Come!" 8 And I looked, and there was a pale green
horse, and the name of its rider was Death, and Hades followed with
him. And they were given authority over a fourth of the earth, to kill
with sword and with famine and with pestilence and by the wild beasts
of the earth.

9 And when he opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar the souls of
those who had been slaughtered because of the word of God and be-
cause of the testimony they had. 10 And they cried out with a loud voice,
"How long, holy and true Master, will you not judge and avenge our
blood on those who live on the earth?" 11 And each of them was given a
white robe, and they were told to rest a little longer, until their fellow
servants and their brothers and sisters, who were about to be killed as
they themselves had been, were complete in number.

12 And I saw when he opened the sixth seal: there was a great earth-
quake, and the sun became black like sackcloth made of hair, and the
whole moon became like blood, 13 and the stars of the sky fell to the

earth, as a fig tree drops its unripe figs when it is shaken by a strong wind. [14] And the sky receded like a scroll being rolled up, and every mountain and island was moved from its place. [15] And the kings of the earth and the nobles and the generals and the rich and the powerful and every slave and free person hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains, [16] and they say to the mountains and the rocks, "Fall on us and hide us from the face of the one seated on the throne and from the wrath of the Lamb, [17] for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?"

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we saw the Lamb take the scroll from the hand of the one seated on the throne, while the whole of heaven sang. Today he begins to open it. "And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals." What follows are some of the best-known and most feared images in the Bible: four horses and their riders, souls under the altar, and a sky rolled up like a scroll.

The images do not come out of nowhere. Zechariah saw horses of different colours, sent out by the LORD to patrol the earth (Zechariah 1:8–11; 6:1–8). And Ezekiel names four judgements that God brings on a land that has turned away: sword, famine, wild beasts and pestilence (Ezekiel 14:21) – exactly the list of verse 8. The first readers did not read this as fantasy. They knew war (the Jewish War and the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70, the civil war of AD 69), they knew famine (Acts 11:28), and on Rome's eastern frontier the Parthians, mounted archers, were a constant threat.

How do we read these seals? They are not a timetable of disasters that will begin only at the end of history. Jesus himself said that wars, famines and earthquakes would mark the whole time until his return, but that this is not yet the end (Mark 13:7–8). The first four seals show the world as it is between Christ's first and second coming – and who holds it in his hand.

(Other interpreters, especially futurists, place the seals in a future period just before the return of Christ.) Only the sixth seal takes us right up to the great day itself.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEN

- **Come! (*Erchou* –Ἔρχου, vv. 1, 3, 5, 7):** Each time one of the living creatures at the throne summons the rider. The horses do not charge out of their own accord; they come only when the Lamb opens a seal and heaven calls.
- **Was given (*edothē* – ἐδόθη, vv. 2, 4, 8, 11):** The crown, the sword and the authority are *given* to the riders. The passive points to God as the one who permits – and limits. The black horse may not harm "the oil and the wine", and Death is given authority "over a fourth of the earth", not over the whole earth.
- **Slaughtered (*esphagmenōn* – ἐσφαγμένων, v. 9):** The souls under the altar are those "who had been slaughtered because of the word of God". It is the same word as for the Lamb (5:6). The witnesses share the lot of their Lord. In the temple the blood of the sacrifices was poured out at the base of the altar (Leviticus 4:7); so their lives have been offered to God.
- **Master (*despotēs* – δεσπότης, v. 10):** The word for a lord with full authority over his household and his servants. The martyrs are not crying out into emptiness; they call to the one who is truly in charge.
- **Who can stand? (*tis dynatai stathēnai* – τίς δύναται σταθῆναι, v. 17):** The question of Nahum 1:6: before his fury who can stand?

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The Lamb holds the seals in his hand – even in a world full of war and hunger.** The conqueror on the white horse, the sword, the costly bread and death are real and terrible. (Some see the first rider as Christ himself, since he rides a white horse in 19:11; but because he rides out

with the other three, many read him as conquest and war, perhaps even as a counterfeit of Christ.) Yet none of the riders rides out unless the Lamb opens a seal. History is not out of control.

2. **God hears the cry of his suffering people.** "How long, holy and true Master" is the prayer of Habakkuk ("How long, LORD, shall I cry for help", Habakkuk 1:2) and of the psalms (Psalm 79:5, 10). God does not rebuke them for it. He gives each of them "a white robe" and tells them "to rest a little longer". Their cause is not forgotten; it is simply not yet the end.

3. **The great day is coming, and no one can stand in their own strength.** The sixth seal uses the prophets' language for the day of the LORD: the sun black, the moon like blood, the sky rolled up like a scroll (Joel 2:31; Isaiah 34:4). Those who hide are the whole pyramid of Rome – kings, nobles, generals, the rich – but also "every slave and free person". They cry, as in Hosea 10:8, "Fall on us". Before the face of God there is no rank any more.

4. **The wrath of the Lamb is the wrath of the one who was slaughtered for the world.** It sounds like a contradiction, but it is both the most serious and the most hopeful word in the chapter. The Judge is the same one who gave his blood. And the question of verse 17 receives its answer tomorrow: a great crowd that no one could count, "standing before the throne and before the Lamb" (7:9).

Living It Out

We do not have to look far to see the four riders. The news is full of war, of prices that put bread beyond people's reach, of disease and death. That can paralyse us with fear, or send us searching for signs and dates to work out how near the end is. Revelation 6 gives a different answer: look at who opens the seals. The Lamb who was slaughtered for the world does not let chaos have the last word.

This also gives us the freedom to pray honestly. The souls under the altar are not polite and content; they cry, "How long?" Perhaps there is an injustice in your life that has gone on for years, a child living far from God, an illness that will not lift. You may cry it out before the throne. Your cry is not ignored, and the "little longer" has an end that God knows.

And then the great question: "who can stand?" Not the powerful with their caves and rocks, and not we with our good intentions. Only those who stand with the Lamb, who have washed their robes in his blood (7:14). You do not have to flee from the face of the one seated on the throne; in Christ you may run to him.

When you read the news this week, choose one place of war or hunger and pray for it – and say it aloud: the Lamb holds the seals in his hand.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which of the "riders" – war, economic pressure, illness, death – frightens you most at the moment (vv. 2–8)? What changes when you remember who opens the seals?
- What have you long been crying "How long?" about (v. 10)? Do you dare to lay it honestly before God?
- Where are you tempted to keep your witness quiet so that you need not pay the price of the souls under the altar (v. 9)?
- On whom or what are you relying to stand on the great day (v. 17)?

Prayer

> *Lamb of God, you alone are worthy to open the seals. The wars, the hunger and the death of this world frighten me, but none of it is outside your hands. You are the holy and true Master, and you know the end of every "little longer".*

I live so easily in fear, Lord, and I keep my faith quiet when witness would cost something. Hear the cry of my heart, and the cry of your children who suffer today because of the word of God. How long, Lord? I lay my questions before your throne.

Thank you that I need not hide on the great day, because you were slaughtered and my robes have been washed in your blood. Let me stand with you today, faithful and without fear, until I stand with the great crowd before the throne and before the Lamb. Amen.

DAY 13

Sealed on the Forehead: The Crowd No One Could Count

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 7:1–17

1 After this I saw four angels standing at the four corners of the earth,
holding back the four winds of the earth, so that no wind would blow
on the earth or on the sea or on any tree. 2 And I saw another angel com-
ing up from the rising of the sun, with the seal of the living God. And he
cried out with a loud voice to the four angels who had been allowed to
harm the earth and the sea, 3 saying, "Do not harm the earth or the sea
or the trees until we have sealed the servants of our God on their
foreheads."

4 And I heard the number of those who were sealed: a hundred and
forty-four thousand, sealed from every tribe of the people of Israel:
5 from the tribe of Judah twelve thousand sealed, from the tribe of
Reuben twelve thousand, from the tribe of Gad twelve thousand, 6 from
the tribe of Asher twelve thousand, from the tribe of Naphtali twelve
thousand, from the tribe of Manasseh twelve thousand, 7 from the tribe
of Simeon twelve thousand, from the tribe of Levi twelve thousand,
from the tribe of Issachar twelve thousand, 8 from the tribe of Zebulun
twelve thousand, from the tribe of Joseph twelve thousand, from the
tribe of Benjamin twelve thousand sealed.

9 After this I looked, and look, a great crowd that no one could count,
from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages, standing
before the throne and before the Lamb, dressed in white robes, with
palm branches in their hands. 10 And they cry out with a loud voice:

To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!

11 And all the angels stood around the throne and around the elders and
the four living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne
and worshipped God, 12 saying:

Amen! The praise and the glory and the wisdom
and the thanksgiving and the honour and the power and the strength
be to our God for ever and ever. Amen.

13 And one of the elders spoke up and said to me, "These who are dressed
in white robes – who are they, and where have they come from?" 14 And I
said to him, "My lord, you know." And he said to me: These are the ones
who are coming out of the great affliction; they have washed their robes
and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.

15 That is why they are before the throne of God
and serve him day and night in his temple,
and the one seated on the throne will spread his tent over them.
16 They will hunger no more and thirst no more,
and the sun will not strike them, nor any scorching heat,
17 for the Lamb in the middle of the throne will shepherd them
and lead them to springs of the water of life,
and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Chapter 6 ended with a question that echoes across the whole earth: "who can stand?" Kings and slaves hide in caves, and we expect the seventh seal to follow at once. But John holds the story back. Between the sixth and the seventh seal comes a pause, and in that pause the question receives its answer.

Four angels hold back the four winds of the earth. Then another angel comes up from the east "with the seal of the living God", and he cries out: "Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads." The storm must wait until God's people have been marked.

Every reader who knew the Old Testament would have thought here of the Passover night in Egypt. Before the last plague passes over the land, the blood of the lamb marks the doors of Israel, so that the destroyer passes them by (Exodus 12:13, 23). Later Ezekiel sees something similar: before judgement begins on Jerusalem, a man with a writing kit puts a

mark on the foreheads of all who sigh and groan over the abominations in the city (Ezekiel 9:4–6). Revelation takes up this line: what follows – the trumpets with plagues like those of Egypt – is a new exodus, not out of creation but out of the power of the world that opposes God. In cities where the emperor cult and the trade guilds asked every day whom you belonged to, this was a great comfort: God had already put his mark on them.

And then the same thing happens as in chapter 5. John **hears** a number: "a hundred and forty-four thousand, sealed from every tribe of the people of Israel", twelve thousand from each tribe. But when he looks, he **sees** "a great crowd that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages". As with the Lion and the Lamb (5:5–6), the seeing interprets the hearing. The whole Israel of God is a countless crowd from all the nations – the promise to Abraham of descendants as numerous as the stars that no one can count (Genesis 15:5), and of blessing for all the families of the earth (Genesis 12:3). (Other interpreters, especially dispensationalists, read the 144,000 literally as Jewish believers, distinct from the crowd; but the pattern of hearing and seeing makes it likely that John is describing one people from two sides.)

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Seal (*sphragida* – σφραγῖδα, v. 2):** A seal was the mark of ownership and authenticity – a signet ring pressed into the wax of a letter, a stamp on a cargo. What is sealed belongs to someone and is guarded by him. Paul uses the same picture for the Holy Spirit, with whom God has sealed believers (2 Corinthians 1:22; Ephesians 1:13).
- **On their foreheads (*epi tōn metōpōn autōn* – ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων αὐτῶν, v. 3):** The forehead is the place everyone can see: the seal says openly to whom these people belong. In chapter 13 the beast will imitate this mark (day 19).
- **Standing (*hestōtes* – ἑστῶτες, v. 9):** The answer to 6:17. The question was who is able to *stand* (*stathēnai*). Here a crowd stands before the throne and before the Lamb – not in their own strength, but because

the Lamb himself stood first, "as though slaughtered" (5:6).

- **Who are coming out of the great affliction (*hoi erchomenoi ek tēs thlipseōs tēs megalēs* – οἱ ἐρχόμενοι ἐκ τῆς θλίψεως τῆς μεγάλης, v. 14):** *Thlipsis* is the same word with which John introduces himself, as "your brother, who shares with you in the affliction" (1:9). The verb is in the present tense: they *are coming* – one by one, down the centuries. Behind the phrase stands Daniel 12:1, the time of distress in which God's people are rescued.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God marks his people before the storm comes.** The seal does not shield them from all suffering – the crowd comes precisely *out of* the affliction, and the souls under the altar were killed (6:9). But it keeps them in their suffering: no storm can tear them away from God. When the trumpets sound later, the locusts strike only "the people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads" (9:4).

2. **The Israel of God becomes a crowd from all the nations.** Israel is not wiped out or replaced; the nations are grafted into Abraham's family (Romans 11:17–18). The list begins with Judah, the tribe of the Lion (5:5): the promise runs through the Messiah, and whoever belongs to Christ is Abraham's offspring (Galatians 3:29).

3. **Salvation belongs to God and to the Lamb – not to us.** The crowd does not sing about its own endurance: "To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!" Their robes are white, but not because they kept them clean themselves: "they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb".

4. **The story ends where God dwells with his people.** "The one seated on the throne will spread his tent over them" – the language of the tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 40:34), of the Word who came to dwell

among us (John 1:14), and of the new creation (21:3). Isaiah's promise – no hunger, no thirst, no scorching sun (Isaiah 49:10) – comes true, "for the Lamb in the middle of the throne will shepherd them".

Living It Out

"Who can stand?" we ask when work burns us out, when our guilt catches up with us, when the doctor's words leave us shaken. Revelation 7 does not answer: the strong. It answers: those who belong to God. They stand, not because they have never stumbled, but because their robes have been washed in the blood of the Lamb.

Every day the world tells us who we are: successful or a failure, popular or overlooked. The first readers knew this too – loyal to the emperor or suspect. But God has written something on your forehead that no one can wipe away. That also brings a question, not a threat: if the forehead shows whom you belong to, what do the people around you see in what you think and do?

Look at the crowd as well. Our churches are often small and tired. But every Sunday we join a throng "that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages". The believer in Iran, in Nigeria and in your own street stands with you before the same throne. And if you are grieving today, the last word of the chapter is a promise: "God will wipe away every tear from their eyes."

Say it to yourself when you look in the mirror each morning this week: I am sealed, and I belong to the Lamb. And pray once for believers in a country and a language that are not your own.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What "storm" is making you wonder at the moment whether you will stand (6:17; 7:1–3)? What does it mean to you that God marks you before the storm comes?

- Which verdict of others about you do you believe more than the seal of the living God (vv. 2–3)?
- How big is the church in your imagination – your own congregation, or the crowd from every nation (v. 9)?
- Where are you still trying to keep your robes clean yourself, instead of washing them in the blood of the Lamb (v. 14)?

Prayer

Living God, salvation belongs to you and to the Lamb. With the angels and the countless crowd I bring you praise and glory and thanks. Thank you that you sealed me before the winds blow, and that you know me in a throng that no one can count.

How easily I live as if I belonged to someone else – to my work, to my fears, to the opinions of others. Forgive me that I have tried to make my robes clean myself. Wash me in the blood of the Lamb, and let my thoughts and my deeds show that I belong to you.

Lord Jesus, Lamb in the middle of the throne, be my shepherd. Lead me through the affliction to the springs of the water of life, and one day wipe away every tear from my eyes. Let me stand today, not in my own strength, but because you stood for me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 14

Silence in Heaven: The Prayers of the Saints

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 8:1–13

1 And when he opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for
about half an hour. 2 And I saw the seven angels who stand before God,
and seven trumpets were given to them.

3 And another angel came and stood at the altar, holding a golden
censer. And much incense was given to him, so that he would put it with
the prayers of all the saints on the golden altar before the throne. 4 And
the smoke of the incense went up with the prayers of the saints from the
hand of the angel before God. 5 And the angel took the censer and filled
it with the fire of the altar and threw it on the earth; and there were
thunder and sounds and lightning and an earthquake.

6 And the seven angels who had the seven trumpets made themselves
ready to blow the trumpet.

7 And the first blew the trumpet; and there came hail and fire, mixed
with blood, and it was thrown on the earth. And a third of the earth was
burnt up, and a third of the trees were burnt up, and all the green grass
was burnt up.

8 And the second angel blew the trumpet; and something like a great
mountain burning with fire was thrown into the sea. And a third of the
sea became blood, 9 and a third of the creatures in the sea that had life
died, and a third of the ships were destroyed.

10 And the third angel blew the trumpet; and a great star fell from
heaven, burning like a torch, and it fell on a third of the rivers and on
the springs of water. 11 And the name of the star is called Wormwood.
And a third of the waters became wormwood, and many people died
from the waters, because they had been made bitter.

12 And the fourth angel blew the trumpet; and a third of the sun was
struck, and a third of the moon and a third of the stars, so that a third of
them was darkened, and for a third of the day there was no light, and
likewise for the night.

[13] And I looked, and I heard an eagle flying in midheaven, saying with a loud voice, "Woe, woe, woe to those who live on the earth, because of the remaining blasts of the trumpet of the three angels who are about to blow!"

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we saw the countless crowd before the throne and heard the promise that God will wipe away every tear. Heaven was full of voices: angels, elders, living creatures, a throng from every nation. And then the Lamb opens the last seal – and nothing happens. "And when he opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about half an hour."

After chapters full of hymns of praise, it is as if the whole of heaven holds its breath. The prophets knew this silence. Habakkuk, who had himself asked, "How long, LORD", receives the answer: "But the LORD is in his holy temple – silence before him, all the earth!" (Habakkuk 2:20). And Zephaniah cries: "Silence before the Lord, the LORD! For the day of the LORD is near" (Zephaniah 1:7). It is the silence before God acts.

But John also tells us why heaven falls silent. An angel takes his stand at the golden altar – the altar of incense that stood in the tabernacle and the temple right in front of the curtain, where the priest burnt incense morning and evening (Exodus 30:1–8). When Zechariah, the father of John the Baptist, once offered the incense, the whole people stood outside praying (Luke 1:9–10). So it is here: the angel is given much incense, "so that he would put it with the prayers of all the saints on the golden altar before the throne". Heaven falls silent because there is prayer – and God is listening.

The churches in Asia were small and without influence; no one in Rome heard their prayers in houses and workshops. But here those prayers rise "before God". And then something unexpected happens: "And the angel

took the censer and filled it with the fire of the altar and threw it on the earth" (cf. Ezekiel 10:2). Thunder and an earthquake follow, as at Sinai (Exodus 19:16–18), and the seven angels make ready to blow the trumpet. The prayers of the saints come back to earth as God's action.

The trumpets that follow sound like the plagues of Egypt – hail and fire mixed with blood, a sea turned to blood, darkness (Exodus 7–10). As once against Pharaoh, God acts again against a power that oppresses his people – against Rome and every empire that behaves like Egypt.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Silence (*sigē* – σιγὴ, v. 1):** An ordinary word for silence. It is not an empty silence, but the silence of a courtroom before the judge speaks – and of a Father who is listening.
- **With the prayers of the saints (*tais proseuchais tōn hagiōn* – ταῖς προσευχαῖς τῶν ἁγίων, vv. 3–4):** The incense is added to the prayers and rises *with* them. In 5:8 the golden bowls full of incense were already "the prayers of the saints". Prayers are not merely tolerated; in heaven they are tended and brought before God.
- **Threw it on the earth (*ebalen eis tēn gēn* – ἔβαλεν εἰς τὴν γῆν, v. 5):** The same verb returns in verses 7 and 8: hail and fire are *thrown on the earth*, a mountain is *thrown into the sea*. The fire comes from the altar – the same altar under which the souls cried out, "How long, holy and true Master" (6:9–10).
- **A third (*to triton* – τὸ τρίτον, vv. 7–12):** Twelve times in six verses. The seals struck a fourth (6:8), the trumpets a third, the bowls later everything. The judgements are limited. They are warnings, not yet the end.
- **Woe, woe, woe (*Ouai ouai ouai* – Οὐαὶ οὐαὶ οὐαὶ, v. 13):** It is an eagle that cries out (*henos aetou* – ἑνὸς ἀετοῦ), not an angel, as older translations read following later manuscripts.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Heaven falls silent to listen.** The God who is worshipped day and night in heaven lets all the songs fall silent so that the prayers of his people can be heard. No prayer is too small for that silence.

2. **Prayer is part of how God governs history.** The trumpets do not begin with a decision made without us, but at the altar where the prayers rise. The answer to "How long?" is not indifference but God's justice set in motion. And behind the angel at the altar stands the great High Priest, Christ, "since he always lives to intercede for them" (Hebrews 7:25).

3. **The trumpets announce a new exodus.** Like the plagues of Egypt, they show that the idols are powerless and that creation belongs to God (Exodus 12:12). Their aim is not the destruction of creation but the liberation of God's people from the grip of the power that oppresses them – and, as we shall see tomorrow, a call to the world to repent.

4. **Even the warning is grace.** In Israel the trumpet was the watchman's alarm (Ezekiel 33:3–6). A God who warns has not yet given up on the world. The eagle's "Woe" is a serious word, but also a merciful one: there is still time.

Living It Out

Many of us pray and hear nothing. The child stays far away, the diagnosis does not change, the injustice at work goes on. We begin to wonder whether our prayers get past the ceiling. Revelation 8 pulls back the curtain and shows us what we cannot see: heaven falls silent, an angel tends our prayers like precious incense, and they rise "before God". Your prayers are not lost.

This also teaches us something about silence. Our lives are full of noise, and even our prayers are often just one more stream of words. But if heaven can fall silent to listen, we too can become still before God – not to

persuade him, but to remember who sits on the throne.

And when we hear of disasters – floods, fires, droughts – we need not fit each one into a timetable or guess which trumpet has just sounded. The trumpets show that this world is not as secure as we think, and that God is still calling: turn back before it is too late. For God's people that is not a reason for fear, but for prayer and witness.

Sit in silence for five minutes today before you pray. Then write down one injustice you have long been praying about, and bring it before God again – knowing that heaven is listening.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When did you last become truly still before God, without speaking (v. 1)?
- Which prayer have you given up on because you thought no one was listening (vv. 3–4)?
- Do you believe that your prayers are part of how God acts in the world (v. 5)? How would that change your intercession?
- How do you respond to news of disasters – with fear, with speculation, or with prayer and repentance (vv. 7–13)?

Prayer

> *Holy God, before you even heaven falls silent. You sit on the throne, and yet you listen to the prayers of your people, mine too. Thank you that no prayer I have ever prayed has been lost, and that it rises before you with the incense.*
>
> *Forgive my impatience and my discouragement, and that I have stopped praying because I heard nothing. Forgive the noise with which I fill my days, so that I can no longer be still before you.*

Lord Jesus, you always live to intercede for us. Teach me to pray with you for the world, for the persecuted and for those who suffer. Make me still before you, and in every storm of this world let me hear your voice calling me to turn back. Amen.

DAY 15

Locusts from the Abyss: And They Did Not Repent

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 9:1–21

[1] And the fifth angel blew the trumpet; and I saw a star that had fallen
from heaven to the earth, and the key to the shaft of the abyss was given
to him. [2] And he opened the shaft of the abyss, and smoke went up from
the shaft like the smoke of a great furnace, and the sun and the air were
darkened by the smoke of the shaft. [3] And out of the smoke came locusts
onto the earth, and they were given authority like the authority that the
scorpions of the earth have. [4] And they were told not to harm the grass
of the earth or any green thing or any tree, but only the people who do
not have the seal of God on their foreheads. [5] And they were allowed not
to kill them, but to torment them for five months; and their torment
was like the torment of a scorpion when it stings a person. [6] And in
those days people will seek death and will not find it; they will long to
die, and death flees from them.

[7] And the shapes of the locusts were like horses prepared for war; and on
their heads was something like crowns, like gold, and their faces were
like human faces. [8] And they had hair like women's hair, and their teeth
were like lions' teeth. [9] And they had breastplates like breastplates of
iron, and the rumble of their wings was like the rumble of chariots with
many horses rushing into war. [10] And they have tails like scorpions, and
stings, and in their tails is their authority to harm people for five
months. [11] They have as king over them the angel of the abyss; his name
in Hebrew is Abaddon, and in Greek he has the name Apollyon.

[12] The first woe has passed; look, two woes are still coming after this.

[13] And the sixth angel blew the trumpet; and I heard a voice from the
horns of the golden altar that is before God, [14] saying to the sixth angel,
who had the trumpet, "Release the four angels who are bound at the
great river, the Euphrates!" [15] And the four angels were released, who
had been made ready for the hour and day and month and year, to kill a
third of humankind. [16] And the number of the mounted troops was
twice ten thousands of ten thousands; I heard their number. [17] And this
is how I saw the horses in the vision and those who sat on them: they
had breastplates fiery red and hyacinth blue and sulphur yellow; and the

heads of the horses were like lions' heads, and out of their mouths come fire and smoke and sulphur. [18] By these three plagues a third of humankind was killed, by the fire and the smoke and the sulphur that come out of their mouths. [19] For the authority of the horses is in their mouths and in their tails; for their tails are like serpents, with heads, and with them they do harm.

[20] And the rest of humankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not even repent of the works of their hands, so as to stop worshipping the demons and the idols of gold and silver and bronze and stone and wood, which can neither see nor hear nor walk. [21] And they did not repent of their murders or of their sorceries or of their sexual immorality or of their thefts.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

After the first four trumpets – hail, blood, bitter water and darkness, as in Egypt – an eagle in midheaven cried, "Woe, woe, woe". Now the first two of those woes arrive, and it is the darkest page so far.

At the fifth trumpet John sees "a star that had fallen from heaven to the earth, and the key to the shaft of the abyss was given to him". In Revelation stars often stand for angels (1:20), and in 20:1 an angel comes with the same key. Others think of a fallen power, like the morning star of Isaiah 14:12 that fell from heaven. Either way, the key is *given*. Even the abyss opens only when God allows it.

From the shaft smoke rises "like the smoke of a great furnace" – the smoke of Sodom (Genesis 19:28) – and out of the smoke come locusts. Here the eighth plague of Egypt (Exodus 10:12–15) merges with the prophet Joel's vision of a locust army charging like horses, with teeth like lions, running ahead of the day of the LORD (Joel 1:4–6; 2:4–11). But the locusts of Revelation do not eat grass. They are to harm "only the people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads". What we saw on day 13 comes

true here: God's people are marked. Their king is *Abaddon*, Hebrew for "destruction" (Job 26:6), in Greek *Apollyon*, "the Destroyer". Many interpreters hear in it a dig at the god Apollo, with whom emperors, especially Nero, liked to be identified: the power that Rome worships is in reality a destroyer.

At the sixth trumpet a voice sounds "from the horns of the golden altar" – the same altar where yesterday the prayers rose. Four angels "bound at the great river, the Euphrates" are released. For John's readers the Euphrates was the eastern frontier of the empire, beyond which the dreaded Parthian horsemen waited; for Israel it was the river across which Assyria and Babylon had come (Isaiah 8:7). John hears the number of the mounted troops – two hundred million – an army too large to grasp, with fire, smoke and sulphur as over Sodom (Genesis 19:24).

And then come the most shocking words of the chapter: "And the rest of humankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not even repent of the works of their hands". Like Pharaoh, whose heart grew harder after every plague (Exodus 7:13; 9:35), the world clings to its idols.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Torment (*basanismos* – βασανισμὸς, v. 5):** A word for pain that goes deep and will not stop; the same word family is used for the woman in torment in childbirth (12:2). The locusts may not kill, only torment for five months – a limited time. The pain is real, but it is limited, and it is still a warning, not the end.
- **The abyss (*tēs abyssou* – τῆς ἀβύσσου, vv. 1–2):** In the Greek Old Testament *abyssos* is the primeval deep (*tehom*) of Genesis 1:2, the chaos before God's creating word, and in Jesus' day the place to which the demons did not want to be sent (Luke 8:31). Behind the locusts stands the power of chaos that wants to undo creation.

- **They did not repent (*oude metenoēsan* – οὐδὲ μετενόησαν, v. 20; *ou metenoēsan* – οὐ μετενόησαν, v. 21):** *Metanoeō* is a turning round of mind and life. It is the same verb that Jesus used in five of the seven letters (2:5, 16, 21; 3:3, 19). The call to repent is addressed first to the church, then to the world.
- **Sorceries (*pharmakōn* – φαρμάκων, v. 21):** The word comes from *pharmakon*, a remedy, poison or potion. In the ancient world it was the magic by which people tried to manipulate the gods and fate – like Nineveh, the "mistress of sorceries" (Nahum 3:4).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Evil has a key, but God holds the whole bunch.** The abyss is deep and the destroyer is cruel, but every step is limited: how long, whom, how many. The churches in Asia did not need to think that Rome, or the demonic powers behind Rome, had the last word.
2. **Judgement alone does not change the heart.** This chapter is disturbingly honest. Plagues, pain and death do not automatically turn people to God; they can harden them, as they hardened Pharaoh. Suffering is a call, but not a guarantee.
3. **People become like the idols they worship.** The idols of gold and silver and bronze and stone and wood, "which can neither see nor hear nor walk", come from Daniel 5:23 and Psalm 115:4–7, where it also says: those who make them become like them (Psalm 115:8). Behind the idols stand demons (Deuteronomy 32:17). And idolatry does not stay in the temple: it leads to murders, sorceries, sexual immorality and thefts – God's commandments broken one after another.
4. **What the plagues cannot do, the Lamb does.** The trumpets do not end in repentance. But the story goes on: in chapters 10 and 11 God sends his witnesses, and afterwards people "gave glory to the God of heaven"

(11:13). It is not fear but God's kindness that leads to repentance (Romans 2:4). The Lamb conquers through witness and self-giving, not through locusts.

Living It Out

We all know the temptation to think that a great shock will make people turn round: "If only they see how bad things are, they will come back to God." But Revelation 9 and our own experience say otherwise. Crises come and go, and most people simply carry on. So do we. How often has an illness, an accident or a loss shaken us awake – and a few weeks later everything was back as it was?

So the question is not only about "the world out there". What are the works of your hands that you trust in? Today they are seldom images of stone and wood, but it may be your career, your savings, your reputation, the phone in your hand. It can neither see nor hear nor walk, and yet we cling to it as though our life depended on it. And slowly we become like it: deaf to God, blind to our neighbour.

The good news is that Jesus did not only tell the churches to repent; he also said, "Look, I am standing at the door and knocking" (3:20). Repentance is not a price we pay to put God in a good mood; it is turning round towards someone who is already waiting for us. Joel's locusts ended with the same invitation: tear your hearts, return to the LORD, for he is gracious and compassionate (Joel 2:13).

Ask yourself honestly today: which work of my hands has taken my heart captive? Name it before God, and take one small step away from it – and towards him.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which crisis in your life turned you to God – and which one made you harder instead (v. 20)?

- What are the works of your hands – things you have made or earned yourself – that you trust more than God (v. 20)?
- In what ways do you try, as with *pharmaka*, to control your life and your fate yourself instead of trusting God (v. 21)?
- Do you hear Jesus' call to repent as a threat or as an invitation (2:5; 3:19–20)?

Prayer

Lord God, you hold the keys of heaven and of the abyss. Nothing happens outside the limits you set, and your people are marked with your seal. Thank you that I need not fear the powers of darkness, for they are on your leash.

My heart is harder than I want to admit, Lord. I have gone through hard times without turning to you, and I cling to the works of my hands – things that can neither see nor hear nor save. I confess that I have sometimes become like my idols: deaf to your voice and blind to my neighbour. Forgive me.

Lord Jesus, you are standing at the door and knocking. Soften my heart and give me the grace to repent – not out of fear, but because you are good and compassionate. Make me a witness of your love in a world that does not want to turn round. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 16

The Little Scroll: Sweet in the Mouth, Bitter in the Stomach

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 10:1–11

1 And I saw another mighty angel coming down from heaven, wrapped
in a cloud, and the rainbow was over his head, and his face was like the
sun, and his feet were like pillars of fire, 2 and he had in his hand a little
scroll, opened. And he set his right foot on the sea and his left foot on
the earth, 3 and he cried out with a loud voice, as a lion roars. And when
he cried out, the seven thunders spoke with their own voices. 4 And
when the seven thunders had spoken, I was about to write; and I heard a
voice from heaven saying, "Seal up what the seven thunders have spo-
ken, and do not write it down!"

5 And the angel whom I saw standing on the sea and on the earth raised
his right hand to heaven 6 and swore by the one who lives for ever and
ever, who created heaven and what is in it, and the earth and what is in
it, and the sea and what is in it, that there will be no more delay, 7 but
that in the days of the voice of the seventh angel, when he is about to
blow the trumpet, the mystery of God is fulfilled, as he announced the
good news to his servants the prophets.

8 And the voice that I had heard from heaven spoke with me again and
said, "Go, take the scroll that lies open in the hand of the angel who is
standing on the sea and on the earth." 9 And I went to the angel and told
him to give me the little scroll. And he says to me, "Take it and eat it up;
it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be sweet as
honey." 10 And I took the little scroll from the hand of the angel and ate it
up, and it was sweet as honey in my mouth; and when I had eaten it, my
stomach was made bitter. 11 And they say to me, "You must prophesy
again about many peoples and nations and languages and kings."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday the chapter ended with hard words: after all the plagues, people did not repent. We expect the seventh trumpet to sound now. But as between the sixth and the seventh seal (chapter 7), another pause comes. In chapter 7 God's people were sealed; in chapters 10 and 11 they are sent. God's answer to a world that will not turn round is not more locusts, but his word in the mouth of his witnesses.

John saw "another mighty angel coming down from heaven, wrapped in a cloud, and the rainbow was over his head, and his face was like the sun, and his feet were like pillars of fire". Every feature comes from Scripture. The pillar of cloud and fire led Israel through the wilderness (Exodus 13:21); the rainbow surrounds God's throne (4:3; Ezekiel 1:28) and recalls God's covenant with the earth after the flood (Genesis 9:13); the face like the sun is the face of Christ himself (1:16). Some therefore think that this is Christ himself; but John calls him an angel, a messenger who carries the glory of the one who sent him. He sets one foot on the sea and the other on the earth – the whole of creation is under the authority of the God who sends him.

Then he cries out "as a lion roars", and the seven thunders answer. Amos said: the lion has roared – who will not fear? The Lord GOD has spoken – who can but prophesy? (Amos 3:8). But when John is about to write, a voice says: "Seal up what the seven thunders have spoken, and do not write it down!" There are things that even the prophet may not pass on.

Then the angel raises his right hand and swears "by the one who lives for ever and ever". This echoes Daniel 12:7, where a man clothed in linen raises his hands to heaven and swears that the end will still take a time, times and half a time. Here the oath is different: "that there will be no more delay". For the souls under the altar, who had been told "to rest a little longer" (6:11), this is the answer to their "How long?"

And then John himself must take the little scroll and eat it. Ezekiel had the same experience. In exile God gave him a scroll, written on both sides with laments and mourning and woe, and said: eat this scroll. It was sweet as honey in his mouth – but afterwards he went away in bitterness of spirit (Ezekiel 2:8–3:3, 14). Jeremiah knew this too: God's words were a joy to him (Jeremiah 15:16), and yet the same word brought him persecution.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **A little scroll, opened (*biblaridion ēneōgmenon* – βιβλαρίδιον ἠνεῳγμένον, v. 2):** The same verb form as the door in heaven that *stood open* (4:1). Many interpreters think that this is the scroll of chapter 5, which the Lamb has meanwhile opened and which is now given to John; others see a smaller, separate message. Either way, it is open, and it is meant for him.
- **Seal up (*Sphragison* – Σφράγισον, v. 4):** Daniel had to seal up his visions until the time of the end (Daniel 12:4, 9). At the end of Revelation John will hear that he must *not* seal up the words of this book (22:10). But the seven thunders remain sealed: not everything is meant for us to know.
- **No more delay (*chronos ouketi estai* – χρόνος οὐκέτι ἔσται, v. 6):** *Chronos* usually means "time". Older translations had "that there should be time no longer", which was often read as if time itself would stop. But the context – the oath of Daniel 12:7 and the "How long?" of 6:10 – is about God's waiting, not about the end of the calendar: God will wait no longer.
- **Take it and eat it up (*Labe kai kataphage auto* – Λάβε καὶ κατάφαγε αὐτό, v. 9):** *Kataphagein* does not mean to taste but to eat up completely. The word must go into the prophet before it can come out of him.

- **You must prophesy again (*Dei se palin prophēteusai* – Δεῖ σε πάλιν προφητεῦσαι, v. 11):** The same *dei* ("must") as in 4:1, "what must take place after this". The witness of God's people is not a side issue; it is part of God's plan for history.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's answer to a hard world is his word.** Where plagues did not bring repentance, God sends prophets "about many peoples and nations and languages and kings" – the same nations from which the Lamb purchased people (5:9). This was the calling of the churches in Rome's cities: not to withdraw, but to bear witness.

2. **Not everything is ours to know.** The sealed thunders are a rebuke to anyone who wants to use Revelation as a puzzle for speculation and dates. God shows us enough to be faithful, not enough to control the future. He asks for trust, not calculation.

3. **God is not late.** The angel swears that "the mystery of God is fulfilled, as he announced the good news to his servants the prophets" (cf. Amos 3:7). The verb for "announce the good news" is the verb of the gospel. In the New Testament the mystery of God is his plan in Christ, in which the nations become heirs together with Israel (Ephesians 3:6). Habakkuk had already learnt to wait for a vision that will surely come and not delay (Habakkuk 2:3).

4. **The word of God is sweet and bitter.** Sweet, because it is the word of the Lamb's victory and of God's faithfulness. Bitter, because carrying it costs something: it includes judgement on the world and suffering for the witnesses, as chapter 11 will show. So it was for Jesus too, whose word was joy for the poor and yet led him to the cross.

Living It Out

Many of us read the Bible like someone sampling at a buffet: a verse here, a comforting thought there. That is not wrong, but John is told to *eat up* the scroll. God's word wants to go into us, shape our thinking and become part of us – and that takes time, repetition and silence.

When that happens, you will taste both the sweetness and the bitterness. The sweetness: the promise that you need not be afraid (1:17), the forgiveness of the Lamb. The bitterness: the word that says you must forgive the one who hurt you; the truth you have to speak at work or in your family and that may cost you something. If the Bible is only sweet to you, you may be reading only half of it. If it is only bitter, you have forgotten the Lamb.

The seven thunders are a comfort as well. You do not have to know everything about the future. You only have to be faithful with what God has actually shown. And if you have long been waiting for an answer, remember the angel's oath: with God there is no delay that breaks his promise.

This week choose one short passage – Revelation 10:8–11, for example – and read it slowly and aloud every day for three days. "Chew" on it. Then share one sentence from it with someone who needs it.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you read the Bible more like someone who tastes or like someone who eats (vv. 9–10)?
- Which part of God's word is sweet to you at the moment, and which part bitter (v. 10)?
- Which "sealed thunders" – questions about the future that God has not answered – make you restless (v. 4)? Can you leave them with him?
- To which "peoples and nations and languages" – the people around you – is God sending you as a witness (v. 11)?

Prayer

Lord God, Creator of heaven and earth and sea, you live for ever and ever, and your word stands firm. Thank you that you are never late, and that the mystery of your plan in Christ is being fulfilled, as you promised your prophets.

Forgive me that I only taste your word and avoid the bitter parts. Forgive my curiosity about what you have sealed, and my slowness to be faithful with what you have shown.

Give me a hunger for your word. Let it be sweet in my mouth, and give me the courage to bear the bitterness when witness costs something. Send me to the people around me, so that they may hear the good news of the Lamb. In the name of the Lamb, Amen.

DAY 17

The Two Witnesses: A Testimony Death Cannot Silence

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 11:1–19

[1] And a reed like a staff was given to me, and I was told, "Get up and measure the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it. [2] But leave out the court outside the temple, and do not measure it, for it has been given to the nations, and they will trample the holy city for forty-two months. [3] And I will grant my two witnesses that they prophesy for a thousand two hundred and sixty days, clothed in sackcloth."

[4] These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord of the earth. [5] And if anyone wants to harm them, fire comes out of their mouth and devours their enemies; and if anyone should want to harm them, this is how he must be killed. [6] They have the authority to shut the sky, so that no rain falls during the days of their prophecy; and they have authority over the waters, to turn them into blood and to strike the earth with every plague, as often as they want.

[7] And when they have finished their testimony, the beast that comes up from the abyss will make war against them and conquer them and kill them. [8] And their corpse lies in the street of the great city, which is spiritually called Sodom and Egypt, where their Lord too was crucified. [9] And people from the peoples and tribes and languages and nations look at their corpse for three and a half days, and they do not allow their corpses to be laid in a tomb. [10] And those who live on the earth are glad over them and rejoice, and they will send gifts to one another, because these two prophets tormented those who live on the earth.

[11] And after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood on their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw them. [12] And they heard a loud voice from heaven saying to them, "Come up here!" And they went up to heaven in the cloud, and their enemies watched them. [13] And in that hour there was a great earthquake, and a tenth of the city fell, and seven thousand people were killed in the earthquake; and the rest were terrified and gave glory to the God of heaven.

[14] The second woe has passed; look, the third woe is coming soon.

15 And the seventh angel blew the trumpet; and there were loud voices in heaven, saying:

The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's,
and he will reign for ever and ever.

16 And the twenty-four elders who sit on their thrones before God fell on their faces and worshipped God, 17 saying:

We give you thanks, Lord God, the Almighty,
who is and who was,
because you have taken your great power
and begun to reign.
18 And the nations were angry,
and your wrath has come,
and the time for the dead to be judged,
and to give the reward to your servants the prophets
and to the saints and to those who fear your name,
the small and the great,
and to destroy those who destroy the earth.

19 And God's temple in heaven was opened, and the ark of his covenant was seen in his temple; and there were lightning and sounds and thunder and an earthquake and great hail.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

A reed is put into John's hand: "Get up and measure the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it." He has just eaten the little scroll – sweet in the mouth, bitter in the stomach – and heard that he must prophesy again about many peoples and nations and languages and kings (10:11). Chapter 11 shows what such a prophetic calling means. John hears of two witnesses who prophesy in sackcloth, are killed, lie in the street – and stand up again.

The measuring reed comes from Ezekiel 40–42, where the new temple is measured, and from Zechariah 2, where Jerusalem is measured as a sign that God will protect the city. To measure something is to say: this belongs to me, and I will keep it. But the outer court is not measured; the nations "will trample the holy city for forty-two months". The first readers knew what that felt like. The temple in Jerusalem had been destroyed by Rome in AD 70, and they themselves were shut out and trampled in their own cities. Yet in the New Testament the temple of God is the church itself (1 Corinthians 3:16). God's people are at once safe within – no one can touch their worship – and exposed without, where they suffer.

Forty-two months, a thousand two hundred and sixty days: this is Daniel's "a time and times and half a time" (Daniel 7:25; 12:7), the measured time of affliction under a godless ruler. Revelation uses it for the whole time of the church's witness between Christ's first and second coming – hard, but not endless. (Futurist interpreters take it as a literal three and a half years at the end of history, with two individual prophets, according to some Moses and Elijah themselves.)

Who are the two witnesses? John gives the key himself: "These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands". And the lampstands are the churches (1:20). The olive trees come from Zechariah 4, where the governor Zerubbabel and the high priest Joshua rebuild the temple, not by might nor by power, but by God's Spirit (Zechariah 4:6). Their signs are those of Elijah, who shut the sky (1 Kings 17:1), and of Moses, who turned the water into blood (Exodus 7:17–20). And there are two because the law requires two witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). So the two witnesses are probably the witnessing church itself.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Witnesses (*martysin* – μάρτυσίν, v. 3):** We translate "witness", not "martyr". But this chapter shows how the two words grew together in the early church: whoever bears faithful witness sometimes pays the

price – like Antipas, "my witness, my faithful one" (2:13), and like Jesus himself, "the faithful witness" (1:5).

- **Spiritually (*pneumatikōs* – πνευματικῶς, v. 8):** The great city is "spiritually called Sodom and Egypt" – not on the map, but through the eyes of the Spirit. Sodom stands for pride and hardness towards the poor (Ezekiel 16:49), Egypt for slavery. It is Jerusalem, "where their Lord too was crucified", but also Rome, and every city that tramples God's witnesses.
- **Breath of life from God (*pneuma zōēs ek tou theou* – πνεῦμα ζωῆς ἐκ τοῦ θεοῦ, v. 11):** The language of Ezekiel 37, where God's breath enters the dry bones and they stand on their feet (Ezekiel 37:5, 10). What God promised the "dead" Israel in exile, he does for his witnesses.
- **Who is and who was (*ho ōn kai ho ēn* – ὁ ὢν καὶ ὁ ἦν, v. 17):** Until now God has been the one "who is and who was and who is coming" (1:4, 8). Here "and who is coming" drops away. He has come; he has "begun to reign".

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The church is a prophetic witness, not a safe fortress.** The two witnesses wear sackcloth – the clothing of mourning and repentance, like Nineveh when Jonah preached (Jonah 3:5). Those who live on the earth experience their message as torment (v. 10). Yet this is the calling of the church in every age: to bear witness to the truth, even when it makes no one popular.

2. **The witnesses follow their Lord on his way – into death and through death.** They die in the city "where their Lord too was crucified", lie in the street for three and a half days, and then go up to heaven in the cloud, like Elijah (2 Kings 2:11) and like Jesus himself (Acts 1:9). The beast will "conquer" them (v. 7) – but just as the Lamb conquered by being slaughtered (5:5–6), their defeat becomes their victory.

3. **God's aim is repentance.** In Elijah's day God spared seven thousand who had not bowed to Baal (1 Kings 19:18). Here it is turned around: seven thousand die, "and the rest were terrified and gave glory to the God of heaven." According to many interpreters this is the first time in the book that people repent – not through the plagues (9:20–21), but through the testimony of believers who were ready to die.

4. **The end is a kingdom, not a catastrophe.** The seventh trumpet brings no further plague, but a song: "The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's" (cf. Psalm 2:2; Daniel 7:14). Then the temple in heaven is opened and "the ark of his covenant" is seen – the ark that was probably lost when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem (586 BC). God has never forgotten his covenant.

Living It Out

Many believers feel like the outer court that is not measured: outside, trampled, overlooked. At work you may weigh every word before you speak about your faith; at school your child may be laughed at for praying before lunch. Revelation 11 does not promise that this will not happen. It promises something deeper: the inner part has been measured. No one can take your place at the altar from you.

The two witnesses also teach us that witness is not about success. They prophesy for years – and then it looks as if it was all for nothing, and the world sends gifts to one another. That is the experience of many faithful people: the minister whose congregation is shrinking, the parents who have prayed for a child for years, the colleague who is the only one not going along with dishonesty. But the last word is not the party in the street. It is the voice from heaven: "Come up here!"

So you do not have to wait until you are strong and popular before you bear witness. A lampstand does not have to be the sun; it only has to burn. An honest word about Jesus, a refusal to join in a lie, a quiet act of service

for a neighbour – that is light in a dark city, not by might nor by power, but by God's Spirit.

Think today of one person around you who does not yet know Christ. Pray for him or her by name, and ask God for one opportunity to share something of your hope – gently, not fearfully.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you sometimes feel like the court that is trampled (v. 2)? What does it mean to you that God has measured the inner part?
- Where are you tempted to stay silent because your witness would make you unpopular (vv. 3, 10)?
- When has it looked to you as if the beast had won – and how does the voice saying "Come up here!" (v. 12) help you to keep going?
- Where would it make a difference today if you truly believed that the kingdom of the world has already become our Lord's (v. 15)?

Prayer

> *Lord God, the Almighty, who is and who was: I thank you that you have taken your great power and begun to reign. The kingdom of the world belongs to you and to your Christ, and nothing on this earth can change that.*
>
> *I confess that I stay silent when I should bear witness, and that I would rather be popular than faithful. Forgive me for the days when I thought the beast had won and my witness was in vain.*
>
> *Thank you that you keep my inner life, and that you give the breath of life to those who die for your name's sake. Make me a burning lampstand in my city – not by might nor by power, but by your Spirit – until I hear your voice: Come up here! Amen.*

DAY 18

The Accuser Is Thrown Down: The Christmas Story from Behind the Curtain

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 12:1–18

[1] And a great sign appeared in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun,
with the moon under her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars.
[2] And she was pregnant, and she cries out in labour and in torment to
give birth.

[3] And another sign appeared in heaven, and look, a great fiery red
dragon, with seven heads and ten horns, and on its heads seven di-
adems. [4] And its tail sweeps away a third of the stars of heaven, and it
threw them to the earth. And the dragon stood before the woman who
was about to give birth, so that when she gave birth it might devour her
child. [5] And she gave birth to a son, a male child, who is to shepherd all
the nations with an iron rod. And her child was snatched up to God and
to his throne. [6] And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she has a
place prepared by God, so that there she might be fed for a thousand
two hundred and sixty days.

[7] And war broke out in heaven: Michael and his angels made war against
the dragon. And the dragon made war, and its angels, [8] but it was not
strong enough, and no place was found for them in heaven any longer.
[9] And the great dragon was thrown down, the ancient serpent, who is
called the devil and Satan, who deceives the whole world – he was
thrown down to the earth, and his angels were thrown down with him.

[10] And I heard a loud voice in heaven saying:

Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our
God
and the authority of his Christ,
for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down,
who accuses them before our God day and night.
[11] And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb
and by the word of their testimony,
and they did not love their life even to death.
[12] Therefore rejoice, you heavens,
and you whose tent is in them!

Woe to the earth and the sea,
for the devil has come down to you
with great fury,
because he knows that he has only a little time.

13 And when the dragon saw that it had been thrown down to the earth,
it pursued the woman who had given birth to the male child. 14 And the
two wings of the great eagle were given to the woman, so that she might
fly into the wilderness to her place, where she is fed for a time and times
and half a time, away from the face of the serpent. 15 And the serpent
spewed water like a river out of its mouth after the woman, so that the
river would sweep her away. 16 And the earth helped the woman, and the
earth opened its mouth and swallowed the river that the dragon had
spewed out of its mouth. 17 And the dragon was angry with the woman
and went off to make war against the rest of her offspring, those who
keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus.
18 And it took its stand on the sand of the sea.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday the seventh trumpet sounded: "The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's". Today John draws the curtain back further and shows how it came about. "And a great sign appeared in heaven": a woman clothed with the sun, pregnant and in labour, and before her a great fiery red dragon, waiting to devour her child.

This is the Christmas story, but told from behind the curtain. On earth it looked like an ordinary birth in Bethlehem and a cruel king who had the children killed (Matthew 2:16). Behind the curtain it was the old conflict of Genesis 3:15, where God tells the serpent that there will be enmity between its offspring and the offspring of the woman. John calls the dragon by name: "the ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan" (v. 9). Its seven heads and ten horns come from the beasts of Daniel 7; the diadems

are the signs of earthly rule. Anyone in Smyrna or Pergamum who heard these words understood: behind Rome's power stands an older and darker power.

The woman with the sun, the moon and twelve stars recalls Joseph's dream, in which the sun, moon and stars are Jacob and his family (Genesis 37:9) – Israel, the people from whom the Messiah is born. Her labour pains are those of Zion in Micah 4:9–10. But after the birth she is also the mother of "the rest of her offspring, those who keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus" (v. 17): the church. It is one people of God, from Abraham until today. The child is "to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod" (Psalm 2:9), and then he is "snatched up to God and to his throne". The whole life of Jesus, from the manger to the ascension, stands in a single sentence.

Then the woman flees into the wilderness, "where she has a place prepared by God". Here we hear the exodus. After Egypt Israel was led through the wilderness and fed with manna, and at Sinai God said: I carried you on eagles' wings and brought you to myself (Exodus 19:4). Now the woman is given "the two wings of the great eagle". The church is on an exodus through this age – not out of creation, for "the earth helped the woman" (v. 16), but out of the dragon's power, on the way to the new creation.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **The accuser (*ho katēgōr* – ὁ κατήγωρ, v. 10):** A word from the courtroom. It is exactly what the Hebrew *hassatan* means in Job 1–2 and Zechariah 3: "the adversary", the accuser in God's heavenly council. In Job 1:9 he asks: Is it for nothing that Job fears God? And the participle *ho katēgorōn* (ὁ κατηγορῶν) shows that he does it constantly: he "accuses them before our God day and night."
- **Thrown down (*eblēthē* – ἐβλήθη, vv. 9–13):** Five times in five verses it rings out: thrown down, thrown down. The passive points to God as the one who does it. The dragon "was not strong enough, and no place

was found for them in heaven any longer."

- **By the blood (*dia to haima* – διὰ τὸ αἷμα, v. 11):** With the accusative, *dia* really means: on the basis of, because of. Believers do not conquer in their own strength; they conquer because the blood of the Lamb has already won.
- **A little time (*oligon kairon* – ὀλίγον καιρὸν, v. 12):** The devil comes down to earth "with great fury, because he knows that he has only a little time." His fury is not the fury of a winner, but of a defeated enemy.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The cross was the decisive battle – in heaven too.** Michael's war (Daniel 12:1) is the heavenly side of Good Friday and Easter. The song does not say that the dragon was defeated by angelic strength, but "by the blood of the Lamb". Jesus said it himself when his cross was near: now the ruler of this world will be driven out (John 12:31). In Job the accuser could still appear before God; after the cross he has no place there any longer.

2. **The accusation is answered by the blood, not by our record.** In Zechariah 3 the high priest Joshua stands in filthy clothes before the angel of the LORD, and Satan stands at his right hand to accuse him. Joshua says nothing in his own defence. The LORD rebukes the accuser, and Joshua is given clean clothes: See, I have taken your guilt away from you (Zechariah 3:4). That is the gospel in a single scene: who will bring a charge against God's chosen ones? It is Christ who intercedes for us (Romans 8:33–34).

3. **The church is on its exodus: kept, fed, but in the wilderness.** The thousand two hundred and sixty days are the same time as the witness of the two witnesses yesterday – the whole time between Christ's ascension and his return. The woman is not taken out of the wilderness but fed in it. God's people are not spared hardship, but they are carried through it.

4. **The dragon's fury is the sign of his defeat.** He can no longer reach the child, so he fights against the woman's offspring. That explains the persecution of the churches in Asia – and of believers today. Yet the chapter ends with an almost comical picture: "And it took its stand on the sand of the sea." There it waits for helpers. Tomorrow we shall see who comes up out of the sea.

Living It Out

Many believers know the accuser's voice well. It whispers in the night: You are a hypocrite. Look at what you said again. God gave up on you long ago. The accuser often uses the truth – we really have sinned – but he uses it to drive us away from God, not towards him. That is the difference between the conviction the Spirit works, which leads to the cross, and Satan's accusation, which ends in despair.

Revelation 12 gives you the answer Joshua received in Zechariah 3. You do not have to conduct your own defence or polish your record. The accuser has been thrown down – not because you have become better, but by the blood of the Lamb. And the second weapon is "the word of their testimony": saying out loud what God has done.

The picture of the wilderness is a comfort too. Perhaps you are in a dry season – illness, loss, loneliness, a church that is struggling. The wilderness is not proof that God has abandoned you. It is the place he has "prepared", where he feeds you and carries you on eagles' wings.

Today, write down one accusation you hear again and again in your head. Next to it write: "for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down" (v. 10). Read it aloud when the voice comes back.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which accusation do you hear most often in your own thoughts, and do you listen to it as though it were the last word (v. 10)?

- Do you try to silence the accuser with your own good works, or do you take refuge in the blood of the Lamb (v. 11)?
- Where are you in the wilderness at the moment, and where, if you look closely, can you see that God is feeding you there (vv. 6, 14)?
- What would it mean for you not to love your life "even to death" (v. 11)?

Prayer

> *You are King, Lord God, and your Christ has the authority. I praise you that the accuser of your children has been thrown down and has no place before you any longer. Your Son was born, he died for me, and he sits on your throne.*
>
> *You know the voices that accuse me. I admit that much of what they say is true: I have sinned, and my clothes are not clean. But I will no longer listen to the accuser as though he had the last word. I take refuge in the blood of the Lamb.*
>
> *Thank you that you feed me in the wilderness and carry me on eagles' wings, on the way to the new creation. Give me courage to speak the word of my testimony, and not to love my life more than I love you. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

DAY 19

The Mark of the Beast: Whose Are You?

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 13:1–18

[1] And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea, with ten horns and seven heads, and on its horns ten diadems, and on its heads names of blasphemy. [2] And the beast that I saw was like a leopard, and its feet were like a bear's, and its mouth like a lion's mouth. And the dragon gave it its power and its throne and great authority. [3] And one of its heads seemed slaughtered to death, and its death wound was healed. And the whole earth followed the beast in amazement, [4] and they worshipped the dragon, because it had given the authority to the beast, and they worshipped the beast, saying, "Who is like the beast, and who can make war against it?"

[5] And it was given a mouth speaking great things and blasphemies, and it was given authority to act for forty-two months. [6] And it opened its mouth in blasphemies against God, to blaspheme his name and his tent – those whose tent is in heaven. [7] And it was allowed to make war against the saints and to conquer them, and it was given authority over every tribe and people and language and nation. [8] And all who live on the earth will worship it – everyone whose name has not been written in the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb from the foundation of the world.

[9] If anyone has an ear, he should hear. [10] If anyone is for captivity, into captivity he goes; if anyone is to be killed with the sword, with the sword he will be killed. Here is the endurance and the faith of the saints.

[11] And I saw another beast coming up out of the earth, and it had two horns like a lamb, and it spoke like a dragon. [12] And it exercises all the authority of the first beast in its presence, and it makes the earth and those who live on it worship the first beast, whose death wound was healed. [13] And it performs great signs, so that it even makes fire come down from heaven to the earth before people. [14] And it deceives those who live on the earth by the signs that it was allowed to perform in the presence of the beast, telling those who live on the earth to make an image for the beast that has the wound of the sword and came to life.

[15] And it was allowed to give breath to the image of the beast, so that the image of the beast would even speak and would cause all who do not worship the image of the beast to be killed. [16] And it makes everyone, the small and the great, the rich and the poor, the free and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, [17] so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark: the name of the beast or the number of its name. [18] Here is wisdom: whoever has understanding should calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a human being. And its number is six hundred and sixty-six.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

"And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea". The dragon, defeated and furious, has taken its stand on the sand of the sea (12:18), and now we see whom it is waiting for. Every Jewish reader knew where this picture came from. Daniel saw four beasts come up out of the sea – a lion, a bear, a leopard and a terrifying fourth beast with ten horns – and they were four empires that oppressed God's people (Daniel 7:2–8, 17). John's beast is all four at once: leopard, bear and lion in one body. It is godless world power in its full form.

For the churches in Asia the beast had a face. Rome came across the sea, and its power was visible everywhere. "And the dragon gave it its power and its throne and great authority." The second beast comes "up out of the earth", out of their own surroundings: according to many interpreters the local elite – priests and city leaders who promoted the imperial cult. Pergamum already had a temple to Roma and the emperor in the time of Augustus, and Ephesus built a great temple to the emperors under Domitian. Whoever wanted to take part in the life of the city – its festivals, the guilds of traders and craftsmen, the market – faced the same choice again and again: incense for the emperor, or exclusion. All this "so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark".

The most shocking thing about the chapter, however, is how much the beast resembles the Lamb. One of its heads "seemed slaughtered to death", and its death wound is healed – just as the Lamb is "as though slaughtered" (5:6). It "came to life" (v. 14), the very words Christ uses of himself (2:8). (Many interpreters also hear the rumour that spread after the emperor Nero's death in AD 68, that he would return.) The second beast "had two horns like a lamb, and it spoke like a dragon." And the crowd cries, "Who is like the beast, and who can make war against it?" – a counterfeit of Israel's song: Who is a God like you? (Exodus 15:11; Micah 7:18). Evil creates nothing new. It imitates.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Mark (*charagma* – χάραγμα, vv. 16–17):** The word for a stamp or impression – also for the emperor's stamp on coins and documents. Many of the coins in the hand of a trader in Thyatira bore the emperor's image and titles. According to verse 17 the mark is "the name of the beast or the number of its name": it says whom you belong to.
- **As though slaughtered (*hōs esphagmenēn* – ὡς ἐσφαγμένην, v. 3):** The same expression as for the Lamb in 5:6 (*hōs esphagmenon*). John wants us to notice the likeness – and the difference. The Lamb's wounds are for others; the beast's healing is for itself.
- **Calculate (*psēphisatō* – ψηφισάτω, v. 18):** From *psēphos*, the pebble used for counting. "Here is wisdom", says John. It is the wisdom of discernment (cf. 17:9), not of code-breakers.
- **The number of a human being (*arithmos anthrōpou* – ἀριθμὸς ἀνθρώπου, v. 18):** "And its number is six hundred and sixty-six" (so the SBLGNT; a few early manuscripts have 616). One well-known reading: the words "Nero Caesar" in Hebrew letters add up to 666, and in a Latin spelling to 616. Others read it as "a human number": six falling short three times of seven, the number of fullness – humanity putting itself in God's place.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Evil is a counterfeit of the Lamb.** The beast has a wound, a resurrection, a throne, worshippers and a "prophet". So the danger for the church is not first of all the open enemy, but the convincing copy: power that looks like salvation, a leader who sounds like a lamb. The test is not how impressive something is, but whether it is like the Lamb – or speaks like the dragon.

2. **Power that demands worship is always the beast.** The image that speaks and has everyone killed who will not worship it comes from Daniel 3, where Nebuchadnezzar's golden statue had to be worshipped. The three friends refused, even if God should not rescue them (Daniel 3:17–18). Rome was the beast of John's day; every age has its own systems – political, economic, ideological – that lay claim to people's whole heart.

3. **No one is unmarked – everyone belongs to someone.** The mark on the right hand or the forehead is the counterpart of God's seal (7:3), which recalls Ezekiel 9:4. Many interpreters also hear the Shema: God's words are to be a sign on your hand and between your eyes (Deuteronomy 6:8). The forehead stands for what you think, the hand for what you do. And God's seal came first: his servants were sealed before the beast ever appeared.

4. **The saints conquer by endurance, not by fear.** "Here is the endurance and the faith of the saints." The beast may make war and even conquer, but only "for forty-two months" – God's measured time. And whoever belongs to the Lamb has their name in "the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb" (v. 8).

Living It Out

The mark of the beast is not something you can receive by accident, or a technology you need to live in fear of. The believers in Asia knew exactly what it was about: the small pinch of incense, the guild meal at the tem-

ple, the silence that would save your business. The mark did not arrive in a day; it grew through a thousand small choices of the hand and the forehead.

We know the same pressure. At work you can only "buy and sell" if you go along with a little dishonesty. Among friends you have to keep quiet about certain things to fit in. Advertising tells you every day who you must be and what you must have. That is not loud persecution, but quiet worship of power, money and status.

So the question of Revelation 13 is not "when?" but "whose are you?" And the gospel's answer is not, "Watch out, or you will be marked!" It is: you are already sealed. Your name is written in the book of the Lamb who was slaughtered for you. You can say no to the beast because you have said yes to him.

Ask yourself two questions tonight: Where is the beast pulling at my hand – at something I do? And where at my forehead – at something I think? Bring both to God with the words: I belong to the Lamb.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Where are you drawn by a convincing "counterfeit" – something that looks like a lamb but speaks like a dragon (v. 11)?
- In which area of your life do you feel the pressure that you can only "buy or sell" if you play along (v. 17)?
- What would someone who had watched your week say: whom do your hand and your forehead belong to (v. 16)?
- How do your fears change when you know that your name is in the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb (v. 8)?

Prayer

Lamb of God, you alone are worthy to be worshipped. The power of this world seems great, and it cries: Who is like the beast? But I confess: Who is a God like you? You were slaughtered for me, and my name is written in your book of life.

Forgive me for the small compromises with which I try to fit in, and for the thoughts and deeds with which I honour the idols of my time. Forgive me when I try to stand with one foot with you and the other with the beast.

Thank you that you sealed me before I knew anything of this struggle. Give me the wisdom to recognise the counterfeits, and the endurance and faith of the saints. Let my hand and my forehead belong to you today. In the name of the Lamb, Amen.

DAY 20

The Lamb on Mount Zion: His Name on Our Foreheads

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 14:1–20

[1] And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion, and with him a hundred and forty-four thousand who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads. [2] And I heard a sound from heaven like the sound of many waters and like the sound of loud thunder; and the sound that I heard was like lyre players playing on their lyres. [3] And they sing something like a new song before the throne and before the four living creatures and the elders; and no one could learn the song except the hundred and forty-four thousand, who have been purchased from the earth. [4] These are the ones who have not defiled themselves with women, for they are virgins. These are the ones who follow the Lamb wherever he goes. These were purchased from among people as firstfruits for God and for the Lamb, [5] and no lie was found in their mouth; they are without blemish.

[6] And I saw another angel flying in midheaven, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who are settled on the earth and to every nation and tribe and language and people. [7] He said with a loud voice, "Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgement has come; and worship the one who made heaven and earth and sea and the springs of water!"

[8] And another, a second angel, followed, saying, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great, who has made all the nations drink of the wine of the fury of her harlotry!"

[9] And another, a third angel, followed them, saying with a loud voice, "If anyone worships the beast and its image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand, [10] he too will drink of the wine of the fury of God, poured undiluted into the cup of his wrath, and he will be tormented with fire and sulphur before holy angels and before the Lamb. [11] And the smoke of their torment goes up for ever and ever, and they have no rest day or night, those who worship the beast and its image, and whoever receives the mark of its name." [12] Here is the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and faith in Jesus.

13 And I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Write: Blessed are the dead
who die in the Lord from now on." "Yes," says the Spirit, "so that they
may rest from their toil, for their works go with them."

14 And I looked, and there was a white cloud, and seated on the cloud
was one like a son of man, with a golden crown on his head and a sharp
sickle in his hand. 15 And another angel came out of the temple, crying
out with a loud voice to the one seated on the cloud, "Send out your
sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, for the harvest of the
earth is dry and ripe." 16 And the one seated on the cloud swung his
sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped.

17 And another angel came out of the temple in heaven, and he too had a
sharp sickle. 18 And another angel came from the altar, the one who has
authority over the fire, and he called with a loud voice to the one who
had the sharp sickle, saying, "Send out your sharp sickle and gather the
clusters from the vine of the earth, for its grapes are ripe." 19 And the an-
gel swung his sickle over the earth and gathered the vintage of the vine
of the earth and threw it into the great winepress of the fury of God.
20 And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out
of the winepress up to the horses' bridles, for a distance of a thousand
six hundred stadia.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday was a heavy day. The dragon on the sand, the beast from the sea, the beast from the earth, and a mark without which no one can buy or sell. A reader in Pergamum or Thyatira might have wondered whether anyone was left who had not bowed down. Then John says: "And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion". The dragon stands on the sand of the sea; the Lamb stands on the rock of Zion.

Zion was the mountain of Jerusalem, the place where God installed his king (Psalm 2:6) and where, the prophets said, he himself would reign: "and the LORD will reign over them on Mount Zion from now on and for ever" (Micah 4:7). John does not mean the hill on the map. The letter to the Hebrews says to ordinary believers: "But you have approached Mount Zion and the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem" (Hebrews 12:22). Zion is the place where God's people stand with their King – already now.

With the Lamb stand "a hundred and forty-four thousand who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads." We met them in chapter 7: the whole people of God, sealed before the storm. Here the seal is given its content. It is a name. In Israel the high priest wore a golden plate on his forehead with the words "Holy to the LORD" (Exodus 28:36–38). Now the whole people bear the Name, as a kingdom of priests. And in the last chapter of the Bible it rings out again: "his name will be on their foreheads" (22:4).

The rest of the chapter is a preview of everything still to come – the eternal gospel, the fall of Babylon, the two harvests – and it begins with the Lamb and his people.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Written on their foreheads (*gegrammenon epi tōn metōpōn autōn* – γεγραμμένον ἐπὶ τῶν μετώπων αὐτῶν, v. 1):** The verb form describes something that has been written and stays written. The name of the Lamb is a lasting gift. (The SBLGNT has "his name and his Father's name"; older editions only the Father's name.)
- **Those who follow the Lamb (*hoi akolouthountes tō arniō* – οἱ ἀκολουθοῦντες τῷ ἀρνίῳ, v. 4):** The present tense describes a way of life: they keep following, "wherever he goes". It is Jesus' own call to his disciples: Follow me. Of the beast's worshippers it was said that "the whole earth followed the beast in amazement" (13:3); these people follow the Lamb.

- **Firstfruits (*aparchē* – ἀπαρχὴ, v. 4):** The first sheaf of the harvest, dedicated to God as the pledge of the whole harvest (Leviticus 23:10). Jeremiah calls Israel the firstfruits of God's harvest (Jeremiah 2:3). The Lamb's people are God's first sheaf from humanity.
- **An eternal gospel (*euangelion aiōnion* – εὐαγγέλιον αἰώνιον, v. 6):** The only time the word "gospel" occurs in Revelation – and it is proclaimed to "every nation and tribe and language and people". Even in the shadow of the beast the door is still open.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Those who belong to the Lamb bear his name.** Yesterday's question – whose are you? – receives its answer today: the name of the Father and the Son, given to those "who have been purchased from the earth" (v. 3; cf. 5:9). It is not enforced by threats but given by grace. The names of this world will pass away; his name remains.

2. **The Lamb's people are an army that fights as the Lamb fights.** That they are "virgins" does not mean that only the unmarried belong to the Lamb. The Old Testament uses the picture of soldiers keeping themselves pure for holy war (Deuteronomy 23:9–14; 1 Samuel 21:5) and of Israel as the bride who faithfully follows her God (Jeremiah 2:2). And "no lie was found in their mouth" – like the remnant of whom Zephaniah says that they speak no lie (Zephaniah 3:13). Against the beast's deception stands a people of the truth.

3. **The judgement is serious, but the gospel comes first.** The first angel cries, "Fear God and give him glory", and worship the one who made all things – as Jonah confessed to the sailors that he feared the God of heaven, "he who made the sea and the dry land" (Jonah 1:9). Only then come the fall of Babylon (Isaiah 21:9) and the warning to those who worship the beast, in the language of Sodom's fire and sulphur (Genesis 19:24). God warns because he wants people to turn back.

4. **The Son of Man will reap.** On the white cloud sits "one like a son of man" (Daniel 7:13) with a sickle. The prophet Joel had already said: Send out the sickle, for the harvest is ripe (Joel 3:13). Many interpreters read the grain harvest (vv. 14–16) as the gathering of God's people, and the grapes in the winepress (vv. 17–20) as judgement (cf. Isaiah 63:1–6). The winepress is trodden "outside the city", over an area as large as the land itself – and some recall that Jesus too suffered outside the city (Hebrews 13:12).

Living It Out

We live in an age of labels. Your job, your income, your looks and your number of followers tell the world who you are. Many of us carry those labels heavily, as if they were written on our foreheads. Revelation 14 says: another name has been written over you, and it is neither your achievement nor your failure. It is the name of the Father and of the Lamb.

To bear that name is first of all a comfort. On the days when you feel that the beast is stronger and your faith is small, you still stand with the Lamb on Zion. It is not you who keep yourself there. He has purchased you.

But it is also a calling. Of those who bear his name it is said: "These are the ones who follow the Lamb wherever he goes." That sometimes means going where you would rather not: to the difficult conversation, to forgiveness, to the people others avoid. And it means being a person of the truth in a world full of half-truths.

And then there is the comfort of verse 13 for everyone who has lost a loved one in the Lord: "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on." They rest, and their works go with them. Nothing done in love for the Lamb is lost.

Watch your words tomorrow. When you notice that you want to tell a small lie to look good or to avoid trouble, tell the truth instead, gently – and thank the Lamb that you may bear his name.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which of the world's "labels" weighs most heavily on you, and what changes when you write the name of the Father and the Lamb over it (v. 1)?
- Where is the Lamb leading you at the moment that you would rather not follow (v. 4)?
- Is there a "small lie" in your mouth that you have grown so used to that you no longer notice it (v. 5)?
- How does verse 13 comfort you about someone you have lost – or about your own death?

Prayer

You stand on Mount Zion, Lamb of God, and I may stand with you. Thank you that you have purchased me from the earth, and that your name and your Father's name are written over my life. No mark of this world is stronger than that.

I confess that I wear the world's labels as if they were my true name. Forgive me for the lies, great and small, and for the times I did not want to follow you where you went.

Teach me to follow you wherever you go, with a mouth without a lie and a heart that belongs to you. And when one day I die in the Lord, let me rest in the knowledge that you do not forget my small works of love. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 21

The Song of Moses and of the Lamb: Singing on the Shore

SCRIPTURE
Revelation 15:1–8

1 And I saw another sign in heaven, great and wonderful: seven angels
with seven plagues, the last ones, for with them the fury of God is
completed.

2 And I saw something like a sea of glass mixed with fire, and those who
conquer the beast and its image and the number of its name, standing
beside the sea of glass, holding lyres of God. 3 And they sing the song of
Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb, saying:

Great and wonderful are your works,
Lord God, the Almighty;
just and true are your ways,
King of the ages.
4 Who will not fear you, Lord,
and glorify your name?
For you alone are holy.
For all the nations will come
and worship before you,
for your righteous acts have been revealed.

5 And after this I looked, and the temple of the tent of witness in heaven
was opened, 6 and the seven angels who had the seven plagues came out
of the temple, dressed in clean, shining linen, with golden sashes
around their chests. 7 And one of the four living creatures gave the seven
angels seven golden bowls full of the fury of God, who lives for ever and
ever. 8 And the temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and
from his power, and no one could enter the temple until the seven
plagues of the seven angels were completed.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

A new sign appears in heaven, "great and wonderful: seven angels with seven plagues, the last ones, for with them the fury of God is completed." After the Lamb on Mount Zion and the harvest of the earth, you would expect the next scene to be the plagues themselves. But before a single bowl is poured out, we first hear a song.

John sees "something like a sea of glass mixed with fire". We have seen this sea before the throne already, "like crystal" (4:6). Now it glows with fire. And beside the sea stand "those who conquer the beast and its image and the number of its name", holding lyres. Anyone who knew the Old Testament would recognise the picture: Israel on the shore of the Red Sea, behind them the water that had covered Pharaoh's army, and Moses and Miriam singing: I sing to the LORD, for he has risen high, so high; horse and rider he has hurled into the sea (Exodus 15:1, 21). In the Bible the sea is often the picture of chaos and threat – the beast came up out of the sea (13:1). But this sea lies still before the throne, and God's people stand safely on the far side of it.

Think of the first readers. For them the beast was no abstract idea. It was the power that demanded that everyone honour its image, the pressure in the marketplace, the price some of their brothers and sisters had already paid for their witness. Yet it is precisely them – not the emperors – whom John sees standing on the shore and singing. They have conquered the beast in the way of the Lamb: by refusing to bow, even when it cost them their lives (12:11).

Then, in verse 5, "the temple of the tent of witness in heaven was opened". This is the language of the wilderness: the tent that Moses built, with the tablets of the testimony in the ark (Exodus 38:21; 40:20). When it was finished, the glory of the LORD filled it, so that Moses could not go in (Exodus 40:34–35; compare Isaiah 6:4). The same happens here: "no one could en-

ter the temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels were completed." Plagues, sea, song and tent – Revelation 15 retells the whole exodus in eight verses, and tomorrow the bowls are poured out.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Those who conquer the beast (*tous nikōntas ek tou thēriou* – τοὺς νικῶντας ἐκ τοῦ θηρίου, v. 2):** The participle is in the present tense, like the promise to every church: "To the one who conquers ..." (2:7–3:21). The preposition *ek* ("out of") is unusual; many interpreters hear in it that they have broken free from the grip of the beast.
- **The song of Moses ... and the song of the Lamb (*tēn ōdēn Mōyseōs ... kai tēn ōdēn tou arniou* – τὴν ᾠδὴν Μωϋσέως ... καὶ τὴν ᾠδὴν τοῦ ἀρνίου, v. 3):** Probably not two songs but one: the song of the exodus, now sung about a greater exodus. The blood of the Passover lamb brought Israel out of Egypt (Exodus 12); the blood of the Lamb has purchased people for God "from every tribe and language and people and nation" (5:9).
- **King of the ages (*ho basileus tōn aiōnōn* – ὁ βασιλεὺς τῶν αἰώνων, v. 3):** Emperors come and go; God is King over every era of history.
- **You alone are holy (*monos hosios* – μόνος ὅσιος, v. 4):** Hosios is seldom used of God in the New Testament. In the Greek translation of the song of Moses in Deuteronomy 32:4, God is called *dikaios kai hosios*, "just and holy" – the two words that are said of God together again in 16:5.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The victory is sung before the battle seems over.** The song comes before the bowls, not after them. Israel sang on the shore while the whole wilderness still lay ahead of them, on the way to the land God had promised. In the same way God's people know the outcome before the last plague is poured out: the Lamb has already conquered (5:5), and those who belong to him already stand safely on the far side of the sea.

2. **The song is about God, not about the singers.** There is not a word about their own suffering or courage; every line is addressed to God. The words are woven from the Old Testament: the song by the sea (Exodus 15:11), the psalms (Psalm 111:2; 86:9) and Jeremiah's question, who would not fear you, King of the nations? (Jeremiah 10:7).

3. **In the middle of judgement there is hope for the nations.** "For all the nations will come and worship before you." This is the promise of the prophets – Micah says: "Many nations will come" (Micah 4:2). God's judgements reveal his "righteous acts", so that people may see him as he is. The bowls of fury and the hope for the nations stand in one and the same chapter.

4. **God judges from his holy presence, according to what he has openly made known.** The seven angels come out of "the tent of witness", the place of the covenant and its tablets. God's judgement is not arbitrary; he judges according to his own testimony. The angels are dressed like priests, "with golden sashes around their chests", like the son of man among the lampstands (1:13). The smoke in the temple says that his holiness is serious.

Living It Out

There are times when singing comes easily, and times when you can hardly get the words out. Perhaps you are not yet standing on the shore but in the middle of the sea: a diagnosis that does not change, a marriage that has become hard, a workplace where faithfulness costs you something. Revelation 15 does not ask you to pretend that all is well; it shows you where the story ends: with a people standing beside the sea and singing.

That is why the church's song is not merely an expression of how we feel. It is an act of faith. When a small congregation sings on an ordinary Sunday, it is already rehearsing the song of the shore. Every time we sing

"just and true are your ways", we say something we cannot always see yet, but which God already knows.

Notice, too, who the conquerors are. Not the successful or the influential, but ordinary believers who refused to bow before the image of the beast. Today that bowing may look different: going along with dishonesty at work, or worshipping what everyone worships – success, security, status. Every time you say no and stay with the Lamb, you conquer in his way, even if it does not feel like a victory at all. And because the song is not about the singers, it lifts our eyes too, to the one whose works are "great and wonderful". That does not make our problems smaller, but it puts them into bigger hands.

Begin every morning this week with the song of Revelation 15:3–4 – sing it, or say it slowly – and then thank God for one concrete work he has done in your life.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Where are you standing at the moment: still in the sea, or already on the shore? What would it mean to sing the song of verse 3 now already?
- Which "image of the beast" is currently asking you to bow – at work, among your friends, in your own heart (v. 2)?
- How many of your prayers are about God himself – his works, his ways, his name – and how many only about you (vv. 3–4)?
- Do you believe that all the nations will come and worship (v. 4)? For which person or people who seem far from God do you want to start praying?

Prayer

> *Lord God, the Almighty, King of the ages: great and wonderful are your works, just and true are your ways. You led your people through the sea, and through the blood of the Lamb you have brought us out from the power*

of sin and death. You alone are holy.

Forgive me for so often singing only when things go well, and falling silent when the water is high. Forgive me for the times I have bowed before the images of this world because it was easier than staying faithful.

Teach me to sing the song of the shore now already. Keep me with the Lamb, and let me one day stand before you with people from all the nations and worship you for ever. Amen.

DAY 22

The Seven Bowls Are Poured Out: It Is Done!

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 16:1–21

1 And I heard a loud voice from the temple saying to the seven angels,
"Go and pour out the seven bowls of the fury of God on the earth!"

2 And the first went and poured out his bowl on the earth; and a foul and
evil sore came on the people who had the mark of the beast and who
worshipped its image.

3 And the second poured out his bowl into the sea; and it became blood
like that of a dead man, and every living soul died, everything that was
in the sea.

4 And the third poured out his bowl into the rivers and the springs of
water; and they became blood. 5 And I heard the angel of the waters say:

Just are you, who is and who was, the Holy One,
because you have judged these things;
6 for they poured out the blood of saints and prophets,
and you have given them blood to drink.
They deserve it.

7 And I heard the altar say:

Yes, Lord God, the Almighty,
true and just are your judgements.

8 And the fourth poured out his bowl on the sun; and it was allowed to
scorch people with fire. 9 And the people were scorched with fierce heat,
and they blasphemed the name of God, who has authority over these
plagues, and they did not repent and give him glory.

10 And the fifth poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast; and its
kingdom was plunged into darkness, and people gnawed their tongues
in pain, 11 and they blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains
and their sores, and they did not repent of their works.

12 And the sixth poured out his bowl on the great river, the Euphrates;
and its water was dried up, so that the way would be prepared for the
kings from the rising of the sun. 13 And I saw coming out of the mouth of

the dragon and out of the mouth of the beast and out of the mouth of the false prophet three unclean spirits like frogs. [14] For they are spirits of demons that perform signs, and they go out to the kings of the whole world, to gather them for the war of the great day of God, the Almighty. [15] – "Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes, so that he does not walk around naked and people see his shame." – [16] And they gathered them at the place that is called in Hebrew Armageddon.

[17] And the seventh poured out his bowl into the air; and a loud voice came out of the temple, from the throne, saying, "It is done!" [18] And there were lightning and sounds and thunder, and there was a great earthquake, such as there had never been since people were on the earth, so great an earthquake, so mighty. [19] And the great city split into three parts, and the cities of the nations fell. And God remembered Babylon the Great, to give her the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath. [20] And every island fled, and mountains were not found. [21] And great hail, each stone as heavy as a talent, comes down from heaven on the people; and the people blasphemed God because of the plague of the hail, for its plague is exceedingly great.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we heard God's people singing on the shore of the sea of glass, and the seven angels received seven golden bowls. Today a loud voice rings out from the temple: "Go and pour out the seven bowls of the fury of God on the earth!" What follows is one of the hardest chapters in the Bible to read. But anyone at home in the Old Testament recognises the images: these are the plagues of Egypt. The sores (Exodus 9:9–11), the Nile turned to blood (Exodus 7:17–21), the darkness over the land (Exodus 10:21–23), the frogs (Exodus 8:2–7), the hail (Exodus 9:22–26). Back then God brought the plagues on Pharaoh because he held God's people in slavery and had their sons drowned in the Nile (Exodus 1:22). Now the plagues fall on the king-

dom of the beast, on "the people who had the mark of the beast and who worshipped its image", and the fifth bowl is poured out "on the throne of the beast". For believers who lived every day in the shadow of Rome's throne, this was a liberating message: that throne is not eternal.

We have already seen similar images with the trumpets (chapters 8–9), but there a third of the earth was struck, here everything. The bowls are not the next chapter in a calendar but the same reality in its full seriousness: the trumpets warn, the bowls show that God's patience with evil has an end.

The sixth bowl dries up the Euphrates, "so that the way would be prepared for the kings from the rising of the sun". For the first readers the Euphrates was the eastern frontier beyond which the dreaded Parthians waited. But the image is older: according to the Greek historian Herodotus (*Histories* 1.191), Cyrus took ancient Babylon by diverting the river, and Jeremiah said in God's name: I will dry up her sea (Jeremiah 51:36). Then three unclean spirits like frogs come out of the mouth of the dragon, the beast and the false prophet to gather the kings of the world "at the place that is called in Hebrew Armageddon".

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Bowls (*phialas* – φιάλας, v. 1):** From *phialē*. The same word as the "golden bowls full of incense, which are the prayers of the saints" (5:8). Many interpreters see a deliberate link: the bowls of wrath are part of God's answer to the prayers of his people (compare 8:3–5).
- **They deserve it (*axioi eisin* – ἄξιοί εἰσιν, v. 6):** The same word as "Worthy are you" (4:11; 5:9), used here with sharp irony. They "poured out the blood of saints and prophets" – the same verb as the pouring out of the bowls – and now they drink blood. God's judgement fits the evil exactly.

- **They did not repent (*ou metenoēsan* – οὐ μετενόησαν, vv. 9, 11):** As with the trumpets (9:20–21). The plagues by themselves bring no one to repentance, just as Pharaoh's heart grew harder with every plague (Exodus 8:15, 32).
- **Armageddon (*Harmagedōn* – Ἁρμαγεδών, v. 16):** According to most interpreters, "the mountain of Megiddo". Megiddo lies at the edge of the plain where famous battles were fought: Deborah and Barak against the kings of Canaan (Judges 5:19), and there King Josiah fell (2 Kings 23:29). But there is no mountain of Megiddo; the name is a symbol of the final revolt of the kings against God. (Futurists expect a literal battle in Israel.) The battle itself is never described.
- **It is done (*Gegonen* – Γέγονεν, v. 17):** The perfect tense – something has happened and stands. The same verb sounds again at the new creation (*Gegonan*, 21:6). Many also hear in it an echo of Jesus' last word on the cross, that all is finished (John 19:30), even though a different Greek word stands there.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's wrath is his just "no" to the evil that destroys his creation and his people.** The angel of the waters says, "Just are you, who is and who was, the Holy One", and the altar answers, "Yes, Lord God, the Almighty, true and just are your judgements." Beneath that altar the souls cried, "How long" (6:10). Now the altar says yes. God's wrath is not a mood; it is his faithfulness to the victims.
2. **Judgement alone does not change a heart.** Three times the people blaspheme God, and twice we read that they did not repent. They know who has authority over the plagues; the problem is a heart that will not give him glory (v. 9). That is the tragedy of Pharaoh – and a warning to anyone who thinks that a big enough shock would make him turn round.

3. **In the middle of the storm Christ speaks to his own.** Suddenly he interrupts the scene: "Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes." These are the words to Sardis (3:3) and to Laodicea (3:18). In Egypt God made a distinction between his people in Goshen and the land of Pharaoh (Exodus 8:22; 9:26). The bowls strike those who bear the mark of the beast, not those who bear his seal (7:3). Believers still suffer in this world, but they do not stand under God's wrath.

4. **The end of evil has already been decided.** The kings gather for war, but before any battle is described, the voice from the throne rings out: "It is done!" God remembers Babylon, the great city – and tomorrow we see who she really is. The story that began in Egypt does not end at Armageddon but at the new creation (21:6).

Living It Out

Honestly, this chapter makes us uncomfortable. We prefer the Lamb to the bowls. But ask someone who has suffered injustice – a woman abused for years, a church under persecution, a people devastated by war – and they will tell you: a God who never judged evil would not be good. Revelation 16 is comfort for those who suffer, not a weapon for threatening others.

That is why we should not read this chapter about "other people", but about our own hearts. Pain can drive a person closer to God, or it can make you bitter and hard. Which happens to you when life is hard – prayer or bitterness? There is no shame in telling God that you are angry and hurt; the souls under the altar did that too. But there is a difference between crying out to God and cursing God.

And then Jesus' word in the middle: stay awake and keep your clothes. Staying awake does not mean calculating dates or searching the news for signs. It means living every day as someone who belongs to Christ, clothed in his righteousness.

Take two minutes tonight and ask yourself where you have fallen asleep this past week – in your prayer, your honesty, your love. Confess it, and then pray for one person or place in the world that suffers injustice, using the words of verse 7: Yes, Lord, true and just are your judgements.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What injustice – in your own life or in the world – makes you long for God to intervene (vv. 5–7)?
- When something hurts, do you become softer or harder towards God (vv. 9, 11)?
- Where have you fallen asleep spiritually lately, and which "clothes" of faith have you left lying about (v. 15)?
- Do you really believe that the end of evil has already been decided (v. 17)? How would that change your fear today?

Prayer

> *Just and holy are you, Lord God, the Almighty, and true and just are your judgements. You see every tear of your suffering children and every drop of blood poured out on the earth. You judged Pharaoh's kingdom and set your people free, and you will bring the evil of our time to an end as well.*
>
> *When things hurt, I easily become bitter, and sometimes I harden my heart against you instead of crying out to you. Forgive me, also for the places where I have fallen asleep and left the clothes of my faith lying about.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, you are coming soon. Keep me awake, clothe me in your righteousness, and let me live as someone who belongs to you. Thank you that I do not stand under your wrath, because you drank the cup for me. In your name, Amen.*

DAY 23

The Prostitute on the Beast: Why Are You Amazed?

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 17:1–18

[1] And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls came and spoke
with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the judgement of the great
prostitute who sits on many waters, [2] with whom the kings of the earth
committed harlotry, and those who live on the earth became drunk
with the wine of her harlotry." [3] And he carried me away in the Spirit
into a wilderness. And I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was
full of names of blasphemy and had seven heads and ten horns. [4] And
the woman was dressed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and
precious stone and pearls; she had in her hand a golden cup full of
abominations and the impurities of her harlotry, [5] and on her forehead a
name was written, a mystery: "Babylon the Great, the mother of prosti-
tutes and of the abominations of the earth." [6] And I saw the woman
drunk with the blood of the saints and with the blood of the witnesses to
Jesus. And when I saw her, I was greatly amazed.

[7] And the angel said to me, "Why are you amazed? I will tell you the mys-
tery of the woman and of the beast that carries her, which has the seven
heads and the ten horns. [8] The beast that you saw was, and is not, and is
about to come up out of the abyss and go to destruction. And those who
live on the earth, whose name has not been written in the book of life
from the foundation of the world, will be amazed when they see the
beast, because it was and is not and will be present. [9] Here is the under-
standing that has wisdom: the seven heads are seven mountains on
which the woman sits. They are also seven kings: [10] five have fallen, one
is, the other has not yet come; and when he comes, he must remain only
a little while. [11] And the beast that was and is not is itself an eighth, and
it belongs to the seven, and it goes to destruction. [12] And the ten horns
that you saw are ten kings who have not yet received a kingdom, but
they receive authority as kings for one hour together with the beast.
[13] These have one purpose, and they give their power and authority to
the beast. [14] These will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will con-
quer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings, and those with him
are called and chosen and faithful." [15] And he says to me, "The waters
that you saw, where the prostitute sits, are peoples and crowds and na-

tions and languages. [16] And the ten horns that you saw, and the beast, these will hate the prostitute; they will make her devastated and naked, and they will eat her flesh and burn her up with fire. [17] For God has put it into their hearts to carry out his purpose, to carry out one purpose, and to give their kingdom to the beast, until the words of God are fulfilled. [18] And the woman that you saw is the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of the earth."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

One of the seven angels with the bowls takes John aside: "Come, I will show you the judgement of the great prostitute who sits on many waters." At the seventh bowl God "remembered Babylon the Great" (16:19). Now the angel wants to show who she is.

First John **hears**: a great prostitute who sits on many waters, with whom "the kings of the earth committed harlotry". Ancient Babylon really did sit on many waters, on the Euphrates with its canals; Jeremiah addresses her in just that way (Jeremiah 51:13). But then the angel "carried me away in the Spirit into a wilderness", and John **sees**: "a woman sitting on a scarlet beast". As so often in Revelation, the seeing interprets the hearing. The city that sounds so mighty actually sits in a wilderness, and her throne is a beast – the same beast with seven heads and ten horns that we saw coming up out of the sea in chapter 13. And at the end of the chapter that very beast will tear her apart.

For the first readers the picture was not hard to recognise. The angel himself says: "the seven heads are seven mountains on which the woman sits", and "the woman that you saw is the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of the earth." Rome was the well-known city on seven hills, and on a coin from the time of the emperor Vespasian the goddess Roma sits on the seven hills. She is "dressed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearls", with a golden cup in her hand – the image

of Jeremiah 51:7, where Babylon was a golden cup that made the whole earth drunk. But the cup is "full of abominations", and she is "drunk with the blood of the saints and with the blood of the witnesses to Jesus".

Yet Babylon is more than Rome. In the great story of the Bible she begins at Babel, where people wanted to build a tower reaching to heaven to make a name for themselves (Genesis 11:4). She destroyed Jerusalem and the temple and carried God's people into exile. The prophets also called Tyre, the trading city, a prostitute (Isaiah 23:17), and Nineveh "lovely and charming, mistress of sorceries" (Nahum 3:4). Babylon is every power in every age that seduces people with luxury and makes them forget to whom they belong.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Prostitute / harlotry (*tēs pornēs / tēs porneias* – τῆς πόρνης / τῆς πορνείας, vv. 1–2):** From *pornē* and *porneia*. In the prophets harlotry is the picture of unfaithfulness to God: giving your love and trust to other gods and powers (Hosea 2; Ezekiel 16). Here it is about the kings and nations who have bound themselves to Rome's power and wealth.
- **I was greatly amazed (*ethaumasa … thauma mega* – ἐθαύμασα … θαῦμα μέγα, v. 6):** Literally, "I wondered with a great wonder." Even John is impressed. The angel asks: "Why are you amazed?" The same verb describes, in verse 8, those who live on the earth, who are amazed when they see the beast (compare 13:3). The danger of Babylon is not that she is repulsive, but that she is so impressive.
- **A mystery (*mystērion* – μυστήριον, v. 5):** On her forehead is written "Babylon the Great, the mother of prostitutes". Over against her stand God's people with the name of the Lamb and of his Father on their foreheads (14:1).
- **Was, and is not, and will be present (*ēn kai ouk estin kai parestai* – ἦν καὶ οὐκ ἔστιν καὶ παρέσται, v. 8):** A deliberate imitation of God's name, "who is and who was and who is coming" (1:4). The beast wants to be like God, but its "was" is only past, and its end is "destruction". (Many

interpreters think here of the rumour that Nero would return; the seven kings of verses 9–11 are hard to match with particular emperors, and seven is probably the number of completeness.)

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **There are two women and two cities, and no neutral ground.** The same angel who leads John to the prostitute here will later say to him: "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb" (21:9). Once he is carried away into a wilderness, the other time "to a great, high mountain" (21:10). The prostitute wears purple and gold; the bride is clothed "in fine linen, shining and clean" (19:8). And the woman of chapter 12, God's people, also fled into the wilderness – but there she is fed by God (12:6), while the prostitute gets drunk on blood. Revelation does not ask who the others are, but: to which woman do you belong?

2. **Babylon's splendour sits on a beast.** Her wealth and glamour rest on violence, blasphemy and the blood of the witnesses. What looks like a royal throne is a beast that will in the end hate her and lay her waste (v. 16). In the end evil destroys its own allies too.

3. **God is in control, even of the evil that destroys itself.** "For God has put it into their hearts to carry out his purpose ... until the words of God are fulfilled." Even the struggle between the beast and the prostitute serves God's plan, and their authority lasts only "for one hour".

4. **The Lamb conquers, and his people are with him.** "The Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings" – the title of God in Deuteronomy 10:17 and Daniel 2:47. And those who are with him are not described as powerful or rich, but as "called and chosen and faithful".

Living It Out

The most honest verse in the chapter may be verse 6: John was greatly amazed. If even the apostle could be impressed by Babylon, so can we. She does not appear as a monster but as a queen in purple with a golden cup. She does not whisper "deny your faith", but "you deserve better" and "everyone does it". She promises security, status and pleasure.

This is where the pattern of hearing and seeing helps. Babylon sounds impressive – many waters, kings, riches. But when God lets you look in the Spirit, you see the wilderness she sits in and the beast she rides. Look behind the glamour: what does it cost, and who pays for it? The angel's question – "Why are you amazed?" – is not a rebuke; he wants to open your eyes.

This does not mean that we should become suspicious of everything beautiful or successful, or point the finger at other people as "Babylon". The question is personal: what impresses *me* so much that it begins to draw my heart away from the Lamb? For one person it is money, for another recognition or a lifestyle everyone admires.

And then the good news: the Lamb conquers, and those with him are called, chosen and faithful. You do not become faithful by your own willpower; you have been called and chosen by the one who will not let you go.

This week, notice when you are "amazed" – when an advertisement, someone's life on social media or an offer at work stirs up longing in you. Then ask with the angel: why am I amazed? And thank God for one thing the Lamb has given you that Babylon can never give.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What impresses you at the moment so much that, like John, you are amazed by it (v. 6)?

- If you look behind the glamour of that thing, what "beast" might you see it riding on (v. 3)?
- Whose name would be written on your forehead if your choices of the past week were the writing (v. 5; 14:1)?
- What does it mean to you that those with the Lamb are called "called and chosen and faithful" (v. 14)?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, Lamb of God, you are Lord of lords and King of kings. The powers of this world look great and glamorous, but they sit on a beast that goes to destruction. You alone conquer, and your kingdom remains for ever.*
>
> *Forgive me for being so easily impressed by what glitters, and for sometimes drinking from Babylon's cup in my heart. Forgive me for the times I have given my love and my trust to things that cannot save me.*
>
> *Open my eyes to see behind the glamour. Thank you that I am called and chosen, and that I belong to you. Keep me with you, so that I may stay faithful and one day be part of your bride, clothed in fine linen, shining and clean. Amen.*

DAY 24

Come Out of Her, My People: The Fall of Babylon

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 18:1–24

[1] After this I saw another angel coming down from heaven, who had
great authority, and the earth was lit up by his glory. [2] And he cried out
with a mighty voice, saying:

Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!
She has become a dwelling place of demons,
a prison of every unclean spirit,
a prison of every unclean bird,
a prison of every unclean and hated beast.
[3] For by the wine of the fury of her harlotry
all the nations have fallen,
and the kings of the earth committed harlotry with her,
and the merchants of the earth grew rich
from the power of her luxury.

[4] And I heard another voice from heaven saying:

Come out of her, my people,
so that you do not share in her sins
and do not receive any of her plagues.
[5] For her sins have piled up to heaven,
and God has remembered her crimes.
[6] Repay her as she herself has repaid,
and pay her back double for her works;
in the cup in which she mixed, mix her a double portion.
[7] As much as she glorified herself and lived in luxury,
so much torment and grief give her.
For in her heart she says:
I sit as a queen;
I am no widow,
and I will never see grief.
[8] That is why her plagues will come in a single day,
pestilence and grief and famine,
and she will be burned up with fire;
for mighty is the Lord God who has judged her.

9 And the kings of the earth who committed harlotry with her and lived
in luxury will weep and mourn over her when they see the smoke of her
burning. 10 They will stand far off for fear of her torment and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
Babylon, the mighty city!
For in one hour your judgement has come.

11 And the merchants of the earth weep and grieve over her, because no
one buys their cargo any more, 12 cargo of gold and silver and precious
stone and pearls, and fine linen and purple and silk and scarlet, and all
kinds of citron wood and every article of ivory and every article of most
precious wood and bronze and iron and marble, 13 and cinnamon and
spice and incense and perfumed oil and frankincense, and wine and
olive oil and fine flour and wheat, and cattle and sheep, and horses and
carriages, and bodies – and human souls.

14 And the fruit your soul longed for
has gone from you,
and all the luxuries and the splendour
are lost to you,
and they will never find them again.

15 The merchants of these things, who grew rich from her, will stand far
off for fear of her torment, weeping and grieving, 16 and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet,
and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearl!
17 For in one hour such great wealth has been devastated.
And every ship's captain and everyone who sails anywhere, and sailors
and all who make their living from the sea, stood far off

18 and cried out when they saw the smoke of her burning, saying, "Who
is like the great city?" 19 And they threw dust on their heads and cried
out, weeping and grieving, and said:

Woe, woe, the great city,
in which all who had ships on the sea

grew rich from her costly wealth!
For in one hour she has been devastated.
[20] Rejoice over her, heaven,
and you saints and apostles and prophets,
for God has judged your case against her.

[21] And a mighty angel picked up a stone like a great millstone and threw it into the sea, saying:

So with violence Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down,
and will never be found again.
[22] And the sound of lyre players and musicians,
of flute players and trumpeters,
will never be heard in you again,
and no craftsman of any craft
will ever be found in you again,
and the sound of the mill
will never be heard in you again,
[23] and the light of a lamp
will never shine in you again,
and the voice of bridegroom and bride
will never be heard in you again.
For your merchants were the nobles of the earth,
for by your sorcery all the nations were deceived,
[24] and in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints
and of all who have been slaughtered on the earth.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we saw the great prostitute on the beast, so impressive that even John was amazed. Today an angel with great authority comes down from heaven, "and the earth was lit up by his glory". His first words sound like a result already known: "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!" These are the words of Isaiah 21:9 about the fall of ancient Babylon.

John sees Babylon's fall through the eyes of three groups who stand far off and weep: the kings of the earth, the merchants and the sailors. The model is Ezekiel's lament over Tyre, the great trading city of the ancient world (Ezekiel 26–27), with its sailors who throw dust on their heads and ask who was like Tyre (Ezekiel 27:30–32).

Then comes the cargo list. It reads like the bill of lading of a ship docking at Ostia, Rome's port: "gold and silver and precious stone and pearls, and fine linen and purple and silk and scarlet", citron wood and ivory, some of it from Africa, cinnamon and spice from the East, wine, olive oil and wheat, cattle, horses and carriages. And then, at the very end: "and bodies – and human souls". "Bodies" was a trade word for slaves, and the empire ran on slave labour. Ezekiel also mentions the trade in human beings (Ezekiel 27:13), but somewhere in the middle of the list. John moves it to the end, where it strikes hardest, and he adds what the merchants did not want to see: these are not just bodies, they are souls.

For the churches in Asia this was no distant world. Ephesus and Smyrna were port cities that lived from this trade; in Thyatira the trade guilds, probably with their feasts in honour of the gods, were part of everyday working life (2:20); and Laodicea said, "I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing" (3:17). Here we hear the same voice from Babylon's heart: "I sit as a queen; I am no widow, and I will never see grief" – the words of Isaiah 47:7–8 about ancient Babylon. Babylon is not only out there. Her voice can speak in the church too.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Come out of her, my people (*Exelthate, ho laos mou, ex autēs* – Ἐξέλθατε, ὁ λαός μου, ἐξ αὐτῆς, v. 4):** The call of Jeremiah to the exiles in ancient Babylon (Jeremiah 51:6, 45; compare Isaiah 52:11). The Greek Old Testament uses the same verb for Israel's exodus from Egypt (e.g. Exodus 13:3): God's people are called out.

- **Share in (*synkoinōnēsēte* – συγκοινωνήσητε, v. 4):** Related to *koinōnia*, fellowship or partnership. The danger is not only doing wrong, but becoming Babylon's partner – sharing her values, her fears and her hope.
- **Luxury (*strēnous, estrēniasen* – στρήνους, ἐστρηνίασεν, vv. 3, 7):** From *strēnos*. Extravagant, self-satisfied luxury that makes you think you are safe. The kings and merchants "lived in luxury" and "grew rich from the power of her luxury".
- **Bodies – and human souls (*sōmatōn, kai psychas anthrōpōn* – σωμάτων, καὶ ψυχὰς ἀνθρώπων, v. 13):** Here the Greek suddenly changes its construction, as though John were interrupting the list; our translation marks this with a dash. The Lamb "purchased people for God" by his blood (5:9); Babylon buys and sells them.
- **Sorcery (*pharmakeia* – φαρμακείᾳ, v. 23):** The word of Nahum 3:4 about Nineveh, "mistress of sorceries". Babylon's power is not only economic; it is a spell by which "all the nations were deceived".

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Babylon's heart is self-glorification and false security.** "As much as she glorified herself and lived in luxury" – that is the core of her sin. She believes her wealth protects her from grief. But what feels like strength is poverty in God's eyes: "in a single day" her plagues will come (v. 8).

2. **Her wealth is built on souls and blood.** The chapter does not end with money but with blood: "and in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints and of all who have been slaughtered on the earth." Babylon is luxury, violence and idolatry in one. God sees the people in the hold, and he hears the blood of everyone who has been slaughtered – as he heard the blood of Abel (Genesis 4:10).

3. **"Come out" is the call of a new exodus.** As Israel was called out of Egypt and out of Babylon, so God's people are called out of the system of this world. The goal is not the wilderness, but the new Jerusalem,

where God dwells with people (21:1–3). The letter to the Hebrews puts it this way: "So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach. For here we have no city that lasts" (Hebrews 13:13–14).

4. **Babylon's silence makes room for the wedding of the Lamb.** A mighty angel throws a millstone into the sea, as Jeremiah's scroll was thrown with a stone into the Euphrates (Jeremiah 51:63–64). Then it falls silent: no music, no craft, no mill, no lamp, and "the voice of bridegroom and bride will never be heard in you again" (compare Jeremiah 25:10). But tomorrow another song rings out: "for the wedding of the Lamb has come" (19:7).

Living It Out

This chapter is not a sermon against money or trade. Wheat and wine and olive oil are good gifts of God. The problem is the heart that says, "I sit as a queen ... and I will never see grief." It is the voice we all know: if only I have enough, I will be safe; if the account is full, nothing can touch me. And without our noticing it can become ours too.

Notice what the merchants weep over. Not over the city, and not over the slaves, but "because no one buys their cargo any more". What we grieve over shows what our hearts are bound to.

Think, too, of the people in the list. Behind many of the things we buy and use there are people – workers in factories and on farms, people whose bodies and time are made cheap. And sometimes we ourselves become part of the cargo: when our worth is measured by what we produce. Babylon turns people into goods. The Lamb has purchased us with his blood, not to own us like a slave, but to set us free for God.

So "come out of her" does not mean fleeing into the wilderness. The first Christians went on living and working in Ephesus and Smyrna. It means living in the city without belonging to her: honest in your business, gen-

erous with what you have, with people rather than profits at the centre, and with your hope set on the city that lasts. This is the new exodus: not out of creation, but out of the power that corrupts it.

This week, do one thing that means "coming out". Give away something you would like to keep, or, with one purchase, ask who the people behind it are and pray for them. Not out of guilt, but as someone who already belongs to the Lamb.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Where do you hear the voice of verse 7 in your own heart: "I sit as a queen … I will never see grief"?
- What would you grieve over most if it were lost tomorrow – and what does that say about what your heart is bound to (v. 11)?
- Which people are perhaps only "cargo" to you – someone whose work you use without really seeing him or her (v. 13)?
- What would "Come out of her, my people" mean for your daily life, your work and your spending (v. 4)?

Prayer

> *Mighty is the Lord God who has judged Babylon. You see every person sold as cargo, and you hear the blood of all who have been slaughtered on the earth. Thank you that the Lamb did not sell me, but purchased me for you with his blood.*
>
> *Forgive me for the times I have said in my heart: I have enough; nothing can touch me. Forgive me for seeking security in what I own, and for sometimes seeing people only in terms of what they could do for me.*

Call me out, Lord, as you called your people out of Egypt and out of Babylon. Teach me to live in this world without belonging to her, and keep my eyes on the city that lasts, where you will dwell with your people. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 25

The Wedding of the Lamb: A Robe That Is Given

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 19:1–10

1 After this I heard something like the loud voice of a great crowd in
heaven, saying:

Hallelujah!
The salvation and the glory and the power belong to our God,
2 for true and just are his judgements;
for he has judged the great prostitute
who corrupted the earth with her harlotry,
and he has avenged the blood of his servants
from her hand.

3 And a second time they said:

Hallelujah!
Her smoke goes up for ever and ever.

4 And the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures fell down and
worshipped God, who sits on the throne, saying:

Amen. Hallelujah!

5 And a voice came out from the throne, saying:

Praise our God, all his servants,
and you who fear him, the small and the great!

6 And I heard something like the voice of a great crowd, and like the
sound of many waters, and like the sound of mighty thunder, saying:

Hallelujah!
For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign.
7 Let us rejoice and be glad,
and we will give him the glory,
for the wedding of the Lamb has come,
and his wife has made herself ready.
8 And it was given to her to clothe herself
in fine linen, shining and clean;
for the fine linen is the righteous acts of the saints.

[9] And he says to me, "Write: Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." And he says to me, "These are the true words of God." [10] And I fell down at his feet to worship him. And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am a fellow servant with you and with your brothers and sisters who hold to the testimony of Jesus. Worship God! For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

On earth the kings, the merchants and the sailors stand far off and weep over the ruins of Babylon. But John hears heaven's answer. Where the earth mourns, there sounds something like "the loud voice of a great crowd in heaven": "Hallelujah! The salvation and the glory and the power belong to our God."

This was no abstract poetry. The believers in Asia lived in cities where Rome's wealth rolled past every day – in the markets of Ephesus, in the banks of Laodicea, in the harbour of Smyrna. Some of their brothers and sisters had already lost their lives for their witness. In chapter 6 the souls under the altar cried out: "How long, holy and true Master, will you not judge and avenge our blood ...?" (6:10). Here is the answer: "for true and just are his judgements ... and he has avenged the blood of his servants." Their prayer has not been forgotten.

The word *Hallelujah* occurs in the whole New Testament only here, four times in six verses. It comes from the Psalms (e.g. Psalm 104:35; 106:1), where it is a call: Praise the LORD! Psalms 113–118, the so-called Hallel, were sung at Passover according to Jewish tradition – the feast of the exodus from Egypt. It fits: the fall of Babylon is the last exodus, and God's people sing as Israel sang on the shore of the sea (Exodus 15; cf. 15:3).

Then the music changes key. The song about judgement becomes a wedding song: "For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign. Let us rejoice and be glad ... for the wedding of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready." The Old Testament prepared this picture long ago. God calls himself Israel's husband (Isaiah 54:5) and promises in Hosea 2 to betroth her to himself for ever. Ezekiel describes how God washed the neglected girl Jerusalem and clothed her in fine linen (Ezekiel 16:8–13) – and then the painful word: she used her beauty to play the harlot (Ezekiel 16:15). The Bible begins with a wedding in the garden (Genesis 2:22–24), it is torn apart by unfaithfulness, and it ends with the wedding of the Lamb. John the Baptist called Jesus the Bridegroom (John 3:29), and Jesus himself told of a king's wedding feast (Matthew 22:1–14).

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Hallelujah (*Hallēlouia* – Ἀλληλουϊά, vv. 1, 3, 4, 6):** A Greek rendering of the Hebrew *hallelu-yah*, "praise Yah", with the short form of God's Name. John writes Greek, but he leaves the Hebrew word standing: heaven sings in the language of Israel's Psalms.
- **Has begun to reign (*ebasileusen* – ἐβασίλευσεν, v. 6):** The verb form here probably describes the beginning of an action. God has always reigned – "the LORD is king" (Psalm 93:1; 97:1) – but now his rule becomes visible and undisputed. No other throne competes with his any more.
- **She has made herself ready ... it was given to her (*hētoimasen heautēn ... edothē autē* – ἡτοίμασεν ἑαυτήν ... ἐδόθη αὐτῇ, vv. 7–8):** Two sides of one thing. The bride makes herself ready, but the robe is *given* to her – the passive form we meet all through Revelation when God is the Giver.
- **Fine linen, shining and clean (*byssinon lampron katharon* – βύσσινον λαμπρὸν καθαρόν, v. 8):** The same cloth was on Babylon's cargo list (18:12), and the great city was dressed in it (18:16). The prostitute buys her splendour with the wealth of the nations; the bride receives hers as a gift.

- **Righteous acts (*ta dikaiōmata tōn hagiōn* – τὰ δικαιώματα τῶν ἁγίων, v. 8):** The same word as for God's "righteous acts" in 15:4. The faithfulness of the saints is not an achievement of their own, but a reflection of God's righteousness in their lives.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Heaven's Hallelujah is the answer to the martyrs' "How long?"** The praise over Babylon's fall is not gloating. It is the joy that evil does not have the last word, that God's judgements are "true and just", and that no tear and no blood of his servants is forgotten. Whoever has never suffered injustice may find it hard to sing about judgement; the churches in Asia understood.

2. **The goal of history is not just a victory, but a wedding.** God's plan does not end on a battlefield, but at a feast. What began in Eden, what was torn apart by unfaithfulness and restored at the cross, is completed here. Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her (Ephesians 5:25); now she stands ready.

3. **Two women, two robes.** In chapter 17 the prostitute was "dressed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold" (17:4); here the bride stands in simple, clean linen. The one buys her splendour at the expense of others; the other receives hers by grace.

4. **God alone is worshipped.** Even John, overwhelmed by the vision, falls down before the angel. The answer is short: "Do not do that! I am a fellow servant with you." Angels, prophets and preachers are fellow servants, not objects of worship. And "the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy": all true prophecy points to Jesus, and whoever bears witness to Jesus stands in the line of the prophets.

Living It Out

The church does not always look like a bride. We know the scandals, the divisions, the weary congregations where fewer people turn up every year. It is easy to become cynical about the church – or to leave her quietly. Revelation 19 lets us see the church as Christ sees her: as his bride, for whom he paid with his blood and for whom he is coming back. If the Lamb loves her, we may not despise her.

The bride's robe also brings comfort for your own ordinary faithfulness. The prayers no one hears, the visit to the hospital, the honest answer at work, the patience with a difficult child – none of it vanishes into nothing. These are threads in the "fine linen". Not because you earn your place at the table with them – the robe is given – but because God weaves your small acts of love into the splendour of his bride.

And then there is the invitation: "Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." In Laodicea the Lord Jesus promised to eat with everyone who opens the door (3:20). Here we see where that meal leads. Every time the church celebrates the Lord's Supper, we taste something in advance of the feast that is coming.

Think today of one fellow believer you find hard to love, and pray for him or her as part of the bride of Christ.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What are you still crying "How long?" about – and does heaven's Hallelujah help you to believe that God's judgements are true and just (vv. 1–2)?
- Do you see the church more as a failure or as the bride of the Lamb (v. 7)? What would change if you saw her through his eyes?
- Are you trying to earn your robe yourself, or do you receive it as a gift (v. 8)?

- Which good things – leaders, experiences, even your ministry – are in danger of taking the place that belongs to God alone (v. 10)?

Prayer

Hallelujah! Lord God, the Almighty, the salvation and the glory and the power belong to you. Your judgements are true and just, and you do not forget the blood and the tears of your servants. With the great crowd in heaven I sing today that you reign.

I am sometimes cynical about your church, and I try to weave my own robe out of achievements and good works. Forgive me. Forgive me when I worship other things and other people, however good they are, instead of you alone.

Lord Jesus, Lamb of God, thank you that you love your bride and gave yourself for her. Thank you for the clean robe I could never have bought. Make me ready for the day of the wedding, and let my small acts of faithfulness today be part of her splendour. In your name, Amen.

DAY 26

Faithful and True: The Rider on the White Horse

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 19:11–21

11 And I saw heaven opened, and there was a white horse, and its rider is
called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war.
12 His eyes are a flame of fire, and on his head are many diadems, and he
has a name written that no one knows except himself. 13 And he is
dressed in a robe dipped in blood, and his name is called The Word of
God. 14 And the armies that are in heaven followed him on white horses,
dressed in fine linen, white and clean. 15 And out of his mouth comes a
sharp sword with which to strike down the nations, and he will shep-
herd them with an iron rod; and he treads the winepress of the wine of
the fury of the wrath of God, the Almighty. 16 And on his robe and on his
thigh he has a name written: King of kings and Lord of lords.

17 And I saw an angel standing in the sun, and he cried out with a loud
voice, saying to all the birds that fly in midheaven, "Come, gather for
the great supper of God, 18 to eat the flesh of kings and the flesh of gener-
als and the flesh of the powerful and the flesh of horses and their riders,
and the flesh of all, free and slave, small and great." 19 And I saw the
beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered to make war
on the rider of the horse and on his army. 20 And the beast was captured,
and with it the false prophet who had performed the signs before it, by
which he deceived those who had received the mark of the beast and
those who worshipped its image. The two of them were thrown alive
into the lake of fire that burns with sulphur. 21 And the rest were killed
with the sword of the rider of the horse, the sword that came out of his
mouth, and all the birds gorged themselves on their flesh.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday heaven sang: "the wedding of the Lamb has come." Today the Bridegroom himself comes. "And I saw heaven opened, and there was a white horse." In chapter 4 John saw a door open in heaven, so that he could go in and see the throne. Now heaven itself opens, so that the King can come out. This is the picture of Christ's return – which, together with the last judgement and the new creation, is the part of the great story that still lies ahead of us.

In the cities of Asia a rider on a white horse was the picture of a conqueror. Rome's generals and emperors celebrated their victories with triumphal processions through the city, and Roman poets sang of "eternal" Rome. But this Rider bears a name no emperor could bear: *Faithful and True*. That is exactly how the Lord Jesus introduced himself to Laodicea, as "the faithful and true witness" (3:14). The one who knocked at the door of the lukewarm church is the same one who comes as King.

The description is woven from the prophets. Isaiah says of the Messiah that he will strike the earth with the rod of his mouth and kill the wicked with the breath of his lips (Isaiah 11:4), and the Servant of the LORD says that God made his mouth a sharp sword (Isaiah 49:2). In Psalm 2:9 the Greek translation reads that the king will shepherd the nations with an iron rod. In Isaiah 63:1–3 the Lord comes from Edom with garments stained red, because he has trodden the winepress alone. And the terrible call to the birds comes from Ezekiel 39:17–20, where God invites the birds to eat the flesh of Gog's armies.

Notice too what John does not describe: a battle. The beast and the kings of the earth gather "to make war" – the same war we heard of at Armageddon (16:14, 16) and shall meet again tomorrow at Gog and Magog (20:8). In all three places the Greek has *ton polemon* (τὸν πόλεμον), "the war", and so many interpreters see here one and the same final conflict

from different angles. And each time there is really no fight at all. The beast is captured, the false prophet with it, and the rest fall by the sword from the Rider's mouth.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Faithful and True (*pistos … kai alēthinos* – πιστὸς … καὶ ἀληθινός, v. 11):** *Pistos* is someone who keeps his word; *alēthinos* is what is genuine, the real thing as against the counterfeit. In a book full of counterfeits – a beast that looks as though slain (13:3), a false prophet with horns like a lamb (13:11) – he is the Genuine One.
- **Dipped in blood (*bebammenon haimati* – βεβαμμένον αἵματι, v. 13):** His robe is already red before there is any fight. In Isaiah 63 it is the blood of the enemies, but many interpreters think here of his own blood, by which he purchased people for God (5:9; 12:11). The Rider is the Lamb.
- **The Word of God (*ho Logos tou Theou* – ὁ Λόγος τοῦ Θεοῦ, v. 13):** This recalls John 1:1, 14. The one through whom God created all things is also the one through whom God judges evil.
- **A sharp sword (*rhomphaia oxeia* – ῥομφαία ὀξεῖα, v. 15):** John already saw it in chapter 1, "out of his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword" (1:16), and Pergamum was warned with it (2:16). The weapon is not in his hand but in his mouth: it is his word.
- **Shepherd (*poimanei* – ποιμανεῖ, v. 15):** Literally "he will be shepherd". It is the same verb as in 7:17, where the Lamb leads his people to springs of the water of life. The shepherd who protects is also the shepherd who drives off the wolves.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The King who comes is the Lamb who was slain.** The eyes like a flame of fire (1:14; 2:18), the robe full of blood and the name "King of kings and Lord of lords" all point to the same one. The dragon had seven diadems

(12:3), the beast ten (13:1), but on the Rider's head are "many diadems": he alone is truly king. And he has "a name written that no one knows except himself" – we shall never finish knowing him.

2. **Christ conquers by his word.** The armies that follow him carry no weapons, only "fine linen, white and clean" – the same robe as the bride's (19:8). They are his people, "called and chosen and faithful" (17:14). They do not fight; they follow. For the word of God is living and effective and sharper than any double-edged sword (Hebrews 4:12). What has carried the church through the centuries was not power but testimony.

3. **There are two suppers.** Yesterday: "Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." Today: "Come, gather for the great supper of God." The harsh images from Ezekiel 39 are not meant to whet our appetite for blood; they say that evil is utterly and finally defeated, and that no rank – "free and slave, small and great" – protects anyone who rises against the Lamb. But the first invitation in the chapter is to the wedding. Everyone is invited there first.

4. **The end of evil is certain.** History is not an eternal draw between good and evil. The beast, which to the first readers looked like invincible Rome, is captured without a fight. What looks like the eternal power of the world has an end; Christ has none.

Living It Out

We live in a world of broken promises. Politicians promise and forget, employers promise and restructure, and we ourselves promise more than we can keep. That is why the Rider's name is such a comfort: *Faithful and True*. What he has said, he will do. What he promised to Smyrna, to Philadelphia and to you stands firm.

The chapter also asks how we fight against evil. It is so easy to pick up the beast's weapons: anger, manipulation, the harsh word that wins the argument but loses the person. The armies behind the Rider wear only their white robes. Our fight is fought with truth, with love, and with what 13:10 calls "the endurance and the faith of the saints".

And if the powers of our time frighten you – the economy, politics, an illness, a person who makes your life bitter – remember that they share the beast's fate. They are great, but not eternal. There is only one on whose thigh it is written: *King of kings and Lord of lords*.

Choose one conversation this week in which you are tempted to win with harsh words. Pray Hebrews 4:12 beforehand, and then speak one true word in love instead of the word that wounds.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which of God's promises do you find hard to believe at the moment – and what does it mean to you that he is called *Faithful and True* (v. 11)?
- When did you last fight with the beast's weapons – anger, manipulation, power – rather than with the sword from his mouth (v. 15)?
- Which power in your life looks as invincible as the beast just now, and what changes when you read verse 20?
- Which supper does your life take part in – the wedding supper of the Lamb, or the table of the world (vv. 9, 17)?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, Faithful and True, Word of God, King of kings and Lord of lords: you are coming, and you come as the Lamb who was slain for me. Your eyes see through everything, and your word is stronger than all the powers of this world. I worship you.*

Forgive me that I am so often afraid of powers you have already defeated, and that I fight with the weapons of this world – with anger, with clever words, with the desire to win. Forgive me for the promises I have broken, while you have never broken a single one of yours.

Let me follow you, dressed in the white robe you have given me, with only your word as my sword. Thank you that I am invited to the wedding supper. Keep me faithful until I see you coming. Amen.

DAY 27

The Dragon on a Chain: The Thousand Years and the Book of Life

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 20:1–15

1 And I saw an angel coming down from heaven, holding in his hand the
key of the abyss and a great chain. 2 And he seized the dragon, the an-
cient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand
years, 3 and threw him into the abyss and locked it and sealed it over
him, so that he would deceive the nations no more until the thousand
years were completed. After that he must be released for a short time.

4 And I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and judgement was given to
them. And I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of
the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God, and who had not
worshipped the beast or its image and had not received the mark on
their foreheads or on their hands. And they lived and reigned with
Christ for a thousand years. 5 The rest of the dead did not live until the
thousand years were completed. This is the first resurrection. 6 Blessed
and holy is the one who has a share in the first resurrection. Over these
the second death has no authority, but they will be priests of God and of
Christ, and they will reign with him for a thousand years.

7 And when the thousand years are completed, Satan will be released
from his prison 8 and will go out to deceive the nations at the four cor-
ners of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them for the war; their
number is like the sand of the sea. 9 And they went up across the
breadth of the earth and surrounded the camp of the saints and the
beloved city. And fire came down from heaven and consumed them.
10 And the devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the lake of fire
and sulphur, where the beast and the false prophet are as well, and they
will be tormented day and night for ever and ever.

11 And I saw a great white throne and the one seated on it. Earth and
heaven fled from his face, and no place was found for them. 12 And I saw
the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne, and books
were opened. And another book was opened, which is the book of life.
And the dead were judged by what was written in the books, according
to their works. 13 And the sea gave up the dead who were in it, and death
and Hades gave up the dead who were in them, and they were judged,

each one according to their works. [14] And death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire. [15] And if anyone was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

An angel comes down from heaven, "holding in his hand the key of the abyss and a great chain". The beast and the false prophet have already been captured without a fight (19:20). Now the third of the evil trio has his turn: "the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan." The angel seizes him and binds him for a thousand years.

Chapter 20 does not necessarily follow chapter 19 in time. As so often in Revelation, the vision goes back and shows the same period from another angle. In chapter 12 we already saw the dragon thrown down when the child was "snatched up to God and to his throne" (12:5, 9) – the victory of the cross, the resurrection and the ascension. The Lord Jesus himself spoke like this. He says that no one can enter a strong man's house and plunder his goods unless he first binds the strong man (Mark 3:27). And before the cross: Now the ruler of this world will be driven out; and when I am lifted up from the earth, I will draw all people to myself (John 12:31–32).

The thousand years, then, are not a period on a calendar, but the time in which we now live, between Christ's first and second coming: a full, long time measured out by God (ten times ten times ten), over against Satan's "short time" at the end. Christ reigns now, and his people reign with him. Other Christians read the chapter differently: premillennialists – among them already church fathers such as Justin and Irenaeus, and later the dispensationalists – expect a literal thousand-year kingdom on earth after

Christ's return, while postmillennialists expect a golden age of the gospel before his coming. Here we follow the line known in the church since Augustine (*The City of God*, book 20).

The first readers knew of brothers and sisters who had been "beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God." What had become of those who had lost their lives for their witness? Of the souls under the altar (6:9)? John now sees them on thrones: "And they lived and reigned with Christ for a thousand years." To the world they had lost; with Christ they reign.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Bound him (*edēsen* – ἔδησεν, v. 2):** From *deō*, "bind" – the same verb Jesus uses in Mark 3:27 for binding the strong man. The binding of Satan begins at the cross.
- **So that he would deceive the nations no more (*hina mē planēsē eti ta ethnē* – ἵνα μὴ πλανήσῃ ἔτι τὰ ἔθνη, v. 3):** The text does not say that Satan can do nothing any more, but that he can no longer deceive the nations. For centuries the nations lay in darkness, and God was known only in Israel. Now the gospel goes out to every tribe and language and people and nation (5:9), and Satan cannot stop it.
- **They lived (*ezēsan* – ἔζησαν, vv. 4–5):** The verb can mean "came to life" or "lived". Our translation chooses the plain "lived". John sees *tas psychas* (τὰς ψυχὰς), "the souls", of the faithful: they are dead to the world, but they live with Christ.
- **The first resurrection (*hē anastasis hē prōtē* – ἡ ἀνάστασις ἡ πρώτη, vv. 5–6):** Whoever belongs to Christ already shares in his resurrection. Jesus says that whoever hears his word and believes has passed from death to life (John 5:24), and Paul writes that God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6). That is why "the second death has no authority" – as Smyrna was promised (2:11).

- **The book of life (*tē biblō tēs zōēs* – τῇ βίβλῳ τῆς ζωῆς, v. 15):** The picture comes from the Old Testament: Moses asks God rather to blot him out of his book (Exodus 32:32–33), and Daniel hears that everyone found written in the book will be delivered (Daniel 12:1). In Revelation it is "the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb" (13:8).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Christ reigns now, and Satan is on a chain.** Being bound does not mean that evil is quiet; a dog on a chain can still bark and bite within the reach of its chain. But he cannot stop the gospel. That there are churches today in almost every country of the world is itself the proof of the chain.

2. **The faithful dead are not lost.** The world beheaded them; God seated them on thrones. The picture comes from Daniel 7:9, 22, where thrones are set up and judgement is given to the saints of the Most High. Whoever dies in Christ does not go into nothingness, but to the throne.

3. **The last rebellion is short, and the end comes from the throne.** At the end Satan is released "for a short time", and he gathers Gog and Magog – Ezekiel's picture of the last enemy from the north (Ezekiel 38–39) – against "the camp of the saints and the beloved city." The church is like Israel in the wilderness: a camp, a pilgrim people. Again there is no battle: "fire came down from heaven and consumed them" (cf. 2 Kings 1:10–12).

4. **We are judged according to our works, but saved by the Lamb's book.** Before the great white throne everyone stands, "the great and the small". The books are opened, and our lives count (Psalm 62:12). But there is another book, and it decides. Whoever is written in it is there not because their works were good enough, but because the Lamb was slain. And then "death and Hades" themselves are thrown into the lake of fire: the last enemy to be destroyed is death (1 Corinthians 15:26).

Living It Out

It does not always feel as though Satan is bound. We see war, persecution and broken families, and our own struggle with sin. Revelation 20 does not deny this. But it shows us what the news does not: the gospel is still going out. People in countries where the church was unknown for centuries pray to Jesus today in their own language. The chain holds.

For anyone grieving a loved one who died in faith, this chapter is a gentle comfort. They are not gone. John sees them living and reigning with Christ. The second death has no authority over them – nor over you, if you belong to him.

And the judgement? Many believers become afraid when they read about the great white throne. The books of our works tell the truth about us, and that is good: God takes our lives seriously. But the last word comes from another book. Jesus told his disciples to rejoice, not because the spirits were subject to them, but because their names were written in heaven (Luke 10:20).

This week, pray every day for one people or country where the gospel is still little known, and thank God for one loved one who died in faith and now lives with Christ.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you live as if Satan were free and Christ bound, or the other way round (vv. 2–4)?
- Which door for the gospel has God opened around you that you have not yet used (v. 3)?
- How do the words "they lived and reigned with Christ" change the way you think about your loved ones who have died (v. 4)?
- For your salvation, do you trust in the books of your works or in the book of life (vv. 12, 15)?

Prayer

You have bound the strong man, Lord Jesus, and broken open his house. You reign now, and your people reign with you. Thank you that Satan cannot stop the gospel, and that people from every nation call on your name today.

Too easily I live as if evil had the upper hand, and I fear the judgement although you have already paid for my sin. Forgive me where my works have dishonoured you, and teach me to take seriously that my life counts before your throne.

Thank you for my loved ones who died in faith and now live with you. Thank you that my name is written in the book of life of the Lamb, not because I deserved it, but because you were slain. Use me to carry your gospel further, until death itself is destroyed. In your name, Amen.

DAY 28

Look, I Am Making All Things New: A New Heaven and a New Earth

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 21:1–8

1 And I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the
first earth had passed away, and the sea is no more. 2 And I saw the holy
city, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, pre-
pared like a bride adorned for her husband. 3 And I heard a loud voice
from the throne saying:

Look, God's tent is with people,
and he will spread his tent with them,
and they will be his peoples,
and God himself will be with them,
4 and he will wipe away every tear from their eyes,
and death will be no more,
nor grief nor crying nor pain will be any more.
The former things have passed away.

5 And the one seated on the throne said, "Look, I am making all things
new." And he says, "Write, for these words are faithful and true." 6 And
he said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning
and the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life
as a gift. 7 The one who conquers will inherit these things, and I will be
his God, and he will be my son. 8 But for the cowardly and the faithless
and the abominable and murderers and the sexually immoral and sor-
cerers and idolaters and all liars, their share will be in the lake that
burns with fire and sulphur, which is the second death."

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday earth and heaven fled from the face of the one seated on the great white throne, and death itself was thrown into the lake of fire. Today John sees what remains when everything evil is gone: "And I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea is no more."

The Bible's first sentence says that in the beginning God created the heavens and the earth (Genesis 1:1). Now, at the end, the same two words stand again, but with the word "new" beside them. Isaiah promised it: God will create a new heaven and a new earth, and the former things will no longer be remembered (Isaiah 65:17). The story that began in Genesis 3 with a curse and with tears ends here with a God who will "wipe away every tear from their eyes".

And the sea? In the Old Testament the sea is often the picture of chaos and threat; out of the sea came Daniel's beasts (Daniel 7:3), and in Revelation the beast of chapter 13. And the sea was Babylon's trade route: when she fell, the sailors stood far off and wept, for across the sea the wealth of the world sailed to Rome (18:17–19). In the new creation there is no more chaos, no more separation – and no market that buys and sells everything.

Then comes the heart of the vision. "Look, God's tent is with people, and he will spread his tent with them." This is the language of the exodus. In the wilderness God told Moses to make him a sanctuary, so that he might dwell in their midst (Exodus 25:8), and his glory filled the tent (Exodus 40:34). The exodus from Egypt was never just an escape; it led into the promised land and to a God who dwells with his people. So it is with the new exodus of Revelation. When Babylon fell, the voice from heaven called: "Come out of her, my people" (18:4). It is an exodus out of Babylon, not out of creation. The goal is not that we escape to a heaven far away, but that God comes down and dwells with us.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **New (*kainon* – καινὸν, v. 1):** *Kainos* often points not just to something young or recent, but to something new in kind. Interpreters differ on how we should picture it – a wholly new creation, or the old creation purified and renewed – but the point is the same: the first order, marked by sin, death and tears, is over.
- **Passed away (*apēlthan* – ἀπῆλθαν, vv. 1, 4):** The same verb stands in the lament over Babylon: "the fruit your soul longed for has gone from you" (18:14, *apēlthen* – ἀπῆλθεν). Babylon's luxury was the first to pass away. Now the whole first heaven and earth go, and everything Babylon had for sale goes with them.
- **God's tent (*hē skēnē tou theou* – ἡ σκηνὴ τοῦ θεοῦ, v. 3):** The word for the tabernacle in the wilderness. John 1:14 uses its verb: the Word became flesh and pitched his tent among us. What began in Jesus becomes true here for ever. And the promise is in the plural: "his peoples" – people from all the nations (cf. Zechariah 2:11).
- **Look, I am making all things new (*Idou kaina poiō panta* – Ἰδοὺ καινὰ ποιῶ πάντα, v. 5):** This is one of the few places in the book where the one seated on the throne speaks himself (cf. 1:8). He does not just make new things; he makes all things new. He does not throw his creation away. And the verb is in the present tense: whoever is in Christ is already a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17).
- **As a gift (*dōrean* – δωρεάν, v. 6):** Freely, without payment – as in Isaiah 55:1, where God invites the thirsty to come and buy without money.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God does not give up his creation; he makes it new.** The Bible does not end with souls escaping to a cloud, but with a new heaven and a new earth. His last word about the world is not destruction but renewal.

2. **The goal of everything is God dwelling with his people.** Eden, the tabernacle, the temple, Jesus pitching his tent among us, the church as the temple of the Spirit – every step in the story points here. "And God himself will be with them." This is the promised land of the new exodus.

3. **Babylon's wealth belongs to the things that pass away.** Babylon staked everything on the first heaven and the first earth, and all she had for sale – even people – passes away with them. In the new creation the water of life is given as a gift. For here we have no city that lasts; rather, we are seeking the one that is to come (Hebrews 13:14).

4. **The thirsty receive it as a gift; the one who conquers inherits everything.** "The one who conquers will inherit these things" is the last of the promises to the conquerors of chapters 2–3, and it is the promise to David's son (2 Samuel 7:14) that now holds for every believer: "I will be his God, and he will be my son." The list in verse 8 begins with "the cowardly": not people who are afraid and weak, but people who out of fear gave up Christ and chose Babylon. It is a warning, but the door stands open: whoever is thirsty may come.

Living It Out

Some tears are not wiped away in this life. The child who was never born, the marriage that broke, the loved one who died of cancer, the body that no longer obeys. Revelation 21 does not give an explanation for every tear. It gives something better: a promise that God himself will wipe each one away – not an angel, God himself.

This vision also helps us look honestly at what we invest in. Our time, our money and our dreams often go to things that pass away with the first earth. Creation is not bad – God is making it new – but our hearts should not hang on Babylon's luxury. Whoever knows that the new creation is coming can live today with open hands.

And because he says "I am making all things new" in the present tense, you do not have to wait to taste something of it. Every time someone comes to faith, every time a broken relationship is healed, every time a church welcomes a stranger, the new creation is already beginning.

Write down today one tear you are still carrying, and read Revelation 21:3–5 beside it. Then say to God: This one too you will wipe away.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What tear or loss are you carrying just now, and what does it mean to you that God himself will wipe it away (v. 4)?
- Do you invest more in things that pass away with the first earth than in the city that is coming (v. 1)?
- Where can you be a sign of the new creation this week – at home, at work, in your church (v. 5)?
- Are you thirsty for the water of life, or are you still trying to pay for what God gives as a gift (v. 6)?

Prayer

Lord God, the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end: you created the heavens and the earth, and you are making all things new. I worship you, for you do not abandon your creation, and your purpose is to dwell with your people yourself.

Forgive me that my heart clings so easily to the things of the first earth – to possessions, security and the luxury of Babylon. Forgive me for the times I kept silent out of fear, and for the lies I have believed about what will make me happy.

Thank you that you will wipe away every tear, even those I am still carrying today. Thank you for the water of life that you give as a gift. Lead me on the way of the new exodus, out of Babylon, to the day when your tent is spread among us and you will be my God. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 29

The Bride Is a City: Where God Himself Is the Temple

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 21:9–27

9 And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls full of the seven
last plagues came and spoke with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the
bride, the wife of the Lamb." 10 And he carried me away in the Spirit to a
great, high mountain and showed me the holy city Jerusalem coming
down out of heaven from God, 11 having the glory of God. Its radiance
was like a most precious stone, like a jasper, clear as crystal. 12 It had a
great, high wall with twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels, and
names written on them, which are the names of the twelve tribes of the
people of Israel: 13 on the east three gates, and on the north three gates,
and on the south three gates, and on the west three gates. 14 And the wall
of the city had twelve foundations, and on them the twelve names of the
twelve apostles of the Lamb.

15 And the one who spoke with me had a gold measuring reed to measure
the city and its gates and its wall. 16 And the city lies foursquare; its
length is as great as its width. And he measured the city with the reed:
twelve thousand stadia. Its length and width and height are equal.
17 And he measured its wall: a hundred and forty-four cubits, by human
measure, which is also an angel's measure. 18 And the wall was built of
jasper, and the city was pure gold, like clear glass. 19 The foundations of
the wall of the city were adorned with every kind of precious stone: the
first foundation was jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony,
the fourth emerald, 20 the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the sev-
enth chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chryso-
prase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst. 21 And the twelve gates
were twelve pearls; each of the gates was made of a single pearl. And the
street of the city was pure gold, like transparent glass.

22 And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God, the Almighty,
and the Lamb. 23 And the city has no need of the sun or of the moon to
shine on it, for the glory of God has given it light, and its lamp is the
Lamb. 24 And the nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the
earth bring their glory into it. 25 And its gates will never be shut by day,
for there will be no night there. 26 And they will bring the glory and the

honour of the nations into it. [27] But nothing unclean will ever enter it, nor anyone who practises abomination and lies, but only those who are written in the book of life of the Lamb.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

The one seated on the throne has said, "Look, I am making all things new." Now one of the angels shows John from close up what that means. And the angel sounds familiar: he is "one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls" – exactly the same formula as in 17:1, when John was to see the great prostitute. Then the angel said, "Come, I will show you the judgement of the great prostitute." Now he says, "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb." The book wants us to see the two women side by side.

And then happens again what we saw with the Lion and the Lamb. John **hears** "the bride", but what he **sees** is a city. The angel shows him "the holy city Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from God". The seeing interprets the hearing. The city is not first of all a place; it is the people of God, in the glory God gives them. On the gates are the names of the twelve tribes of Israel, on the foundations the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb – the whole people of God, old and new covenant together in one city.

Here John stands on Ezekiel's shoulders. The prophet, in exile in Babylon, was taken in a vision to a very high mountain, where he saw something like a city (Ezekiel 40:2). A man with a measuring reed measured the new temple (Ezekiel 40–48), there were twelve gates bearing the names of the tribes, and the last words of the book are the name of the city: The LORD is there (Ezekiel 48:30–35). Isaiah sang of the same city: gates that never close, nations coming to its light, and the LORD himself as its everlasting light, so that it no longer needs sun or moon (Isaiah 60:3, 11, 19).

Now think of the first readers. Pergamum, Smyrna and Ephesus competed for the honour of having temples to the emperor; the temple was the heart of every city. And the temple in Jerusalem had lain in ruins since AD 70. Into that world John writes the most astonishing sentence of the chapter: "And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God, the Almighty, and the Lamb."

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Come, I will show you (*Deuro, deixō soi* – Δεῦρο, δείξω σοι, v. 9):** Word for word the same invitation as in 17:1. Two women, two cities, two destinies – and the question of whom we belong to is given a face.
- **Foursquare (*tetragōnos* – τετράγωνος, v. 16):** Length, width and height are equal; the city is a cube. In Solomon's temple only one room was built like that: the Most Holy Place, twenty cubits long, wide and high (1 Kings 6:20). The whole city has become the Most Holy Place – the room only the high priest could enter, once a year, is now the home of all who belong to the Lamb.
- **Twelve thousand stadia (*stadious dōdeka chiliadōn* – σταδίους δώδεκα χιλιάδων, v. 16):** About 2,200 kilometres in every direction. The number is not meant for a map but for wonder: twelve (the people of God) times a thousand. The wall of "a hundred and forty-four cubits" is twelve times twelve. There is room for all whom God has called.
- **Temple (*naon* – ναόν, v. 22):** From *naos*, the word for the sanctuary itself, God's dwelling. In the new Jerusalem there is no separate holy place any more, because God and the Lamb fill everything.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The whole Bible is on its way to this city.** In the garden God walked with humankind (Genesis 3:8). After the exodus he lived in a tent among his people (Exodus 40:34), then in the temple (1 Kings 8:10–11). Ezekiel saw the glory depart before the exile (Ezekiel 10) and return (Ezekiel 43:2–5). In Jesus the Word pitched his tent among us (John

1:14), and the church became the temple of the Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16). In the new Jerusalem the story is completed: God no longer lives in one corner of the world; his presence fills everything.

2. **The prostitute sells her splendour; the bride receives hers.** The prostitute was adorned "with gold and precious stone and pearls" (17:4); the bride's gates *are* pearls, her street *is* gold, her foundations are adorned with precious stones. Babylon wears the splendour as seduction and sells it; Jerusalem receives it as God's gift. And the kings of the earth, who "committed harlotry with her and lived in luxury" (18:9), here bring their glory into the city. What was good and beautiful in the cultures of the nations is not lost; it is cleansed and brought home.

3. **The gates stand open, and the Lamb holds the book.** "And its gates will never be shut by day, for there will be no night there." The open gates are an invitation, not indifference: "nothing unclean will ever enter it". Whoever enters does not come in on their own merit, but because they are "written in the book of life of the Lamb".

Living It Out

We live in cities of a different kind. The shopping centre, the office tower, the stadium – every culture builds its temples to what it values most. And we tend to put God in a room too: Sunday morning, the quiet time, the church building. Revelation 21 shows where everything is heading: a city without a temple, because no part of life lies outside God's presence any more. That future may already come into our Mondays. The kitchen, the office and the classroom are no less holy than the church, for the Spirit lives in you.

This vision also says something about the church you belong to. John hears "bride" and sees a city with twelve tribes and twelve apostles in its foundations. The bride is not a collection of individuals each going to heaven alone; she is a people. The people you sing with on Sunday, with

all their quirks, are part of the city God is building. It is sometimes easier to believe in the glory of the future than to be patient with a difficult brother or sister – but it is the same city.

And for anyone bowed down under a burden, this chapter shows a city without night. For believers in Smyrna and Philadelphia, who at times had to live in the darkness of persecution and exclusion, this was a promise to hold on to: a day is coming without night, without locked doors, without anything that hurts. You may walk in that light today, even if your night is not yet over.

This week, choose one "ordinary" place in your life – your desk, your car, your kitchen table – and pray there deliberately: Lord, you live here too.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What "temples" does the culture around you build, and which pulls at you more strongly – the splendour of Babylon or the glory of the bride (vv. 9–11; cf. 17:1–4)?
- Are there areas of your life where you would rather not have God, because you keep him in a temple corner (v. 22)?
- How do you see the church you belong to when you remember that the bride is a city with twelve foundations (vv. 12–14)?
- What does it mean to you that your name is "written in the book of life of the Lamb" (v. 27)?

Prayer

> *Lord God, the Almighty, and you, Lamb of God: you are the temple and the light of the city that is coming. I worship you for the holy city Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven with your glory, and for the bride you are preparing for yourself from every tribe and nation.*

The splendour of Babylon easily dazzles me, and I so often shut you away in one small corner of my life. Forgive me. Forgive me, too, that I sometimes see my brothers and sisters as a burden, when they are part with me of the city you are building.

Thank you that the gates stand open, and that my name is written in the book of life of the Lamb – not by my merit, but by your grace. Let me walk in your light today, so that others may see something of your glory through me. Amen.

DAY 30

The River and the Tree of Life: The Garden Open Again

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 22:1–5

[1] And he showed me a river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing
out from the throne of God and of the Lamb [2] through the middle of the
city's street. And on either side of the river was the tree of life, bearing
twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month; and the leaves of the
tree are for the healing of the nations. [3] And there will no longer be any
curse. And the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his ser-
vants will serve him, [4] and they will see his face, and his name will be on
their foreheads. [5] And there will be no more night, and they have no
need of the light of a lamp or the light of the sun, for the Lord God will
shine on them, and they will reign for ever and ever.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday we saw the new Jerusalem: a city without a temple, because God and the Lamb themselves are its temple. Today the angel leads John into the middle of that city, and what he sees there is not another building but a garden: "a river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing out from the throne of God and of the Lamb", and on either side of it the tree of life.

Every reader who knows the Bible knows where we last heard these words. In its very first chapters a river went out from Eden to water the garden, and in the middle of the garden stood the tree of life (Genesis 2:9–10). After humanity's rebellion God cursed the ground (Genesis 3:17), and cherubim with a flaming sword guarded the way to the tree of life (Genesis 3:24). From that day on humankind was an exile from the gar-

den. The whole Bible tells of God's way of opening the road back. In Revelation 22 the circle closes: what was shut in Genesis now stands open – and it is greater than the beginning. The garden has become a city, and the tree stands in the middle of its street.

John borrows his images from the prophets as well. Ezekiel saw water flowing out from under the threshold of the temple, deeper and deeper, until it became a river that made the Dead Sea fresh; on both banks grew trees that bore fruit every month, and their leaves were for healing (Ezekiel 47:1–12). Zechariah saw living water flowing out from Jerusalem and promised that there would never again be a curse (Zechariah 14:8, 11). The first readers had heard this promise before: to Ephesus Jesus had said, "To the one who conquers I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God" (2:7). What was promised to one church at the beginning of the book is given to the whole people of God at its end.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Tree (*xylon* – ξύλον, v. 2):** The word really means "wood" and can also be used for a tree. The same word is used in the New Testament for the cross (Acts 5:30; 1 Peter 2:24), and Paul quotes Deuteronomy 21:23: cursed is everyone who hangs on a *xylon* (Galatians 3:13). Many interpreters hear the connection here: because Christ bore the curse on the wood, the tree of life stands open again.
- **No longer any curse (*pan katathema ouk estai eti* – πᾶν κατάθεμα οὐκ ἔσται ἔτι, v. 3):** Literally "every accursed thing will be no more". The curse of Genesis 3, which lay on the ground, on human work and on human relationships, is gone – as Zechariah 14:11 promised.
- **They will serve him (*latreusousin autō* – λατρεύσουσιν αὐτῷ, v. 3):** The word for priestly service in the sanctuary. In the city without a temple all God's servants are priests, and their whole life is worship.
- **They will see his face (*opsontai to prosōpon autou* – ὄψονται τὸ πρόσωπον αὐτοῦ, v. 4):** God told Moses that no one can see his face and live (Exodus 33:20). The psalmists longed for it (Psalm 17:15; 42:2). Now

the deepest longing of the Old Testament is fulfilled. Notice too: "the throne of God and of the Lamb", but then *his* servants, *his* face, *his* name – the Father and the Lamb are one.

- **For the healing of the nations (*eis therapeian tōn ethnōn* – εἰς θεραπείαν τῶν ἐθνῶν, v. 2):** The same nations that were deceived by Babylon (18:23) are in the end not destroyed but healed.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **What was lost in Eden is restored by the Lamb – and more.** The river flows "from the throne of God and of the Lamb". The way back to the tree of life does not bypass the cross; it goes through it. That is why the last page of the Bible is not simply a return to the beginning: in Eden the tree was a promise; in the new Jerusalem it is fruit given every month.

2. **The name on the forehead: we belong to him.** Throughout the book everyone bears a mark: God's seal (7:3) or the mark of the beast (13:16), as we saw in chapter 13. But now only one mark remains: "his name will be on their foreheads". What was often hidden in this age is then visible for ever: they belong to him.

3. **To see God is the goal of our existence.** Heaven is not first of all a place of golden streets but of a Person. "They will see his face." All we know of God here is like a reflection in a dim mirror; then we shall see him face to face (1 Corinthians 13:12).

4. **The servants reign.** The book does not end with people who merely enjoy things passively: "they will reign for ever and ever" – the promise of Daniel 7:18, 27. What already began in 5:10, in witness and suffering, is completed here in glory.

Living It Out

We still live east of Eden. The curse is visible everywhere: in work that is toilsome, in relationships that break, in bodies that grow ill and old, in an earth that groans. Revelation 22 does not pretend otherwise, but it tells the first readers – and us – where the story is going. The last word over your life is not the curse but the tree of life.

That future already casts its light on today. The leaves of the tree are "for the healing of the nations". Every time Christians bring peace where there was hatred, care for the sick, or forgive where it would be easier to blame, they show something of that healing before it has fully come. You do not have to save the world, but you can be a leaf of that tree for someone near you.

And then there is the name on the forehead. We all carry other names that try to define us: the name of our job, of our failures, of what others say about us. Some of those names are heavy to carry. But God's last word over his children is his own name. You belong to him, and one day that will be plain for all to see.

Tonight, read Genesis 3:22–24 and then Revelation 22:1–5 one after the other, and thank God for the open way.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Where do you feel the weight of the curse today – in your work, your body, your relationships (v. 3)? What changes when you know it is not the last word?
- Do you really long to see God's face, or do you care more about the blessings than about him (v. 4)?
- Whose name do you bear in what you think and do – to whom does your heart belong (v. 4; cf. 13:16)?
- For whom can you be a leaf of healing this week (v. 2)?

Prayer

Lord God and Lamb of God, from your throne flows the river of the water of life. I worship you, for what we lost in Eden you have opened again through the cross. You bore the curse, so that one day there will no longer be any curse.

Forgive me that I so often give my heart to other things and let other names define me. Forgive me that I long more for your gifts than for you yourself. Teach me to seek your face, even now, in your word and in prayer.

Thank you that I bear your name, and that one day I will see your face. Make me a leaf of healing today for someone who is hurting, until with all your servants I serve you and reign with you for ever and ever. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 31

Come, Lord Jesus: The Curtain Stays Open

SCRIPTURE

Revelation 22:6–21

6 And he said to me, "These words are faithful and true. And the Lord,
the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his ser-
vants what must soon take place. 7 And look, I am coming soon. Blessed
is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book."

8 And I, John, am the one who heard and saw these things. And when I
heard and saw them, I fell down to worship at the feet of the angel who
showed them to me. 9 And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am a fellow
servant with you and with your brothers and sisters the prophets, and
with those who keep the words of this book. Worship God!"

10 And he says to me, "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this
book, for the time is near. 11 Let the one who does wrong still do wrong,
and the filthy still be filthy, and the righteous still do what is right, and
the holy still be holy. 12 Look, I am coming soon, and my reward is with
me, to repay each one according to what he has done. 13 I am the Alpha
and the Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning and the end.
14 Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the
right to the tree of life and may go through the gates into the city.
15 Outside are the dogs and the sorcerers and the sexually immoral and
the murderers and the idolaters, and everyone who loves and practises
lies. 16 I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify to you about these things for
the churches. I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright
morning star."

17 And the Spirit and the bride say, "Come!" And let the one who hears
say, "Come!" And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes
take the water of life as a gift.

18 I testify to everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book:
if anyone adds to them, God will add to him the plagues that are written
in this book. 19 And if anyone takes away from the words of the book of
this prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and in the
holy city, which are written about in this book.

[20] The one who testifies to these things says, "Yes, I am coming soon." Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!

[21] The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

The book – and our journey – comes to a close. We have stood by the river and the tree of life and heard: "they will see his face". And anyone who listens carefully hears the end echoing the beginning. "What must soon take place" (v. 6) are word for word the words of 1:1. "Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book" (v. 7) repeats the blessing of 1:3. "The time is near" (v. 10) is also in 1:3. The Alpha and the Omega of 1:8 speaks again in verse 13, and the book ends like a letter, with grace (v. 21), just as it began in 1:4. From beginning to end Revelation is one letter to seven churches in Asia – and through them to the church of every age.

One word sounds through the whole ending: "Look, I am coming soon" (vv. 7, 12, 20). For the first readers, living under the pressure of Rome, it was a promise to hold on to. But it was also a question they would ask: if he is coming "soon", why are we still waiting? Peter had already answered the same question: with the Lord one day is like a thousand years, and he is not slow in keeping his promise but is patient, because he wants all to come to repentance (2 Peter 3:8–9). Long before, Habakkuk had heard about the vision: "If it lingers, wait for it, for it will surely come; it will not delay" (Habakkuk 2:3). "Soon" is not a date on a calendar but a promise that keeps every generation on its toes.

And then the striking command of verse 10: "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book." Daniel was told the opposite: he was to shut up the words and seal the book until the time of the end (Daniel 12:4, 9).

What was still far off for Daniel has begun with the cross and resurrection of Christ. The scroll that only the Lamb could open (chapter 5) may not be closed again. The curtain drawn back in chapter 4 stays open.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **I am coming soon (*erchomai tachy* – ἔρχομαι ταχύ, vv. 7, 12, 20):** *Erchomai* is in the present tense: he is already on his way. *Tachy* means "soon", "without delay". It describes God's certainty and our readiness, not a timetable.
- **Do not seal up (*Mē sphragisēs* – Μὴ σφραγίσῃς, v. 10):** The same word as for the seals of the scroll in chapters 5–6. The message is not stored away for a distant future; it is for the churches of that day, and for us, to read and to keep now.
- **Worship God! (*tō theō proskynēson* – τῷ θεῷ προσκύνησον, v. 9):** For the second time John falls down before the angel (cf. 19:10), and for the second time he is set right. Even the most glorious messenger is only a fellow servant. The whole book wants to bring us to one place: the worship of God and the Lamb.
- **The bright morning star (*ho astēr ho lampros, ho prōinos* – ὁ ἀστὴρ ὁ λαμπρός, ὁ πρωϊνός, v. 16):** Balaam saw a star rising out of Jacob (Numbers 24:17). The morning star appears when the night is darkest and announces the day. Thyatira was promised: "And I will give him the morning star" (2:28). Jesus himself is that promise.
- **Come, Lord Jesus (*erchou, kyrie Iēsou* – ἔρχου, κύριε Ἰησοῦ, v. 20):** The early church probably prayed the same prayer in Aramaic, *Marana tha* – "Our Lord, come!" (1 Corinthians 16:22). According to the *Didache* (10:6), an early Christian writing, it was also part of the prayers at the Lord's Supper.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The future is a Person, not a programme.** The book does not end with a map of the end times but with Jesus saying: "I, Jesus, have sent my angel ... I am the root and the descendant of David" (v. 16). He is at once the root from which David's house grew and the descendant of that house (Isaiah 11:1, 10) – the beginning and the end of God's promises. Whoever wants to know the future must know him.

2. **The invitation is wider than the warning.** There are solemn words in this ending: "Outside are the dogs and the sorcerers ..." (v. 15), and the warning not to add to the prophecy or take away from it (vv. 18–19; cf. Deuteronomy 4:2). But between these words stands the heart of the gospel: the Spirit and the bride say, "Come!" (v. 17). The thirsty may come and drink without paying. The last invitation in the Bible is a gift.

3. **Washed robes are the only way in.** The seventh and last beatitude of the book reads: "Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life" (v. 14). The way to the tree, guarded in Genesis 3:24, opens for those who have washed their robes in the blood of the Lamb (7:14). We do not get in by achievement, but by grace.

4. **The last word is grace.** After all the visions of judgement and conflict, the very last verse says: "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all." So the whole story begins and ends: with the grace of God.

Living It Out

Thirty-one days ago we began with the first word of the book, *apokalypsis* – the curtain is drawn back. We have looked behind the curtain and seen the throne that stands firm, the Lamb who was slaughtered and yet reigns, the accuser thrown down, Babylon falling, and a city where God himself is the temple. It was an exodus: the Passover Lamb who ransomed a people, the plagues and the song of Moses and of the Lamb, the call to come out of Babylon – and at the end the arrival in the promised land of

the new creation. The curtain is open, and it stays open – until one day it is taken away altogether and we see his face. Tomorrow we go back to the streets of our own "Pergamum" – the work, the news, the bills, the hospital corridor – but now we know who truly sits on the throne.

That changes how we wait. Jesus' "soon" is not meant to make us speculate about dates or live in fear. It calls us to be awake and faithful, to *keep* his words (v. 7), to wash our robes, and to invite others to come and drink with us. Whoever truly expects the Bridegroom to come lives like a bride making herself ready.

And it gives us a prayer for every day. "Come, Lord Jesus" is the prayer of the whole church – in the persecution of Smyrna, in the comfort of Laodicea, and in your own life. You can pray it when the world looks dark, when your own heart is tired, and when you simply long to see him. It is the prayer of someone who knows how the story ends.

Pray today, and every morning this week, the last prayer of the Bible: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!"

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which picture from these 31 days has helped you most to see behind the curtain? How do you want to live it out this week (v. 7)?
- Do you live as though Jesus is coming *soon* – or as though he is never coming (v. 12)?
- Who in your life is thirsty, and how can you join the Spirit and the bride in saying to them, "Come!" (v. 17)?
- Can you pray "Come, Lord Jesus" with joy, or rather with hesitation (v. 20)? What does that say about your heart?

Prayer

Lord Jesus, the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning and the end: thank you for drawing back the curtain and letting me see who sits on the throne. You are the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star who ends the night.

I sometimes live as though you were not coming, and I have given my heart to the things of this passing world. Forgive me. Wash my robes in your blood, and make me faithful to keep your words.

Thank you that your grace is the first and the last word. Make me a voice with the Spirit and the bride, saying to a thirsty world: Come! I long for the day when I will see your face. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!

The whole book of Revelation

The complete text of Revelation in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] The revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave him to show his servants
what must soon take place. He made it known by sending it through his angel
to his servant John, [2] who testified to the word of God and to the testimony of
Jesus Christ – everything he saw. [3] Blessed is the one who reads aloud, and
blessed are those who hear the words of the prophecy and keep what is writ-
ten in it, for the time is near.

[4] John, to the seven churches in the province of Asia: Grace to you and peace
from him who is and who was and who is coming, and from the seven spirits
who are before his throne, [5] and from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, the
firstborn of the dead and the ruler of the kings of the earth.

To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood
[6] – and he made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father –
to him be the glory and the might for ever and ever. Amen.
[7] Look, he is coming with the clouds,
and every eye will see him,
even those who pierced him,
and all the tribes of the earth will mourn over him.
Yes, amen.

[8] "I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, who is and who was and
who is coming, the Almighty.

[9] I, John, your brother, who shares with you in the affliction and the king-
dom and the endurance in Jesus, was on the island called Patmos because of
the word of God and the testimony of Jesus. [10] On the Lord's day I came to be
in the Spirit, and behind me I heard a loud voice like a trumpet, [11] saying,
"Write what you see in a book and send it to the seven churches: to Ephesus,
to Smyrna, to Pergamum, to Thyatira, to Sardis, to Philadelphia and to
Laodicea." [12] And I turned to see the voice that was speaking with me. And
when I had turned, I saw seven golden lampstands, [13] and in the middle of the

lampstands one like a son of man, dressed in a robe that reached to his feet, with a golden sash around his chest. [14] His head and his hair were white like white wool, like snow, and his eyes were like a flame of fire; [15] his feet were like burnished bronze, as if glowing in a furnace, and his voice was like the sound of many waters. [16] In his right hand he had seven stars, out of his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun shining in its power.

[17] When I saw him, I fell at his feet as though dead. And he placed his right hand on me and said, "Do not be afraid. I am the First and the Last, [18] and the Living One. I was dead, and look, I am alive for ever and ever, and I have the keys of death and of Hades. [19] So write down what you have seen, what is, and what is going to take place after this. [20] As for the mystery of the seven stars that you saw in my right hand, and the seven golden lampstands: the seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are the seven churches."

Chapter 2

[1] To the angel of the church in Ephesus write: The one who holds the seven stars in his right hand, who walks among the seven golden lampstands, says this: [2] I know your works, your toil and your endurance, and that you cannot bear evil people. You have tested those who call themselves apostles and are not, and you have found them to be liars. [3] You have endurance, and you have borne up for my name's sake, and you have not grown weary. [4] But I have this against you: you have abandoned your first love. [5] So remember from where you have fallen, repent, and do the first works. If not, I am coming to you, and I will move your lampstand from its place, unless you repent. [6] But you have this: you hate the works of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate. [7] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God.

[8] And to the angel of the church in Smyrna write: The First and the Last, who was dead and came to life, says this: [9] I know your affliction and your poverty – but you are rich – and the slander of those who say they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan. [10] Do not fear anything you are about to suf-

fer. Look, the devil is about to throw some of you into prison so that you may be tested, and you will have affliction for ten days. Be faithful to the point of death, and I will give you the crown of life. [11] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. The one who conquers will not be harmed at all by the second death.

[12] And to the angel of the church in Pergamum write: The one who has the sharp two-edged sword says this: [13] I know where you live: where the throne of Satan is. Yet you hold fast to my name, and you did not deny your faith in me, even in the days of Antipas, my witness, my faithful one, who was killed among you, where Satan lives. [14] But I have a few things against you: you have people there who hold fast to the teaching of Balaam, who taught Balak to put a stumbling block before the people of Israel, so that they would eat food sacrificed to idols and commit sexual immorality. [15] So you too have people who in the same way hold fast to the teaching of the Nicolaitans. [16] So repent. If not, I am coming to you soon, and I will make war against them with the sword of my mouth. [17] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches. To the one who conquers I will give some of the hidden manna, and I will give him a white stone, and on the stone a new name is written that no one knows except the one who receives it.

[18] And to the angel of the church in Thyatira write: The Son of God, who has eyes like a flame of fire and whose feet are like burnished bronze, says this: [19] I know your works: your love and faith and service and endurance, and that your last works are more than the first. [20] But I have this against you: you tolerate the woman Jezebel, who calls herself a prophetess and teaches and deceives my servants, so that they commit sexual immorality and eat food sacrificed to idols. [21] I gave her time to repent, but she does not want to repent of her sexual immorality. [22] Look, I am throwing her onto a bed, and those who commit adultery with her into great affliction, unless they repent of her works. [23] And I will kill her children with pestilence. And all the churches will know that I am the one who searches minds and hearts, and I will give to each of you according to your works. [24] But to the rest of you in Thyatira, all who do not hold this teaching, who have not come to know the deep things of Satan, as they call them, I say: I am not putting any other burden on you. [25] Only hold fast to what you have until I come. [26] And the one who conquers and keeps my works to the end, I will give him authority over the nations,

27 and he will shepherd them with an iron rod,
as clay pots are shattered –

28 just as I too have received it from my Father. And I will give him the morning star. 29 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

Chapter 3

1 And to the angel of the church in Sardis write: The one who has the seven spirits of God and the seven stars says this: I know your works: you have the name of being alive, but you are dead. 2 Wake up, and strengthen what remains, which was about to die, for I have not found your works complete before my God. 3 So remember how you received and heard; keep it, and repent. If you do not wake up, I will come like a thief, and you will not know at all at what hour I will come upon you. 4 But you have a few names in Sardis who have not soiled their clothes, and they will walk with me in white, because they are worthy. 5 The one who conquers will in this way be dressed in white clothes, and I will never blot his name out of the book of life, and I will confess his name before my Father and before his angels. 6 Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

7 And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write: The Holy One, the True One, who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut, and who shuts and no one opens, says this: 8 I know your works – look, I have set before you an open door, which no one is able to shut – that you have little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name. 9 Look, I will give you some from the synagogue of Satan, who say they are Jews and are not, but are lying – look, I will make them come and bow down before your feet, and they will know that I have loved you. 10 Because you have kept the word of my endurance, I too will keep you from the hour of testing that is about to come on the whole world, to test those who live on the earth. 11 I am coming soon. Hold fast to what you have, so that no one takes your crown. 12 The one who conquers, I will make him a pillar in the temple of my God, and he will never go out of it again. And I will write on him the name of my

God and the name of the city of my God, the new Jerusalem, which comes down out of heaven from my God, and my new name. [13] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

[14] And to the angel of the church in Laodicea write: The Amen, the faithful and true witness, the beginning of God's creation, says this: [15] I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. I wish you were cold or hot! [16] So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I am about to vomit you out of my mouth. [17] For you say: I am rich, I have become wealthy, and I need nothing – and you do not know that it is you who are wretched and pitiable and poor and blind and naked. [18] I advise you to buy from me gold refined by fire, so that you may become rich, and white clothes to put on, so that the shame of your nakedness may not be exposed, and salve to put on your eyes, so that you may see. [19] All those I love, I reprove and discipline. So be zealous and repent. [20] Look, I am standing at the door and knocking. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. [21] The one who conquers, I will give him the right to sit with me on my throne, just as I too conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne. [22] Whoever has an ear should hear what the Spirit says to the churches.

Chapter 4

[1] After this I looked, and look, a door stood open in heaven, and the first voice, which I had heard speaking with me like a trumpet, said, "Come up here, and I will show you what must take place after this." [2] At once I was in the Spirit. And look, a throne stood in heaven, and on the throne someone was seated. [3] And the one seated there looked like jasper and carnelian, and around the throne was a rainbow that looked like an emerald. [4] And around the throne were twenty-four thrones, and on the thrones sat twenty-four elders, dressed in white clothes, with golden crowns on their heads. [5] And from the throne come lightning and sounds and thunder, and seven torches of fire are burning before the throne; these are the seven spirits of God. [6] And before the throne there was something like a sea of glass, like crystal. And in the middle of the throne and around the throne were four living creatures, full of eyes in front and behind. [7] The first living creature was like a lion, the second living creature was like a young bull, the third living creature had a face

like a human being, and the fourth living creature was like a flying eagle.
8 And the four living creatures, each of them with six wings, are full of eyes
all around and within. And day and night they never rest, saying:

Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God, the Almighty,
who was and who is and who is coming.

9 And whenever the living creatures give glory and honour and thanks to the
one seated on the throne, who lives for ever and ever, 10 the twenty-four el-
ders fall down before the one seated on the throne and worship the one who
lives for ever and ever, and they cast their crowns before the throne, saying:

11 Worthy are you, our Lord and God,
to receive the glory and the honour and the power,
for you created all things,
and by your will they existed and were created.

Chapter 5

1 And I saw in the right hand of the one seated on the throne a scroll written
inside and on the back, sealed with seven seals. 2 And I saw a mighty angel
proclaiming with a loud voice, "Who is worthy to open the scroll and to break
its seals?" 3 And no one in heaven or on earth or under the earth was able to
open the scroll or to look into it. 4 And I wept and wept, because no one was
found worthy to open the scroll or to look into it. 5 And one of the elders says
to me, "Do not weep. Look, the Lion from the tribe of Judah, the Root of
David, has conquered, so that he can open the scroll and its seven seals."

6 And I saw in the middle of the throne and of the four living creatures, and in
the middle of the elders, a Lamb standing, as though slaughtered. He had
seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of God sent out into
all the earth. 7 And he came and took it out of the right hand of the one seated
on the throne. 8 And when he had taken the scroll, the four living creatures
and the twenty-four elders fell down before the Lamb, each holding a lyre
and golden bowls full of incense, which are the prayers of the saints. 9 And
they sing a new song:

Worthy are you to take the scroll
and to open its seals,

for you were slaughtered,
and by your blood you purchased people for God
from every tribe and language and people and nation,
10 and you made them a kingdom and priests to our God,
and they reign on the earth.

11 And I looked, and I heard the voice of many angels around the throne and
the living creatures and the elders, and their number was ten thousands of
ten thousands and thousands of thousands, 12 saying with a loud voice:

Worthy is the Lamb who was slaughtered
to receive the power and wealth and wisdom and strength
and honour and glory and praise.

13 And every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and on the
sea, and everything in them, I heard saying:

To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb
be the praise and the honour and the glory and the might
for ever and ever.

14 And the four living creatures said, "Amen." And the elders fell down and
worshipped.

Chapter 6

1 And I saw when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals, and I heard one of
the four living creatures say with a voice like thunder, "Come!" 2 And I
looked, and there was a white horse, and its rider had a bow; and a crown was
given to him, and he went out conquering and to conquer.

3 And when he opened the second seal, I heard the second living creature say,
"Come!" 4 And another horse came out, fiery red; and its rider was allowed to
take peace from the earth, so that people would slaughter one another; and a
great sword was given to him.

5 And when he opened the third seal, I heard the third living creature say,
"Come!" And I looked, and there was a black horse, and its rider had a pair of
scales in his hand. 6 And I heard something like a voice in the middle of the

four living creatures, saying, "A quart of wheat for a denarius, and three quarts of barley for a denarius, but do not harm the oil and the wine!"

[7] And when he opened the fourth seal, I heard the voice of the fourth living creature say, "Come!" [8] And I looked, and there was a pale green horse, and the name of its rider was Death, and Hades followed with him. And they were given authority over a fourth of the earth, to kill with sword and with famine and with pestilence and by the wild beasts of the earth.

[9] And when he opened the fifth seal, I saw under the altar the souls of those who had been slaughtered because of the word of God and because of the testimony they had. [10] And they cried out with a loud voice, "How long, holy and true Master, will you not judge and avenge our blood on those who live on the earth?" [11] And each of them was given a white robe, and they were told to rest a little longer, until their fellow servants and their brothers and sisters, who were about to be killed as they themselves had been, were complete in number.

[12] And I saw when he opened the sixth seal: there was a great earthquake, and the sun became black like sackcloth made of hair, and the whole moon became like blood, [13] and the stars of the sky fell to the earth, as a fig tree drops its unripe figs when it is shaken by a strong wind. [14] And the sky receded like a scroll being rolled up, and every mountain and island was moved from its place. [15] And the kings of the earth and the nobles and the generals and the rich and the powerful and every slave and free person hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains, [16] and they say to the mountains and the rocks, "Fall on us and hide us from the face of the one seated on the throne and from the wrath of the Lamb, [17] for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?"

Chapter 7

[1] After this I saw four angels standing at the four corners of the earth, holding back the four winds of the earth, so that no wind would blow on the earth or on the sea or on any tree. [2] And I saw another angel coming up from the rising of the sun, with the seal of the living God. And he cried out with a loud voice

to the four angels who had been allowed to harm the earth and the sea, [3] saying, "Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads."

[4] And I heard the number of those who were sealed: a hundred and forty-four thousand, sealed from every tribe of the people of Israel: [5] from the tribe of Judah twelve thousand sealed, from the tribe of Reuben twelve thousand, from the tribe of Gad twelve thousand, [6] from the tribe of Asher twelve thousand, from the tribe of Naphtali twelve thousand, from the tribe of Manasseh twelve thousand, [7] from the tribe of Simeon twelve thousand, from the tribe of Levi twelve thousand, from the tribe of Issachar twelve thousand, [8] from the tribe of Zebulun twelve thousand, from the tribe of Joseph twelve thousand, from the tribe of Benjamin twelve thousand sealed.

[9] After this I looked, and look, a great crowd that no one could count, from every nation and all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, dressed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands. [10] And they cry out with a loud voice:

To our God, who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb belongs salvation!

[11] And all the angels stood around the throne and around the elders and the four living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne and worshipped God, [12] saying:

Amen! The praise and the glory and the wisdom
and the thanksgiving and the honour and the power and the strength
be to our God for ever and ever. Amen.

[13] And one of the elders spoke up and said to me, "These who are dressed in white robes – who are they, and where have they come from?" [14] And I said to him, "My lord, you know." And he said to me: These are the ones who are coming out of the great affliction; they have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.

[15] That is why they are before the throne of God
and serve him day and night in his temple,
and the one seated on the throne will spread his tent over them.
[16] They will hunger no more and thirst no more,

and the sun will not strike them, nor any scorching heat,
17 for the Lamb in the middle of the throne will shepherd them
and lead them to springs of the water of life,
and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes.

Chapter 8

1 And when he opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about
half an hour. 2 And I saw the seven angels who stand before God, and seven
trumpets were given to them.

3 And another angel came and stood at the altar, holding a golden censer. And
much incense was given to him, so that he would put it with the prayers of all
the saints on the golden altar before the throne. 4 And the smoke of the in-
cense went up with the prayers of the saints from the hand of the angel be-
fore God. 5 And the angel took the censer and filled it with the fire of the altar
and threw it on the earth; and there were thunder and sounds and lightning
and an earthquake.

6 And the seven angels who had the seven trumpets made themselves ready to
blow the trumpet.

7 And the first blew the trumpet; and there came hail and fire, mixed with
blood, and it was thrown on the earth. And a third of the earth was burnt up,
and a third of the trees were burnt up, and all the green grass was burnt up.

8 And the second angel blew the trumpet; and something like a great moun-
tain burning with fire was thrown into the sea. And a third of the sea became
blood, 9 and a third of the creatures in the sea that had life died, and a third of
the ships were destroyed.

10 And the third angel blew the trumpet; and a great star fell from heaven,
burning like a torch, and it fell on a third of the rivers and on the springs of
water. 11 And the name of the star is called Wormwood. And a third of the wa-
ters became wormwood, and many people died from the waters, because
they had been made bitter.

12 And the fourth angel blew the trumpet; and a third of the sun was struck,
and a third of the moon and a third of the stars, so that a third of them was
darkened, and for a third of the day there was no light, and likewise for the

night.

13 And I looked, and I heard an eagle flying in midheaven, saying with a loud
voice, "Woe, woe, woe to those who live on the earth, because of the remain-
ing blasts of the trumpet of the three angels who are about to blow!"

Chapter 9

1 And the fifth angel blew the trumpet; and I saw a star that had fallen from
heaven to the earth, and the key to the shaft of the abyss was given to him.
2 And he opened the shaft of the abyss, and smoke went up from the shaft like
the smoke of a great furnace, and the sun and the air were darkened by the
smoke of the shaft. 3 And out of the smoke came locusts onto the earth, and
they were given authority like the authority that the scorpions of the earth
have. 4 And they were told not to harm the grass of the earth or any green
thing or any tree, but only the people who do not have the seal of God on
their foreheads. 5 And they were allowed not to kill them, but to torment
them for five months; and their torment was like the torment of a scorpion
when it stings a person. 6 And in those days people will seek death and will
not find it; they will long to die, and death flees from them.

7 And the shapes of the locusts were like horses prepared for war; and on
their heads was something like crowns, like gold, and their faces were like
human faces. 8 And they had hair like women's hair, and their teeth were like
lions' teeth. 9 And they had breastplates like breastplates of iron, and the
rumble of their wings was like the rumble of chariots with many horses rush-
ing into war. 10 And they have tails like scorpions, and stings, and in their
tails is their authority to harm people for five months. 11 They have as king
over them the angel of the abyss; his name in Hebrew is Abaddon, and in
Greek he has the name Apollyon.

12 The first woe has passed; look, two woes are still coming after this.

13 And the sixth angel blew the trumpet; and I heard a voice from the horns of
the golden altar that is before God, 14 saying to the sixth angel, who had the
trumpet, "Release the four angels who are bound at the great river, the
Euphrates!" 15 And the four angels were released, who had been made ready
for the hour and day and month and year, to kill a third of humankind. 16 And

the number of the mounted troops was twice ten thousands of ten thousands; I heard their number. [17] And this is how I saw the horses in the vision and those who sat on them: they had breastplates fiery red and hyacinth blue and sulphur yellow; and the heads of the horses were like lions' heads, and out of their mouths come fire and smoke and sulphur. [18] By these three plagues a third of humankind was killed, by the fire and the smoke and the sulphur that come out of their mouths. [19] For the authority of the horses is in their mouths and in their tails; for their tails are like serpents, with heads, and with them they do harm.

[20] And the rest of humankind, who were not killed by these plagues, did not even repent of the works of their hands, so as to stop worshipping the demons and the idols of gold and silver and bronze and stone and wood, which can neither see nor hear nor walk. [21] And they did not repent of their murders or of their sorceries or of their sexual immorality or of their thefts.

Chapter 10

[1] And I saw another mighty angel coming down from heaven, wrapped in a cloud, and the rainbow was over his head, and his face was like the sun, and his feet were like pillars of fire, [2] and he had in his hand a little scroll, opened. And he set his right foot on the sea and his left foot on the earth, [3] and he cried out with a loud voice, as a lion roars. And when he cried out, the seven thunders spoke with their own voices. [4] And when the seven thunders had spoken, I was about to write; and I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Seal up what the seven thunders have spoken, and do not write it down!"

[5] And the angel whom I saw standing on the sea and on the earth raised his right hand to heaven [6] and swore by the one who lives for ever and ever, who created heaven and what is in it, and the earth and what is in it, and the sea and what is in it, that there will be no more delay, [7] but that in the days of the voice of the seventh angel, when he is about to blow the trumpet, the mystery of God is fulfilled, as he announced the good news to his servants the prophets.

[8] And the voice that I had heard from heaven spoke with me again and said, "Go, take the scroll that lies open in the hand of the angel who is standing on the sea and on the earth." [9] And I went to the angel and told him to give me

the little scroll. And he says to me, "Take it and eat it up; it will make your stomach bitter, but in your mouth it will be sweet as honey." [10] And I took the little scroll from the hand of the angel and ate it up, and it was sweet as honey in my mouth; and when I had eaten it, my stomach was made bitter. [11] And they say to me, "You must prophesy again about many peoples and nations and languages and kings."

Chapter 11

[1] And a reed like a staff was given to me, and I was told, "Get up and measure the temple of God and the altar and those who worship in it. [2] But leave out the court outside the temple, and do not measure it, for it has been given to the nations, and they will trample the holy city for forty-two months. [3] And I will grant my two witnesses that they prophesy for a thousand two hundred and sixty days, clothed in sackcloth."

[4] These are the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord of the earth. [5] And if anyone wants to harm them, fire comes out of their mouth and devours their enemies; and if anyone should want to harm them, this is how he must be killed. [6] They have the authority to shut the sky, so that no rain falls during the days of their prophecy; and they have authority over the waters, to turn them into blood and to strike the earth with every plague, as often as they want.

[7] And when they have finished their testimony, the beast that comes up from the abyss will make war against them and conquer them and kill them. [8] And their corpse lies in the street of the great city, which is spiritually called Sodom and Egypt, where their Lord too was crucified. [9] And people from the peoples and tribes and languages and nations look at their corpse for three and a half days, and they do not allow their corpses to be laid in a tomb. [10] And those who live on the earth are glad over them and rejoice, and they will send gifts to one another, because these two prophets tormented those who live on the earth.

[11] And after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood on their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw them. [12] And they heard a loud voice from heaven saying to them, "Come up here!" And they went up to heaven in the cloud, and their enemies watched them. [13] And

in that hour there was a great earthquake, and a tenth of the city fell, and seven thousand people were killed in the earthquake; and the rest were terrified and gave glory to the God of heaven.

14 The second woe has passed; look, the third woe is coming soon.

15 And the seventh angel blew the trumpet; and there were loud voices in heaven, saying:

The kingdom of the world has become our Lord's and his Christ's,
and he will reign for ever and ever.

16 And the twenty-four elders who sit on their thrones before God fell on their faces and worshipped God, 17 saying:

We give you thanks, Lord God, the Almighty,
who is and who was,
because you have taken your great power
and begun to reign.
18 And the nations were angry,
and your wrath has come,
and the time for the dead to be judged,
and to give the reward to your servants the prophets
and to the saints and to those who fear your name,
the small and the great,
and to destroy those who destroy the earth.

19 And God's temple in heaven was opened, and the ark of his covenant was seen in his temple; and there were lightning and sounds and thunder and an earthquake and great hail.

Chapter 12

1 And a great sign appeared in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars. 2 And she was pregnant, and she cries out in labour and in torment to give birth.

3 And another sign appeared in heaven, and look, a great fiery red dragon, with seven heads and ten horns, and on its heads seven diadems. 4 And its tail sweeps away a third of the stars of heaven, and it threw them to the earth.

And the dragon stood before the woman who was about to give birth, so that when she gave birth it might devour her child. [5] And she gave birth to a son, a male child, who is to shepherd all the nations with an iron rod. And her child was snatched up to God and to his throne. [6] And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she has a place prepared by God, so that there she might be fed for a thousand two hundred and sixty days.

[7] And war broke out in heaven: Michael and his angels made war against the dragon. And the dragon made war, and its angels, [8] but it was not strong enough, and no place was found for them in heaven any longer. [9] And the great dragon was thrown down, the ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, who deceives the whole world – he was thrown down to the earth, and his angels were thrown down with him.

[10] And I heard a loud voice in heaven saying:

Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God
and the authority of his Christ,
for the accuser of our brothers and sisters has been thrown down,
who accuses them before our God day and night.
[11] And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb
and by the word of their testimony,
and they did not love their life even to death.
[12] Therefore rejoice, you heavens,
and you whose tent is in them!
Woe to the earth and the sea,
for the devil has come down to you
with great fury,
because he knows that he has only a little time.

[13] And when the dragon saw that it had been thrown down to the earth, it pursued the woman who had given birth to the male child. [14] And the two wings of the great eagle were given to the woman, so that she might fly into the wilderness to her place, where she is fed for a time and times and half a time, away from the face of the serpent. [15] And the serpent spewed water like a river out of its mouth after the woman, so that the river would sweep her away. [16] And the earth helped the woman, and the earth opened its mouth and swallowed the river that the dragon had spewed out of its mouth. [17] And

the dragon was angry with the woman and went off to make war against the rest of her offspring, those who keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus. [18] And it took its stand on the sand of the sea.

Chapter 13

[1] And I saw a beast coming up out of the sea, with ten horns and seven heads, and on its horns ten diadems, and on its heads names of blasphemy. [2] And the beast that I saw was like a leopard, and its feet were like a bear's, and its mouth like a lion's mouth. And the dragon gave it its power and its throne and great authority. [3] And one of its heads seemed slaughtered to death, and its death wound was healed. And the whole earth followed the beast in amazement, [4] and they worshipped the dragon, because it had given the authority to the beast, and they worshipped the beast, saying, "Who is like the beast, and who can make war against it?"

[5] And it was given a mouth speaking great things and blasphemies, and it was given authority to act for forty-two months. [6] And it opened its mouth in blasphemies against God, to blaspheme his name and his tent – those whose tent is in heaven. [7] And it was allowed to make war against the saints and to conquer them, and it was given authority over every tribe and people and language and nation. [8] And all who live on the earth will worship it – everyone whose name has not been written in the book of life of the slaughtered Lamb from the foundation of the world.

[9] If anyone has an ear, he should hear. [10] If anyone is for captivity, into captivity he goes; if anyone is to be killed with the sword, with the sword he will be killed. Here is the endurance and the faith of the saints.

[11] And I saw another beast coming up out of the earth, and it had two horns like a lamb, and it spoke like a dragon. [12] And it exercises all the authority of the first beast in its presence, and it makes the earth and those who live on it worship the first beast, whose death wound was healed. [13] And it performs great signs, so that it even makes fire come down from heaven to the earth before people. [14] And it deceives those who live on the earth by the signs that it was allowed to perform in the presence of the beast, telling those who live on the earth to make an image for the beast that has the wound of the sword and came to life. [15] And it was allowed to give breath to the image of the beast,

so that the image of the beast would even speak and would cause all who do not worship the image of the beast to be killed. [16] And it makes everyone, the small and the great, the rich and the poor, the free and the slaves, to be given a mark on their right hand or on their forehead, [17] so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark: the name of the beast or the number of its name. [18] Here is wisdom: whoever has understanding should calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a human being. And its number is six hundred and sixty-six.

Chapter 14

[1] And I looked, and there was the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion, and with him a hundred and forty-four thousand who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads. [2] And I heard a sound from heaven like the sound of many waters and like the sound of loud thunder; and the sound that I heard was like lyre players playing on their lyres. [3] And they sing something like a new song before the throne and before the four living creatures and the elders; and no one could learn the song except the hundred and forty-four thousand, who have been purchased from the earth. [4] These are the ones who have not defiled themselves with women, for they are virgins. These are the ones who follow the Lamb wherever he goes. These were purchased from among people as firstfruits for God and for the Lamb, [5] and no lie was found in their mouth; they are without blemish.

[6] And I saw another angel flying in midheaven, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who are settled on the earth and to every nation and tribe and language and people. [7] He said with a loud voice, "Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgement has come; and worship the one who made heaven and earth and sea and the springs of water!"

[8] And another, a second angel, followed, saying, "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great, who has made all the nations drink of the wine of the fury of her harlotry!"

[9] And another, a third angel, followed them, saying with a loud voice, "If anyone worships the beast and its image and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand, [10] he too will drink of the wine of the fury of God, poured undiluted into the cup of his wrath, and he will be tormented with fire and sul-

phur before holy angels and before the Lamb. [11] And the smoke of their torment goes up for ever and ever, and they have no rest day or night, those who worship the beast and its image, and whoever receives the mark of its name." [12] Here is the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and faith in Jesus.

[13] And I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Write: Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on." "Yes," says the Spirit, "so that they may rest from their toil, for their works go with them."

[14] And I looked, and there was a white cloud, and seated on the cloud was one like a son of man, with a golden crown on his head and a sharp sickle in his hand. [15] And another angel came out of the temple, crying out with a loud voice to the one seated on the cloud, "Send out your sickle and reap, for the hour to reap has come, for the harvest of the earth is dry and ripe." [16] And the one seated on the cloud swung his sickle over the earth, and the earth was reaped.

[17] And another angel came out of the temple in heaven, and he too had a sharp sickle. [18] And another angel came from the altar, the one who has authority over the fire, and he called with a loud voice to the one who had the sharp sickle, saying, "Send out your sharp sickle and gather the clusters from the vine of the earth, for its grapes are ripe." [19] And the angel swung his sickle over the earth and gathered the vintage of the vine of the earth and threw it into the great winepress of the fury of God. [20] And the winepress was trodden outside the city, and blood came out of the winepress up to the horses' bridles, for a distance of a thousand six hundred stadia.

Chapter 15

[1] And I saw another sign in heaven, great and wonderful: seven angels with seven plagues, the last ones, for with them the fury of God is completed.

[2] And I saw something like a sea of glass mixed with fire, and those who conquer the beast and its image and the number of its name, standing beside the sea of glass, holding lyres of God. [3] And they sing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb, saying:

Great and wonderful are your works,

Lord God, the Almighty;
just and true are your ways,
King of the ages.
[4] Who will not fear you, Lord,
and glorify your name?
For you alone are holy.
For all the nations will come
and worship before you,
for your righteous acts have been revealed.

[5] And after this I looked, and the temple of the tent of witness in heaven was opened, [6] and the seven angels who had the seven plagues came out of the temple, dressed in clean, shining linen, with golden sashes around their chests. [7] And one of the four living creatures gave the seven angels seven golden bowls full of the fury of God, who lives for ever and ever. [8] And the temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and from his power, and no one could enter the temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels were completed.

Chapter 16

[1] And I heard a loud voice from the temple saying to the seven angels, "Go and pour out the seven bowls of the fury of God on the earth!"

[2] And the first went and poured out his bowl on the earth; and a foul and evil sore came on the people who had the mark of the beast and who worshipped its image.

[3] And the second poured out his bowl into the sea; and it became blood like that of a dead man, and every living soul died, everything that was in the sea.

[4] And the third poured out his bowl into the rivers and the springs of water; and they became blood. [5] And I heard the angel of the waters say:

Just are you, who is and who was, the Holy One,
because you have judged these things;
[6] for they poured out the blood of saints and prophets,
and you have given them blood to drink.
They deserve it.

[7] And I heard the altar say:

Yes, Lord God, the Almighty,
true and just are your judgements.

[8] And the fourth poured out his bowl on the sun; and it was allowed to scorch people with fire. [9] And the people were scorched with fierce heat, and they blasphemed the name of God, who has authority over these plagues, and they did not repent and give him glory.

[10] And the fifth poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast; and its kingdom was plunged into darkness, and people gnawed their tongues in pain, [11] and they blasphemed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores, and they did not repent of their works.

[12] And the sixth poured out his bowl on the great river, the Euphrates; and its water was dried up, so that the way would be prepared for the kings from the rising of the sun. [13] And I saw coming out of the mouth of the dragon and out of the mouth of the beast and out of the mouth of the false prophet three unclean spirits like frogs. [14] For they are spirits of demons that perform signs, and they go out to the kings of the whole world, to gather them for the war of the great day of God, the Almighty. [15] – "Look, I am coming like a thief. Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes, so that he does not walk around naked and people see his shame." – [16] And they gathered them at the place that is called in Hebrew Armageddon.

[17] And the seventh poured out his bowl into the air; and a loud voice came out of the temple, from the throne, saying, "It is done!" [18] And there were lightning and sounds and thunder, and there was a great earthquake, such as there had never been since people were on the earth, so great an earthquake, so mighty. [19] And the great city split into three parts, and the cities of the nations fell. And God remembered Babylon the Great, to give her the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath. [20] And every island fled, and mountains were not found. [21] And great hail, each stone as heavy as a talent, comes down from heaven on the people; and the people blasphemed God because of the plague of the hail, for its plague is exceedingly great.

Chapter 17

[1] And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls came and spoke with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the judgement of the great prostitute who sits on many waters, [2] with whom the kings of the earth committed harlotry, and those who live on the earth became drunk with the wine of her harlotry." [3] And he carried me away in the Spirit into a wilderness. And I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was full of names of blasphemy and had seven heads and ten horns. [4] And the woman was dressed in purple and scarlet and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearls; she had in her hand a golden cup full of abominations and the impurities of her harlotry, [5] and on her forehead a name was written, a mystery: "Babylon the Great, the mother of prostitutes and of the abominations of the earth." [6] And I saw the woman drunk with the blood of the saints and with the blood of the witnesses to Jesus. And when I saw her, I was greatly amazed.

[7] And the angel said to me, "Why are you amazed? I will tell you the mystery of the woman and of the beast that carries her, which has the seven heads and the ten horns. [8] The beast that you saw was, and is not, and is about to come up out of the abyss and go to destruction. And those who live on the earth, whose name has not been written in the book of life from the foundation of the world, will be amazed when they see the beast, because it was and is not and will be present. [9] Here is the understanding that has wisdom: the seven heads are seven mountains on which the woman sits. They are also seven kings: [10] five have fallen, one is, the other has not yet come; and when he comes, he must remain only a little while. [11] And the beast that was and is not is itself an eighth, and it belongs to the seven, and it goes to destruction. [12] And the ten horns that you saw are ten kings who have not yet received a kingdom, but they receive authority as kings for one hour together with the beast. [13] These have one purpose, and they give their power and authority to the beast. [14] These will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings, and those with him are called and chosen and faithful." [15] And he says to me, "The waters that you saw, where the prostitute sits, are peoples and crowds and nations and languages. [16] And the ten horns that you saw, and the beast, these will hate the prostitute; they will make her devastated and naked, and they will eat her flesh and burn her up with fire. [17] For God has put it into their hearts to carry out his

purpose, to carry out one purpose, and to give their kingdom to the beast, until the words of God are fulfilled. [18] And the woman that you saw is the great city that has a kingdom over the kings of the earth."

Chapter 18

[1] After this I saw another angel coming down from heaven, who had great authority, and the earth was lit up by his glory. [2] And he cried out with a mighty voice, saying:

Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!
She has become a dwelling place of demons,
a prison of every unclean spirit,
a prison of every unclean bird,
a prison of every unclean and hated beast.
[3] For by the wine of the fury of her harlotry
all the nations have fallen,
and the kings of the earth committed harlotry with her,
and the merchants of the earth grew rich
from the power of her luxury.

[4] And I heard another voice from heaven saying:

Come out of her, my people,
so that you do not share in her sins
and do not receive any of her plagues.
[5] For her sins have piled up to heaven,
and God has remembered her crimes.
[6] Repay her as she herself has repaid,
and pay her back double for her works;
in the cup in which she mixed, mix her a double portion.
[7] As much as she glorified herself and lived in luxury,
so much torment and grief give her.
For in her heart she says:
I sit as a queen;
I am no widow,
and I will never see grief.
[8] That is why her plagues will come in a single day,

pestilence and grief and famine,
and she will be burned up with fire;
for mighty is the Lord God who has judged her.

9 And the kings of the earth who committed harlotry with her and lived in
luxury will weep and mourn over her when they see the smoke of her burn-
ing. 10 They will stand far off for fear of her torment and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
Babylon, the mighty city!
For in one hour your judgement has come.

11 And the merchants of the earth weep and grieve over her, because no one
buys their cargo any more, 12 cargo of gold and silver and precious stone and
pearls, and fine linen and purple and silk and scarlet, and all kinds of citron
wood and every article of ivory and every article of most precious wood and
bronze and iron and marble, 13 and cinnamon and spice and incense and per-
fumed oil and frankincense, and wine and olive oil and fine flour and wheat,
and cattle and sheep, and horses and carriages, and bodies – and human
souls.

14 And the fruit your soul longed for
has gone from you,
and all the luxuries and the splendour
are lost to you,
and they will never find them again.

15 The merchants of these things, who grew rich from her, will stand far off
for fear of her torment, weeping and grieving, 16 and say:

Woe, woe, the great city,
dressed in fine linen and purple and scarlet,
and adorned with gold and precious stone and pearl!
17 For in one hour such great wealth has been devastated.
And every ship's captain and everyone who sails anywhere, and sailors and
all who make their living from the sea, stood far off

[18] and cried out when they saw the smoke of her burning, saying, "Who is like
the great city?" [19] And they threw dust on their heads and cried out, weeping
and grieving, and said:

Woe, woe, the great city,
in which all who had ships on the sea
grew rich from her costly wealth!
For in one hour she has been devastated.
[20] Rejoice over her, heaven,
and you saints and apostles and prophets,
for God has judged your case against her.

[21] And a mighty angel picked up a stone like a great millstone and threw it
into the sea, saying:

So with violence Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down,
and will never be found again.
[22] And the sound of lyre players and musicians,
of flute players and trumpeters,
will never be heard in you again,
and no craftsman of any craft
will ever be found in you again,
and the sound of the mill
will never be heard in you again,
[23] and the light of a lamp
will never shine in you again,
and the voice of bridegroom and bride
will never be heard in you again.
For your merchants were the nobles of the earth,
for by your sorcery all the nations were deceived,
[24] and in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints
and of all who have been slaughtered on the earth.

Chapter 19

[1] After this I heard something like the loud voice of a great crowd in heaven,
saying:

Hallelujah!
The salvation and the glory and the power belong to our God,
2 for true and just are his judgements;
for he has judged the great prostitute
who corrupted the earth with her harlotry,
and he has avenged the blood of his servants
from her hand.

3 And a second time they said:

Hallelujah!
Her smoke goes up for ever and ever.

4 And the twenty-four elders and the four living creatures fell down and worshipped God, who sits on the throne, saying:

Amen. Hallelujah!

5 And a voice came out from the throne, saying:

Praise our God, all his servants,
and you who fear him, the small and the great!

6 And I heard something like the voice of a great crowd, and like the sound of many waters, and like the sound of mighty thunder, saying:

Hallelujah!
For the Lord God, the Almighty has begun to reign.
7 Let us rejoice and be glad,
and we will give him the glory,
for the wedding of the Lamb has come,
and his wife has made herself ready.
8 And it was given to her to clothe herself
in fine linen, shining and clean;
for the fine linen is the righteous acts of the saints.

9 And he says to me, "Write: Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." And he says to me, "These are the true words of God."
10 And I fell down at his feet to worship him. And he says to me, "Do not do

that! I am a fellow servant with you and with your brothers and sisters who hold to the testimony of Jesus. Worship God! For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy."

[11] And I saw heaven opened, and there was a white horse, and its rider is called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war. [12] His eyes are a flame of fire, and on his head are many diadems, and he has a name written that no one knows except himself. [13] And he is dressed in a robe dipped in blood, and his name is called The Word of God. [14] And the armies that are in heaven followed him on white horses, dressed in fine linen, white and clean. [15] And out of his mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations, and he will shepherd them with an iron rod; and he treads the winepress of the wine of the fury of the wrath of God, the Almighty. [16] And on his robe and on his thigh he has a name written: King of kings and Lord of lords.

[17] And I saw an angel standing in the sun, and he cried out with a loud voice, saying to all the birds that fly in midheaven, "Come, gather for the great supper of God, [18] to eat the flesh of kings and the flesh of generals and the flesh of the powerful and the flesh of horses and their riders, and the flesh of all, free and slave, small and great." [19] And I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered to make war on the rider of the horse and on his army. [20] And the beast was captured, and with it the false prophet who had performed the signs before it, by which he deceived those who had received the mark of the beast and those who worshipped its image. The two of them were thrown alive into the lake of fire that burns with sulphur. [21] And the rest were killed with the sword of the rider of the horse, the sword that came out of his mouth, and all the birds gorged themselves on their flesh.

Chapter 20

[1] And I saw an angel coming down from heaven, holding in his hand the key of the abyss and a great chain. [2] And he seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years, [3] and threw him into the abyss and locked it and sealed it over him, so that he would deceive the nations no more until the thousand years were completed. After that he must be released for a short time.

[4] And I saw thrones, and they sat on them, and judgement was given to them. And I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God, and who had not worshipped the beast or its image and had not received the mark on their foreheads or on their hands. And they lived and reigned with Christ for a thousand years. [5] The rest of the dead did not live until the thousand years were completed. This is the first resurrection. [6] Blessed and holy is the one who has a share in the first resurrection. Over these the second death has no authority, but they will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with him for a thousand years.

[7] And when the thousand years are completed, Satan will be released from his prison [8] and will go out to deceive the nations at the four corners of the earth, Gog and Magog, to gather them for the war; their number is like the sand of the sea. [9] And they went up across the breadth of the earth and surrounded the camp of the saints and the beloved city. And fire came down from heaven and consumed them. [10] And the devil, who deceived them, was thrown into the lake of fire and sulphur, where the beast and the false prophet are as well, and they will be tormented day and night for ever and ever.

[11] And I saw a great white throne and the one seated on it. Earth and heaven fled from his face, and no place was found for them. [12] And I saw the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne, and books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the book of life. And the dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to their works. [13] And the sea gave up the dead who were in it, and death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them, and they were judged, each one according to their works. [14] And death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire. [15] And if anyone was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire.

Chapter 21

[1] And I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea is no more. [2] And I saw the holy city, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared like a bride adorned for her husband. [3] And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying:

Look, God's tent is with people,
and he will spread his tent with them,
and they will be his peoples,
and God himself will be with them,
4 and he will wipe away every tear from their eyes,
and death will be no more,
nor grief nor crying nor pain will be any more.
The former things have passed away.

5 And the one seated on the throne said, "Look, I am making all things new." And he says, "Write, for these words are faithful and true." 6 And he said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life as a gift. 7 The one who conquers will inherit these things, and I will be his God, and he will be my son. 8 But for the cowardly and the faithless and the abominable and murderers and the sexually immoral and sorcerers and idolaters and all liars, their share will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulphur, which is the second death."

9 And one of the seven angels who had the seven bowls full of the seven last plagues came and spoke with me, saying, "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb." 10 And he carried me away in the Spirit to a great, high mountain and showed me the holy city Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from God, 11 having the glory of God. Its radiance was like a most precious stone, like a jasper, clear as crystal. 12 It had a great, high wall with twelve gates, and at the gates twelve angels, and names written on them, which are the names of the twelve tribes of the people of Israel: 13 on the east three gates, and on the north three gates, and on the south three gates, and on the west three gates. 14 And the wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb.

15 And the one who spoke with me had a gold measuring reed to measure the city and its gates and its wall. 16 And the city lies foursquare; its length is as great as its width. And he measured the city with the reed: twelve thousand stadia. Its length and width and height are equal. 17 And he measured its wall: a hundred and forty-four cubits, by human measure, which is also an angel's measure. 18 And the wall was built of jasper, and the city was pure gold, like

clear glass. [19] The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with every kind of precious stone: the first foundation was jasper, the second sapphire, the third chalcedony, the fourth emerald, [20] the fifth sardonyx, the sixth carnelian, the seventh chrysolite, the eighth beryl, the ninth topaz, the tenth chrysoprase, the eleventh jacinth, the twelfth amethyst. [21] And the twelve gates were twelve pearls; each of the gates was made of a single pearl. And the street of the city was pure gold, like transparent glass.

[22] And I saw no temple in it, for its temple is the Lord God, the Almighty, and the Lamb. [23] And the city has no need of the sun or of the moon to shine on it, for the glory of God has given it light, and its lamp is the Lamb. [24] And the nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the earth bring their glory into it. [25] And its gates will never be shut by day, for there will be no night there. [26] And they will bring the glory and the honour of the nations into it. [27] But nothing unclean will ever enter it, nor anyone who practises abomination and lies, but only those who are written in the book of life of the Lamb.

Chapter 22

[1] And he showed me a river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing out from the throne of God and of the Lamb [2] through the middle of the city's street. And on either side of the river was the tree of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month; and the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations. [3] And there will no longer be any curse. And the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will serve him, [4] and they will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. [5] And there will be no more night, and they have no need of the light of a lamp or the light of the sun, for the Lord God will shine on them, and they will reign for ever and ever.

[6] And he said to me, "These words are faithful and true. And the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take place. [7] And look, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book."

[8] And I, John, am the one who heard and saw these things. And when I heard and saw them, I fell down to worship at the feet of the angel who showed them to me. [9] And he says to me, "Do not do that! I am a fellow servant with

you and with your brothers and sisters the prophets, and with those who keep the words of this book. Worship God!"

10 And he says to me, "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, for the time is near. 11 Let the one who does wrong still do wrong, and the filthy still be filthy, and the righteous still do what is right, and the holy still be holy. 12 Look, I am coming soon, and my reward is with me, to repay each one according to what he has done. 13 I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the beginning and the end. 14 Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life and may go through the gates into the city. 15 Outside are the dogs and the sorcerers and the sexually immoral and the murderers and the idolaters, and everyone who loves and practises lies. 16 I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify to you about these things for the churches. I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star."

17 And the Spirit and the bride say, "Come!" And let the one who hears say, "Come!" And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes take the water of life as a gift.

18 I testify to everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: if anyone adds to them, God will add to him the plagues that are written in this book. 19 And if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are written about in this book.

20 The one who testifies to these things says, "Yes, I am coming soon." Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!

21 The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all.